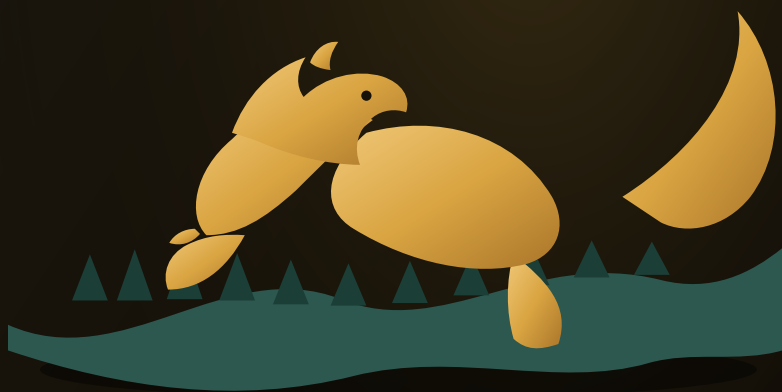


A NOVEL OF CRIME & NYĀYA

MONGOOSE

AMONG THE MONITOR LIZARDS

Nyāya Philosophy and a Modern Crime Saga



GAJENDRA THAKUR

translated from the Maithili by the author himself

VIDEHA

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AUTHOR'S NOTE

This is an original work of fiction. Crime, justice, social fear, financial networks, digital fraud, and human tragedy are imaginatively rendered here in literary form. All private individuals, private institutions, criminal groups, businesses, sequences of events, and dialogues are fictional. Any resemblance to a real person or private institution should be understood as coincidental. References to real public institutions occur only in a general legal and social context. This work is written not to teach the methods of crime, but to understand crime's human consequences and the questions it raises for justice and moral discernment.

It had not rained in Garh Narikel that night, yet the earth was wet. During the day, a thin spill of the Kamala-Balan had risen as far as the edge of the fields; by evening it had withdrawn, leaving behind in the courtyard only a slick, intimate smell—the smell of raw earth, crushed grass, and old water.

Everyone in the house was asleep. Outside, beside the little tulsi altar, an earthen lamp was half extinguished and half burning. Whenever the flame trembled in the wind, the shadow of a leaf moved across the unplastered wall—as though some small creature were silently slipping past.

Dhaneshwari Devi slept lightly. Age had weakened her hearing, but even now she could hear the unnatural silences of the night. She turned on her side. At the other end of the room her daughter-in-law, Mrinalini, slept with her seven-year-old son Ishaan folded into her arms. The child's mouth was open; his breathing was steady.

Then something black gleamed beneath the door.

At first Dhaneshwari thought it was a lizard. Then the gleam lifted from the floor, gathered itself, and for a moment widened like a hood.

A cobra.

No sound came from her throat. Her body awakened; her voice did not. She reached for her staff, but there was too much distance between the staff and the snake. The cobra moved along the wall, gliding toward the child's pillow.

Mrinalini was still asleep. One of Ishaan's feet lay outside the sheet.

No mantra came to Dhaneshwari's mind, no divine name. Only one thought: if she screamed, her daughter-in-law would start awake, the child would move, and the snake would strike. If she remained silent, the snake would reach him.

How much of a life can be contained between two moments—Dhaneshwari would never afterward be able to understand.

Just then there was a rustle outside the door.

A slender grey-brown body shot inside like a living bolt of lightning.

A mongoose.

The cobra's hood rose to its full height in a single motion. The snake that, only moments before, had been gliding through the sleeping house like its master suddenly drew back. The mongoose did not stop. Its body sprang a handspan above the floor and dropped again. A hiss. A crack. A furious scuffle. Mrinalini woke with a start. Ishaan began to cry. At last Dhaneshwari found her voice—"Don't move!"

The fight did not last long. To human fear it was endless; to a clock, only a few moments. The cobra recoiled toward the wall, then fled into the open

courtyard. The mongoose went after it. Beside the tulsi altar came another hiss, and then silence.

At dawn the men searched with torches. The snake was found dead beside the bamboo grove behind the house. The mongoose was nowhere to be seen.

That day, stroking Ishaan's head, Dhaneshwari repeated an old saying: "A cobra changes its path the moment it catches the scent of a mongoose; even the monitor lizard changes waters when it sees the mongoose running along the bank. That is what our elders said—not science. But understand what it means. Whoever keeps others safe must remain awake."

Ishaan kept insisting that he wanted to see the snake. Mrinalini kept refusing. At last Dhaneshwari took him as far as the courtyard, but not to the dead snake. She showed him only four small mongoose tracks in the earth.

"Remember this," she said. "When a snake can be seen, people are afraid. When a monitor lizard lives in the water, people become afraid too late. A mongoose is small, but standing guard is its work."

Ishaan stared at the tracks for a long time. He did not yet understand that, years later, the creature in his family's story would not be a snake but a monitor lizard—and that the mongoose would once again, for a long while, remain only a set of tracks.



Eight years later, Garh Narikel had changed.

The Kamala-Balan was the same—fierce in the monsoon, contracted in winter, a thin glittering current across the sand in summer—but the world along its banks had changed. A paved road had arrived. A mobile tower could be seen from far away. An ATM had opened near the old market. Bright lists of government schemes were pasted on the wall of the panchayat building. People said, "Now look at development."

And development was visible. A new embankment had been sanctioned along the river's western bank. The road joining two districts was to be widened. Three culverts, one small bridge, seven kilometres of embankment repair, a new school building, and a separate contract for stone supply. On paper, every job was distinct; in practice, money was like the branches of the same river—appearing separate, only to meet one another in the end.

Satyaprakash Karna saw this new opportunity as a turning point in his life.

He was not a major contractor. Even the name of his company was modest: Kamala Construction Service. Two old trucks, one rented mixer, twenty or twenty-five permanent labourers, and the rest hired as needed. For years he had supported his family by taking subcontracts under larger

contractors. Sometimes payment arrived on time, sometimes six months later. Many times the work was complete and only half the money had come.

Mrinalini would say, "Take work in your own name. Why stand at someone else's door?"

Satyaprakash would laugh. "To get work in your own name, you need more than a name."

"What?"

"The very thing I have too little of."

"Money?"

"Money is short, yes. But before money comes access."

This time the system had moved toward online tendering. There was less crowding to submit papers, and the grip of middlemen at the office gate was a little weaker. Satyaprakash prepared for three months. Bank guarantees. Experience certificates. Machinery details. Tax papers. Rate calculations. Night after night Ishaan sat beside his father's laptop, watching the numbers.

"Do you understand any of this?" Satyaprakash would ask.

"No."

"Then why are you watching?"

"Because you are."

Satyaprakash laughed. "The worst reason of all."

Ishaan was fifteen now. He had begun to grow tall, though the same childhood curiosity remained in his eyes. He remembered the night of the snake and the mongoose only vaguely—not as a scene, but as a family story. Whenever anyone saw a mongoose near the house, Dhaneshwari would immediately say, "Our sentry has come."

When the tender results were announced, Satyaprakash's company emerged as the lowest valid bidder for two sections of the embankment. The work was not large enough to put his name in the newspapers; for him, however, it was the biggest contract of his life.

That evening rasgullas came home. Dhaneshwari placed one before God. Mrinalini sat down to make a list of expenses. Ishaan asked, "Will we get a new roof on the house now?"

Satyaprakash replied, "First the embankment. The house afterward."

Three days later, the first call came.

The number was unknown. The voice was courteous.

"Congratulations, Karna-ji."

"Thank you. Who is this?"

"The name is not important. The work is. You are new. You will have to understand the rules."

Satyaprakash said nothing.

“Six percent of the total payment is the share for those above. Two percent in advance. The rest as the bills are cleared.”

Satyaprakash thought someone was playing a joke. “Whose share?”

A soft laugh at the other end. “That question is not asked.”

“I will not pay anyone a share.”

The laughter stopped. The voice remained courteous. “You have not understood. This is not a bribe. This is the system.”

“My system is written in the tender document.”

The call ended.

Mrinalini asked, “Who was it?”

Satyaprakash said, “Wrong number.”

He did not sleep for a long time that night.



Work began the following week.

Earth was cut from the embankment. Crews of labourers arrived. Trucks brought sand, aggregate, and soil. The department’s junior engineer took measurements. Dust and grit all day, exhaustion at night. Satyaprakash continued to perform the role of a happy man.

The second call came from a different number. This time, the voice was different too.

“The two percent has not been deposited.”

“I have already given my answer.”

“Then your materials may be stopped.”

“Why?”

“There are many ways.”

Three days later his first load of stone aggregate was stopped near the police-station boundary. Papers were checked. Weight was checked. The mining transit permit was checked. Everything was valid. The truck was released two hours later. The next day the transport department stopped another truck. On the third day the local labour crew suddenly demanded twice the wages and walked off the job.

Satyaprakash wanted to see each incident separately. Mrinalini saw a single thread running through them all.

“Everything began after the calls.”

“It could be coincidence.”

“Three times?”

“Three coincidences can happen too.”

Mrinalini paused. “And a fourth?”

Satyaprakash did not answer.

The fourth time, a letter came from the department: discrepancy in the soil-density test; suspend work temporarily. Satyaprakash had the sample tested again by a private laboratory. The result was satisfactory. Whether the department's paperwork was wrong or the sample had been changed, nothing was clear.

After that he began writing down the numbers from which the calls came. Date, time, voice, and whatever happened after each call. A small black diary.

One day Ishaan saw it.

"Babu, what is that?"

Satyaprakash closed the diary. "An account of the work."

"Expenses?"

"No. An account of the expenses that do not show."

Ishaan laughed. "Invisible expenses?"

Satyaprakash looked at him for a moment. "Yes. Sometimes the greatest expense is invisible."



In the Public Works Department in the capital, Assistant Accounts Officer Mayank Jha had never known Satyaprakash. Dozens of files reached his desk every day. Contractors' bills, security deposits, price escalation, extensions of time, penalties, revised estimates. In files, people disappeared; numbers moved.

Mayank had a habit of noticing abnormal repetition. One day he found something peculiar. Different districts, different contractors, different departmental divisions—and yet, before the security deposits were released, the files all contained a "quality verification" from the same private consultancy. Its name was "Pravahi Consultancy Private Limited."

Mayank wrote down the name.

Two days later Satyaprakash's withheld bill arrived. The file contained a note as well: "Local coordination pending." No technical condition called "local coordination" existed in the official format. Mayank circled the words in red pencil.

His colleague Arun laughed. "Don't read so much. If a word doesn't make sense, leave it alone."

Mayank asked, "What does 'local coordination' mean?"

"What everyone understands is never written in the file."

"And what is written in the file?"

"You don't need to understand that."

Mayank did not smile. His father had taught Nyāya philosophy. From childhood he had heard one sentence again and again: “Doubt is not a fault; failing to inquire after doubt arises is the fault.” Mayank was no philosopher, but the sentence had stayed with him.

He did not copy Satyaprakash’s file; he merely noted its number. Then he began searching old payments involving a company called Pravahi Consultancy.

In three years the company had received very few government contracts. Yet its certificates appeared in the files of dozens of contractors. The company itself was not making money from the government; presumably, it was making money from contractors.

“Why?” Mayank asked himself.

The question was not evidence yet. Only smoke. Smoke may permit an inference of fire; but not every haze comes from fire—it may also be dust.

He closed the file.



Satyaprakash’s fifth call came in the evening as he was returning home from the embankment site.

“There’s still time.”

“Who are you people?”

“The people who make the work move.”

“The government makes the work move.”

“On paper.”

Satyaprakash stopped the vehicle. Ahead lay a small bridge over a narrow branch of the Kamala-Balan. The sun was setting. In the water, the truck’s shadow stretched long.

“I’ll go to the police.”

For the first time there was no laughter at the other end. “Go.”

One word. Complete unconcern.

Satyaprakash’s hand went cold. More frightening than the threat was that untroubled “Go.” A criminal who does not fear the word police either has someone inside the police or possesses limitless faith in his own reach. Both possibilities were bad.

When he reached home, he showed Mrinalini the diary. Not all of it, only a few pages.

“If anything happens to me...”

Mrinalini flared. “Don’t say that again.”

“Listen.”

“No.”

“Mrinal.”

His voice changed. Mrinalini fell silent.

“Don’t give this diary to Ishaan. If any policeman comes, ask his name first. Not the police station—take it straight to the office of the District Superintendent of Police. And give one copy to an officer named Mayank Jha—in the Public Works Accounts Branch in the capital.”

“Who is this Mayank?”

“I don’t know him. I saw his note on the file. At least someone asked a question.”

Holding back tears, Mrinalini said, “Give up the contract.”

Satyaprakash remained silent for a long time. “If I withdraw, the next man will pay the six percent. Then the next. Then it becomes a rule.”

“It has already become a rule.”

“Then at least one person has to say that it isn’t a rule.”

“And why does that person have to be you?”

Satyaprakash had no answer to that question. Human beings often construct the arguments for their moral decisions afterwards; first, something within them simply accepts a certain course as necessary.

He took Mrinalini’s hand. “I’ll be careful.”

There was a rustle in the grass outside the door. Both fell silent for a moment.

A mongoose darted across the courtyard—a slender body, raised tail, a flash and gone.

Without meaning to, Mrinalini remembered Dhaneshwari’s old words: every night demands a new watch.

She did not sleep that night.



Two weeks later, Satyaprakash was dead.

At first the news called it a “road accident.”

At about four in the morning, eight kilometres short of the district boundary, his SUV was found after a collision with a heavy truck loaded with stone. The road was straight. The weather was clear. His driver, Raghunath, had also died at the scene. The truck driver was missing. The vehicle leaned half into a ditch on the left side of the road.

The police’s first assumption: an accident while overtaking.

When Mrinalini arrived—not at the hospital but at the mortuary—she said only one sentence: “This was not an accident.”

Someone tried to console her. She repeated, “This was not an accident.”

Dhaneshwari had kept Ishaan at home. But a fifteen-year-old boy was no longer a child. He reached the town on a neighbour's motorcycle. The moment he saw his father's face beneath the white cloth, what people call "weeping" did not emerge from inside him. No sound came. His body merely trembled.

Mrinalini embraced him.

"Babu will be careful," Ishaan whispered.

At those words Mrinalini broke for the first time.

Being careful belonged to the future tense. Before a dead body, the future tense is the cruellest grammar of all.



District Superintendent of Police Aniruddh Chaudhary did not ordinarily visit accident scenes. Such matters belonged at police-station level. But on the day of Satyaprakash's death, calls came from three directions—the Chamber of Commerce, the contractors' association, and the Public Works Department. One person said, "He was a very honest man." Another, "The contract was controversial." Another, "The family is calling it murder."

Aniruddh went to the scene that evening.

On one side of the road the police had marked the ground with chalk. The truck had been taken to the station. The SUV had been hauled out by crane. The place was almost empty.

The station house officer described the incident. "Sir, the truck came from the opposite direction. Probably an overtaking manoeuvre. Night, speed..."

Aniruddh interrupted. "Night or dawn?"

"Dawn, sir."

"Road lighting?"

"No."

"Fog?"

"No."

"Brake marks?"

The officer hesitated. "Not very clear."

Aniruddh bent and examined the road. Scrapes on the asphalt. The tracks of a heavy vehicle in the earth on one side. He was no expert; reaching instant conclusions was not his habit.

"Which lane was the car in?"

"Everything got disturbed after the collision, sir."

"The truck driver?"

"Absconding."

“The owner?”

“A local transport company. We’ve called for the papers.”

Aniruddh looked towards the fields in the distance. The sun was setting.

“Is an accident possible?” he asked.

“Yes.”

“Is murder possible?”

The station house officer fell silent. “The family alleges it.”

“I didn’t ask about an allegation. I asked about the possibility.”

“Yes... possible.”

Aniruddh straightened. “Then what do we know at this moment?”

The officer was about to answer. Aniruddh answered for him. “We know that two men are dead. Two vehicles collided. One driver is missing. Everything else is inference.”

After a few moments he added, “We must understand the limits of direct perception. If we form the conclusion first, every fact that comes afterwards will be made to serve that conclusion.”

The station house officer had probably not expected a philosophical proposition.

Aniruddh said, “Do not investigate on the assumption that it was an accident. Do not investigate on the assumption that it was murder either. Keep both possibilities open.”

At that moment a constable came running. “Sir, we may be able to get the night’s footage from the nearby toll plaza.”

Aniruddh said only, “Get it.”



That night Mrinalini opened Satyaprakash’s cupboard.

The black diary was gone.

She searched every drawer. Files. Bank papers. Insurance. Old receipts. No diary.

Her hands began to tremble. Ishaan stood in the doorway.

“What are you looking for?”

“Nothing.”

“Babu’s accounts diary?”

Mrinalini turned. “How do you know about it?”

“I’d seen it.”

“Where?”

“He said it was an account of invisible expenses.”

Mrinalini sat down on the bed.

“Did anyone come into the house after his death?”

“Lots of people.”

“Anyone in this room?”

Ishaan thought. “Two people from the contractors’ association. Babu’s office clerk. A man from the department. Two policemen. Uncle...”

The list kept growing. Every familiar person became, suddenly, a possible hand.

Mrinalini’s first thought was to call Aniruddh at once; then she remembered Satyaprakash’s words—“Ask the name first.”

She found the public number of the district police office. It was very late. The duty officer answered.

“I want to speak to Superintendent of Police Aniruddh Chaudhary. I am Satyaprakash Karna’s wife.”

Ten minutes later Aniruddh himself was on the line.

“Tell me.”

“A diary is missing.”

“Since when?”

“I discovered it today.”

“What was in it?”

“A record of threatening calls.”

There was silence at the other end for a few moments.

“Who knew about this diary?”

Mrinalini looked at Ishaan. “I did. My husband. Perhaps my son. And...”

She remembered Mayank Jha’s name.

“An accounts officer. In the capital. Mayank Jha.”

Aniruddh wrote it down. “Don’t touch any papers in the house now. I’ll send a team in the morning. And one thing—the disappearance of the diary does not prove murder. But it certainly weakens the accident hypothesis.”

Mrinalini said, “I don’t want a hypothesis. I want the truth.”

Aniruddh’s voice was very calm. “To reach the truth, an inference has to survive the test of evidence. We will try.”

The call ended.

Ishaan asked, “Did he believe us?”

“I don’t know.”

“Then?”

Mrinalini looked at the empty cupboard. “Perhaps, for now, the fact that he asked a question matters more than whether he believed us.”



In the capital, Mayank Jha was alone in his office that night.

His search into “Pravahi Consultancy” had turned out stranger than expected. The company’s registered office was in a small commercial complex. Its directors were two young men—one an insurance agent, the other a consultant on paper. The company’s bank details were not in the government files, but the receipts attached by contractors had one feature in common: the amount paid hovered around a fixed percentage of the total contract value.

In his notebook Mayank wrote only the ratios: 1.98. 2.02. 1.96. 2.01.

Two percent.

He leaned back in his chair.

It might be coincidence. It might be a fee. It might be a standard industry rate. Or—it might be something else.

Then his mobile rang. Unknown number.

“Mayank Jha?”

“Yes.”

“Did you know Satyaprakash Karna?”

“No. Only the name from a file.”

“He’s dead.”

Mayank sat upright. “Who?”

“Road accident. Read the newspaper.”

“Who are you?”

The call ended.

Mayank searched the news at once. A photograph opened on the screen—a crushed vehicle, police, a crowd, and the headline: “Contractor Dies in Road Accident.”

He stared at the screen. Then he looked at the numbers on his paper: 1.98, 2.02, 1.96.

Until then they had been numbers. Now a dead man’s name stood beside them.

His father, who taught Nyāya philosophy, used to say, “Inference is born of trust in invariable concomitance; but an incautious mind sees one event and invents a universal relation.”

Mayank checked himself. No connection between Satyaprakash’s death and the two percent had yet been established. The caller’s identity was unknown.

Even so, for the first time, he was afraid.

He decided not to leave the Pravahi Consultancy papers in the office. He made no copies; he simply put his notebook into his bag.

The corridor was empty when he left. In the glass of the lift he saw his own face. An ordinary government employee. Not police. Not a journalist. Not a contractor.

“Why me?” his mind asked.

Another part of his mind answered, “Because you saw it.”

The criminal fears being seen. Often the fear of the one who has seen is greater still.



At dawn the mongoose returned to Satyaprakash's courtyard.

Dhaneshwari saw it first. It stood near the tulsi altar, nose raised, smelling the air. Because of the mourning, the hearth had barely been lit for three days. People came, wept, sat in silence, and went away.

The mongoose neither threatened anyone nor showed fear nor came inside. It merely circled the threshold and stopped beside the window of the room where Satyaprakash's cupboard stood.

The moment Ishaan saw it, he came outside.

“Grandmother, is it the same one?”

Dhaneshwari said, “All mongooses look alike. Whether it is the same one or its offspring—who can know?”

Ishaan crouched on his knees. The mongoose looked at him, then suddenly darted towards the bushes behind the house. A few crows flew up from there.

“Is there a snake?” Ishaan asked.

After a long pause Dhaneshwari replied, “This time the snake cannot be seen.”

Ishaan's face hardened. “Then what does the mongoose do?”

“Keep watch.”

“Over what?”

Dhaneshwari's eyes burned, but her voice remained steady. “Over what is still alive.”

Ishaan could not tell whether his grandmother meant him, his mother, the house, or the truth.

Far away the waters of the Kamala-Balan lay silent. Small mongoose tracks marked the bank. And beneath the water, beyond the reach of the eye, some heavy body might have been changing its place.



Three things reached Aniruddh Chaudhary's desk together.

First—the flickering footage from the toll plaza. Satyaprakash's vehicle passed at 3:41 a.m. Seven minutes later came the same stone-laden truck. Its number plate was half covered in mud.

Second—Mrinalini's statement: threats, percentages, the missing diary.

Third—an email from Mayank Jha in the capital, containing only this: "I believe attention should be given to the expression 'local coordination' in Satyaprakash Karna's file and to the payment pattern of a private consultancy. I would prefer to deliver the detailed papers in person."

Aniruddh laid the three items apart from one another.

Assistant Inspector Rohit asked, "Sir, do we call it murder now?"

"No."

"Even after all this?"

Aniruddh looked towards the window. "Three indications point in one direction. But a direction and a destination are not the same thing."

"Then?"

"Join the facts. The owner of the truck. The driver. Call records. The contract dispute. The consultancy. Satyaprakash's office. Whoever removed that diary may not have understood that a man's memory does not live in a single diary."

Rohit said, "The family says he was planning to go to the police."

"Words can become evidence, but only after the reliability of the statement is tested. The family is grieving. We will respect that grief, but the investigation will not be conducted according to it."

"Sir, you drag Nyāya philosophy into everything."

Aniruddh smiled faintly. "No. Crime drags it in by itself. The gravest disease in policing is to decide first who the criminal is and only then go looking for proof. Nyāya says: first understand the nature of the evidence; then judge."

He played the toll footage again. The truck crossed the screen in darkness.

"Find this truck."

"The owner's details have come in—'Sarita Logistics.'"

"Director?"

Rohit checked the paper. "Kaushal Mahto."

Aniruddh wrote down the name.

"The directors of Pravahi Consultancy?"

"I've asked for them."

The phone rang. Control room. A burnt vehicle had been found near an abandoned warehouse on the outskirts of the town. The number plates had

been removed. Preliminary information suggested that the mobile phone of the driver from Satyaprakash's accident had last been active in that area.

Aniruddh stood up.

"Let's go."

Rohit gathered the file.

At the door Aniruddh turned back once more. Satyaprakash's photograph lay on the desk—an ordinary face cropped from a government identity card.

A criminal investigation often begins with the dead person; slowly one discovers that the dead person was not the centre at all, merely the first visible circle.

Aniruddh did not yet know that Satyaprakash's death was not merely a dispute over six percent. Nor that Mayank's two-per-cent figures were the outermost thread of a much larger web. Nor that, years later, some of the money flowing through that web would leave guns, trucks, and tenders behind and enter the invisible world of screens, games, digital accounts, and gambling.

For now, there was only one truck to find.

And in Garh Narikel a mongoose moved along the threshold, sniffing the air.

The cruellest property of tragedy is that by the time a human being understands the first sign, the story has already travelled far ahead.



The abandoned warehouse stood on the outskirts of the town, but "abandoned" was true only on paper.

Dawn was brightening when Aniruddh Chaudhary's vehicle entered through the broken gate. There was little grass in the yard and many tyre tracks. On one side stood the black skeleton of a burnt vehicle. On the other lay empty drums, torn tarpaulins, and a heap of bricks.

Rohit said, "For people who do nothing here, why would they need so much...?"

Aniruddh did not answer at once.

Beside the burnt vehicle, fire-service personnel were sifting through ash. The number plate had been removed. Some parts of the engine were still identifiable, but the paint had been obliterated.

"Is this the truck that hit Satyaprakash's car?" Rohit asked.

The vehicle examiner shook his head. "Too early to say. The dimensions match. Some parts do too. But first we have to connect the identification numbers, ownership papers, repair records—everything."

Aniruddh did not smile, but he looked once at Rohit.

Rohit understood—the same lesson again.

Direct perception is one thing.

Inference another.

Judgment comes much later.

Inside the warehouse the floor smelled of burnt rubber. In one corner stood a small stove for making tea, two glasses, and a half-full tin of sugar. If someone had set a vehicle ablaze in the night and fled, had he really had time to drink tea?

On one wall, half of the word “Sarita” could still be seen in blue paint.

Rohit brightened. “Sarita Logistics.”

“A name on a wall is not proof of ownership,” Aniruddh said. “The paint left by an old tenant can survive for years.”

At the back of the warehouse they found a torn register. Rain had eaten into the pages. Some dates, some vehicle numbers, some entries reduced to initials.

On one page was written “K. M.”

Rohit said again, “Kaushal Mahto.”

This time Aniruddh gave him a hard look.

“Are you looking for the criminal, or for confirmation of your own inference?”

Rohit said nothing.

Aniruddh had the register placed in an evidence bag.

The first enemy of an investigation is not the criminal.

Often its first enemy is the pleasure that rises in the mind at the first apparent match: “Got him.”



Kaushal Mahto reached the police station by noon.

He was around fifty. His face was burnt dark by the sun; deep fatigue lay beneath his eyes. On entering, he did not begin by protesting his innocence. First he asked for water.

Then he said, “Sarita Logistics is mine. But that truck is not.”

Rohit placed the papers on the table. “The registration is in your company’s name.”

“I sold it six months ago.”

“Transfer of ownership?”

Kaushal lowered his eyes. “It wasn’t completed.”

“Whom did you sell it to?”

“Through a broker from Durga Freight. Name—Kanhaiya Rajak. He said all the papers could be done later.”

Rohit laughed. “Papers later. Vehicle first. Excellent.”

Kaushal bristled, but Aniruddh raised a hand and stopped him.

“Why did you sell the truck?”

“Debt.”

“Do you know Pravahi Consultancy?”

Kaushal’s face did not change. “I’ve heard the name.”

“Where?”

“Among contractors. People say they advise you on everything if you want government work.”

“Have you paid them?”

Kaushal was silent for a moment.

This time Aniruddh noted the silence.

“I’ll ask again. Have you paid them?”

Kaushal said softly, “Twice.”

“What did they do?”

“Looked over the papers. Advised me on filing the tender.”

“A written report?”

“I don’t remember.”

“How much, both times?”

Kaushal glanced at Rohit, then at the door.

“Why is the amount important?”

“Because if it was a legitimate fee, that is one thing. If it was payment under pressure, that is another.”

Kaushal’s lips went dry.

“No one pressured me.”

Aniruddh changed the question. “Did you know Satyaprakash Karna?”

“I knew him.”

“A friend?”

“A competitor.”

“An enemy?”

“No.”

“What did you think when he died?”

Kaushal had not been prepared for that question. He shifted in his chair.

“An accident.”

“Why that answer?”

“I read it in the newspaper.”

Aniruddh closed his notebook.

“All right.”

Rohit looked surprised. "That's all?"

"For now."

As he was leaving, Kaushal stopped at the doorway. He did not turn around. He merely said—

"Sir, in contracting you don't have to kill a man to make an enemy. Stop his payment and his house will collapse by itself."

Aniruddh let him go.

The sentence was not a threat.

But it contained the kind of experience that never appears on paper.



Mayank Jha arrived from the capital on the evening bus.

The department provided cars for government officers, but he had not asked for one. He felt that the fewer people who knew what he was carrying, the better.

There was no thick file in his bag.

Only a thin notebook.

The two-percent figures.

A few company names.

A few dates.

And one question.

Aniruddh met him in the dining room of the circuit house. Half the lights were off. An old fan turned in one corner. Dogs barked outside.

Mayank opened the notebook.

"I examined the tender papers available for the past three years. Not every contractor made these payments. But in works concentrated in one particular geographical belt, the 'consultancy' expense is unusually uniform."

Aniruddh asked, "Uniform in what sense?"

"About two percent of the total value."

"Could that be an ordinary professional fee?"

"Yes."

Mayank answered at once.

Rohit was surprised.

Mayank continued, "Which is why I am not calling it a crime yet. The problem is elsewhere. Different contractors, different works, different kinds of advice—but the reports are almost identical."

He took out three papers.

One concerned geotechnical advice for a bridge.

Another, procurement management for a school building.

The third, work coordination for road repairs.

The language of all three ought to have been different.

Yet the four concluding lines were almost the same.

Aniruddh read them.

“What does this prove?”

“For now, only that the consultancy may not correspond to the actual work performed.”

“And then?”

“After the two percent, another payment appears repeatedly—‘local support’, ‘regional facilitation’, ‘public relations’. Different names. Taken together, the amounts usually come to around six percent.”

Rohit leaned forward in his chair.

Six percent.

Satyaprakash’s wife had also spoken of six percent.

Aniruddh’s eyes became still for a moment, but his voice did not change.

“This is the first real correspondence.”

Mayank said, “But correspondence is not proof of crime.”

Aniruddh smiled faintly. “You suffer from it too.”

“From what?”

“Nyāya philosophy.”

Mayank laughed for the first time.

“My father used to teach it. If smoke rose in the house, he would first say not ‘There is a fire,’ but ‘There is an inference of fire.’ Mother would say, ‘Go and look in the kitchen; we’ll do philosophy afterwards.’”

All three laughed.

For a few moments the tension in the room eased.

Then Aniruddh grew serious again.

“I need one thing. A list of every beneficiary entity receiving payments within this six percent. But no conclusions about individuals in advance.”

Mayank said, “One name keeps recurring—‘Loksetu Public Relations Service’. A private organisation. It handles election publicity as well as cultural events.”

“Owner?”

“On paper, a woman named Malati Ghosh.”

“Politics?”

“Nothing direct.”

Aniruddh made a note.

Mayank turned another page.

“And there is a small company called ‘Ambar Sports Media’. The amounts are very small at present. Sports events, local competitions, advertising.”

Rohit showed no interest.

Aniruddh too merely wrote down the name.

Many names on paper are meaningless at first.

Years later, the same names become doorways into an entire age.



The crowds of mourners at Satyaprakash's house began to thin.

In the first week the house had been full of people. In the second, only close relatives remained. By the third, the threshold was empty again.

Mrinalini had begun to fear the empty house.

Satyaprakash's chair stood exactly as he had left it.

His spectacles lay on the table.

An old coat hung from a peg.

At night Ishaan pretended to study, but never turned a page.

One evening he sat beside his mother and asked, "Who killed Babu?"

Mrinalini drew a long breath.

"The police have not yet said that he was killed."

"Do you believe it was an accident?"

Mrinalini did not answer.

Ishaan's voice hardened. "If everyone waits for proof, the person who killed him will be gone by then."

Dhaneshwari had been listening from the veranda.

She came inside and said, "Justice does not come in haste, son. Haste brings only revenge."

Ishaan stood up.

"Is revenge wrong?"

"Yes."

"And if justice never comes?"

Dhaneshwari's face changed.

In books, the answer to that question was simple.

In life, it was not.

"Then we keep asking for justice. But we must not become the snake ourselves."

Ishaan said nothing.

He went outside.

There was no mongoose in the rear courtyard that day.

Only dry grass beside its old burrow.

Sometimes the guardian cannot be seen.

That is why a human being must awaken a watchman within.



Three days later, the examination of the burnt vehicle delivered the investigation its first setback.

It was not the truck that had struck Satyaprakash.

The size matched.

At first, the colour had seemed to match as well.

But the engine and chassis identities were different.

Rohit was disappointed.

“So the warehouse was useless?”

Aniruddh said, “No. If someone wanted us to believe that this was the truck, then the question has changed.”

“Meaning?”

“The first question was: where is the truck? Now the question is: why did someone manufacture a false answer?”

Rohit fell silent.

It was the investigation's second lesson.

False evidence is also evidence—evidence of the mind of the person who wants to send an inquiry in the wrong direction.

The warehouse register also proved old. The initials “K. M.” might not have stood for Kaushal Mahto at all, but for an employee named Kaushik Mistri.

The painted name of Sarita Logistics on the wall was two years old.

There was no basis for immediately arresting Kaushal Mahto.

A few journalists were waiting outside the police station. “Has the truck owner been arrested?”

Aniruddh answered, “No.”

“The principal accused?”

“There is no principal accused yet.”

One journalist laughed. “Sir, the public wants a name.”

Aniruddh said, “A court proceeds on evidence, not on names.”

The next day's newspaper carried the headline: “Police Empty-Handed.”

Rohit slapped the paper down on the table.

“Look at this.”

Aniruddh went on drinking his tea.

“Being empty-handed is not a crime.”

“But calls will come from above.”

“They will.”

“Political pressure?”

“That too.”

“Then?”

Aniruddh put down his cup.

“If pressure makes us arrest the wrong man, the government itself will have saved the real criminal.”



The pressure did come.

First from the district office.

Then from the capital.

A senior officer said over the telephone, “The matter is becoming sensitive. The deceased contractor’s community is preparing to protest.”

Aniruddh replied, “The investigation is under way.”

“Any progress?”

“Some indications.”

“Names?”

“Not yet.”

There was silence at the other end.

“Chaudharyji, the public does not understand process.”

“That does not mean the process can be changed.”

The call ended.

Rohit asked, “Did he scold you?”

“No.”

“Then?”

“He gave me time—without naming a time.”



That same night, a fire broke out in the city’s new industrial belt.

Road-construction machinery, a diesel tank, tarpaulins, rubber pipes—within minutes the flames had surged.

The yard belonged to a small contractor called Shivdhara Construction.

The owner was out of town with his family.

Two labourers were on night watch.

One escaped.

The other did not.

At dawn his body was found inside the burnt tin shed.

His name was Mohan Paswan.

He was forty-two.

A wife in the village.

Three children.

Once the fire was extinguished, the police found an old mobile phone more important than the ruined machinery. It had been in the pocket of Ramjeevan, the watchman who had escaped.

He said that shortly before the fire, the owner had received a telephone call.

The phone had not been on speaker.

But Ramjeevan had heard the owner's reply—

"I will not withdraw the tender."

That was all.

Aniruddh reached the scene.

Mohan's body had already been removed. On the ground, only the iron frame of the burnt cot remained.

The owner, Shivkumar Mandal, said in a trembling voice, "It is not the machines I grieve for, sahib. Machines can be bought again. That man had worked for me for ten years."

He suddenly sat down.

"What will I say when I go to his house?"

Aniruddh had no answer.

On paper, the meaning of crime changes.

"Arson."

"Coercion."

"Criminal conspiracy."

But for Mohan's wife, the crime had another name—

"The one who earned for the household is gone."

No aphorism of Nyāya philosophy could make that sentence weigh less.



Mohan's death altered the public direction of the investigation for the first time.

Satyaprakash's road accident was still disputed.

But the fire at the yard was unmistakably a crime.

Three days earlier, Shivkumar Mandal had submitted a bid for the same regional road tender in which five large companies were also competing.

He had been pressured to withdraw.

"By whom?" Aniruddh asked.

Shivkumar was silent.

"The person who called you."

"No name."

"The voice?"

"Disguised."

"Did he ask for money?"

"No."

"What did he ask for?"

“That I step aside.”

“Why?”

Shivkumar’s eyes filled.

“He said, ‘A small boat does not sail in a great current.’”

Rohit wrote it down.

Aniruddh asked, “Why did you not tell the police earlier?”

Shivkumar suddenly flared with anger.

“Satyaprakash wanted to tell you. Where is he now?”

Everyone in the room fell silent.

“Should I make my own children orphans?”

Aniruddh accepted the anger without protest.

A law book may call a witness a ‘cooperating citizen’.

In a society ruled by fear, a witness is first a father, a husband, a son.

A citizen only afterwards.



After the yard was set on fire, one fact became clear: the tender network did not merely extract money; it controlled competition.

Mayank Jha reopened the documents.

Where payments to Pravahi Consulting were higher, there were fewer competing bids.

Where competition was greater, two or three companies withdrew their papers at the last moment.

Sometimes because of a technical defect.

Sometimes because a bank guarantee did not arrive in time.

Sometimes because an owner suddenly fell ill.

Each incident, taken alone, was ordinary.

Seen together, they were not.

Mayank said, “This is like upamāna.”

Rohit asked, “Upamāna?”

“Suppose you have never seen a nilgai in the forest. Someone tells you: it is somewhat like a cow, but larger and blue-grey. When you encounter those features in the forest, recognition becomes possible. Here we knew the marks of an old extortion network—fear, percentages, the removal of competitors. Now a new form of it is appearing on paper.”

Aniruddh added, “But upamāna gives recognition, not conviction.”

Rohit laughed. “Putting the two of you in one room was a mistake.”

Mayank laughed too.

But the laughter ended quickly.

For on the next page, one name surfaced again—

Loksetu Public Relations Service.
Shivdhara Construction too had paid it a year earlier.
Satyaprakash's company had not.
Why?



Loksetu's registered office occupied two rooms above a cultural centre.

Photographs of folk dances hung on the walls, alongside certificates from blood-donation camps and sports trophies.

Malati Ghosh sat opposite them.

Past forty, precise in speech, confidence in her eyes.

"We handle public relations—local meetings about government schemes, labour camps, inaugurations, press liaison."

Mayank asked, "The same percentage for a bridge contractor and a school-building contractor?"

"That is our fee structure."

"In writing?"

"Yes."

The file was brought.

The papers were clean.

Taxes regularly paid.

An employee list.

Photographs of programmes.

Rohit's face said: we will find nothing here.

Aniruddh picked up one photograph.

An embankment-awareness camp.

A banner in the background.

Ten or fifteen labourers in front.

"Where was this programme held?"

"Kushwaha Tola."

"Date?"

"Twelfth of June."

Aniruddh put the photograph back.

"That area was flooded that day. The road was closed."

For the first time, Malati's eyes shifted.

"The date may have been printed incorrectly."

"Possible."

"The photograph is genuine."

"That too is possible."

"Then what are you trying to say?"

Aniruddh said calmly, "I am not saying anything. I am asking."

Malati's face steadied again.

Legal paperwork is sometimes not a shield for crime.

Sometimes the paperwork truly is innocent.

That is the investigator's difficulty: to see clean papers and assume crime is prejudice; to see clean papers and assume innocence is folly.



As they left the office, Mayank said quietly, "The wrong date could be a coincidence."

"Yes."

"But in three photographs?"

Aniruddh stopped.

"Three?"

Mayank took copies from his bag.

Two programmes had supposedly been held on dates when, according to official records, movement in the area had been restricted by prohibitory orders or weather.

"So the reports were created afterwards?"

"Possible."

"Fabricated?"

"I will not say that yet."

Rohit muttered, "Why don't you arrest the word 'possible' while you're at it?"

For the first time, Aniruddh laughed openly.

"Because for half an investigation, that word is what keeps us out of jail."



One evening a motorcycle stopped outside Mrinalini's house.

The two young men did not get off.

They merely threw an envelope across the threshold.

Ishaan picked it up.

Inside was a photograph of Satyaprakash.

Across it, in black ink, one line had been written—

"Let the one who is gone remain gone."

Mrinalini began to tremble as she took the envelope.

Dhaneshwari did not snatch the photograph away and burn it.

She placed it in a plastic bag.

"The police."

Mrinalini recoiled. "Maaji—"

“Not this time. We will not hide it.”

Ishaan looked at his grandmother.

Dhaneshwari’s voice was hard—

“Once a cobra has entered the house, you do not shut the door and go to sleep.”

Aniruddh came himself that night.

The envelope, photograph, and paper were secured.

“Did anyone see the motorcycle?”

A neighbour said, “Black.”

“The number?”

No one had seen it.

Ishaan said, “This means Babu was murdered.”

Aniruddh did not answer him directly.

“It means someone wants all of you to remain silent.”

“What’s the difference?”

“A great deal.”

Ishaan grew angry.

“You people play with words.”

Aniruddh sat down in front of him.

“You are right. For you, the difference is small. For me, someone’s entire life can depend on that difference.”

“My father’s life?”

Aniruddh’s face tightened.

“He will not come back.”

Ishaan’s eyes filled.

“Then what does justice change?”

In the room, Dhaneshwari, Mrinalini, and Aniruddh all fell silent.

A faint rustle came from the courtyard outside.

Every gaze turned that way.

A mongoose stood for a moment beyond the threshold.

Then it vanished into the darkness.

Aniruddh watched it go.

Dhaneshwari said softly, “The watch is not over yet.”



The following week, the government approved a joint investigative arrangement.

Its name was strikingly ordinary: “Integrated Economic Crime Investigation Cell.”

No special uniform.

No separate insignia.

No public inauguration.

Five rooms on the third floor of the Accounts Training Building in the capital.

Aniruddh Chaudhary as coordinator.

Mayank Jha for financial analysis.

Rohit for field investigation.

A bank officer on deputation.

And a digital-records specialist—Naina Verma.

The objective was no longer only Satyaprakash's death.

Tenders, coercion, consulting payments, arson, fabricated public-relations reports—all were to be examined together.

At the first meeting, Aniruddh wrote no suspect's name on the board.

He wrote five words—

Event.

Relation.

Cause.

Evidence.

Judgment.

Naina asked, "Is this police training or philosophy?"

Mayank smiled.

Aniruddh said, "Both."

Then beneath the five words he wrote one line—

"Do not begin by treating as true the very thing you are trying to prove."



Naina Verma began with the payment records.

She was not a hacker.

Nor was she a specialist in criminal forums.

She read the data of banking systems—how many accounts became unusually active on the same day, how many entities received payments from the same cluster of contractors, how many payments quickly dissolved into other business expenses.

On the first day she said, "The network is remarkably clean on paper."

Rohit sounded disappointed. "Then?"

"Cleanliness is itself information."

Mayank asked, "How?"

"Small companies usually carry the disorder of ordinary life—sometimes a delay, sometimes a wrong detail, sometimes a minor outstanding balance.

Here, some entities are unnaturally regular. As though someone measures every step before taking it.”

Aniruddh asked, “Proof of crime?”

Naina laughed. “No. Only proof that whoever prepares the paperwork is disciplined.”

“Good.”

Rohit put a hand to his head.

There were now three people in the room who added “not proof” after every answer.



Within two weeks, the first solid connection emerged.

Pravahi Consultancy and Loksetu Public Relations had separate offices.

Different directors.

Different banks.

But the annual accounts of both were prepared by the same outside accounting firm—

“Samyak Accounting Support.”

Owner—Harinath Mishra.

Sixty years old.

A small office.

Four employees.

When Aniruddh’s team arrived, Harinath did not try to flee.

Cleaning his spectacles, he said, “I am an accountant, not a criminal.”

“And at present I am not calling you a criminal either.”

Harinath smiled bitterly. “These days, that sentence frightens people more.”

The files were brought out.

Harinath cooperated openly.

“Who brings Pravahi’s papers?”

“Employees.”

“Names?”

“Sometimes Deepak, sometimes Shashank.”

“Loksetu?”

“Malatiji’s office.”

“Anyone common to both?”

Harinath thought for a moment.

“One young man.”

“Name?”

“I do not know the full name. Everyone calls him ‘Pranav Babu’.”

“What does he do?”

“He comes when the annual reconciliations of both organisations are being done. He says, ‘There must be no question left in the papers.’”

Rohit asked at once, “Threats?”

“No.”

“Money?”

“The fees are paid on time.”

“Pranav’s surname?”

“Perhaps Sen.”

Harinath paused.

“No. Perhaps ‘Singh’. I am not certain.”

Aniruddh said, “If you are not certain, do not say it.”

Harinath let out a breath of relief.

As they stepped outside, Mayank said, “The first condition of testimonial evidence is that the speaker remain within the limits of what he actually knows.”

Aniruddh nodded.

“And the investigator’s first temptation is to make the speaker say what he does not know.”



The search for ‘Pranav Babu’ produced five Pranavs.

An insurance agent.

A schoolteacher.

A vehicle dealer.

An unemployed young man.

And a project coordinator—Pranavesh Pathak.

Rohit’s attention settled on the last.

Pranavesh worked for a company called ‘Digant Project Group’.

Digant itself did not bid for government tenders.

For large contractors it handled every kind of ‘coordination’—land, labour, local permissions, public relations, security, vehicles.

Legitimate on paper.

Mayank studied the list.

One of Pravahi’s directors had previously been an employee of Digant.

One of Loksetu’s programme coordinators was contracted to Digant.

Sarita Logistics had supplied vehicles to three Digant projects.

Ambar Sports Media publicised Digant’s annual sports festival.

For the first time, a centre appeared among several separate names.

Rohit brightened. “This time we have a name.”

Aniruddh said, “We have a name. Not yet a crime.”

“Sir.”

“Digant may be a lawful company whose clients commit crimes.”

Mayank added, “Or it may itself be the centre of the crime.”

Naina said, “Or somewhere between the two.”

Digant’s name was written on the board.

No circle around it.

No red ink.

Only the name.



The head of Digant was Devanshu Rakshit.

Forty-five years old.

Educated in an English-medium school.

Formerly a project manager with a construction company.

Later, proprietor of his own ‘coordination’ business.

At public forums he spoke about development, investment and local employment.

In photographs he stood on bridges wearing a hard hat.

Computer donations to schools.

Food distribution during floods.

An honour from the Chamber of Commerce.

No photograph proves a crime.

No donation proves innocence either.

Aniruddh did not summon him at once.

Documents first.

Digant’s client list.

Its employees.

Pranavesh Pathak’s travel.

Its links with the consultancy organisations.

The technical team could determine only the broad area from which the call pressuring Shivdhara Construction to withdraw its bid had originated—not the specific person.

The truck from Satyaprakash’s crash was still missing.

The net was becoming visible.

But its centre was still only an inference.



One night, while returning home, Mayank Jha noticed a motorcycle behind him.

The first turn.
The second.
The third.
He accelerated.
So did the motorcycle.
Mayank's palms began to sweat.
Instead of taking the road home, he drove straight to a crowded square.
The motorcycle passed him and went on.
Perhaps coincidence.
Perhaps pursuit.
He had not seen the number plate.
That night his wife asked, "What happened?"
"Nothing."
It was a very small lie.
But with that lie, the investigation entered his home for the first time.
The next day Mayank told Aniruddh what had happened.
"Do you want police protection?"
"No."
"Why?"
"What if it was only coincidence?"
"And what if it was not?"
Mayank fell silent.
Aniruddh said, "Courage is not a category of evidence."
Mayank smiled faintly, but the smile did not reach his eyes.
From that day, discreet surveillance was placed around his home.
Mayank told his wife the whole truth.
She asked only one question—
"Can you leave this work?"
Mayank remained silent for a long time before answering.
"I can."
"Will you?"
"No."
His wife turned her face away.
Tragedy does not visit only those who commit crimes.
Sometimes duty too breaks the peace of a home.



Mohan Paswan's wife, Sarojini, did not come to the capital.

She was sitting in her village, surrounded by her three children, when Aniruddh's team arrived for the compensation formalities and her statement.

The house was of mud.

The roof of tin.

On the wall hung a photograph of Mohan from the time of his wedding.

Sarojini did not want the vocabulary of law.

She asked, "Why did they set the fire?"

Aniruddh said, "The investigation is continuing."

"Had my husband done anything?"

"No."

"Then?"

Aniruddh was silent.

Sarojini did not cry.

"If he had not gone to work that night, he would have lived."

There was no answer.

"Did he go to save the owner's machines, or could he simply not get out?"

"The man who was with him says the fire spread very fast."

Sarojini looked at the wall.

"I do not understand justice. I understand how my daughter will pay her school fees next month."

After they stepped outside, Aniruddh stood for a long time before getting into the vehicle.

Mayank, who was with him, said, "Philosophy becomes small here."

Aniruddh replied, "If justice cannot reach this question, then philosophy truly is small."



The cell met again.

There were now five circles on the board.

Pravahi.

Loksetu.

Digant.

Sarita.

Ambar Sports.

A question mark in the middle.

Naina said, "Ambar still stands apart from the rest."

"Why?" Rohit asked.

"Its income is small, and its work is sports advertising. But two of its payment sources are linked to Digant."

Mayank asked, "Any criminal indicator?"

"No."

Aniruddh erased the circle around its name.

"Then for now it remains on the list only as a connection. No criminal attribution."

Rohit muttered, "Even this board has turned into a courtroom."

Aniruddh said, "Good."

Then beneath Digant's name he wrote—

"Pranavesh Pathak."

"Understand this man first."



Pranavesh came to the police on his own.

The development surprised everyone.

At ten in the morning he told the reception desk, "I need to meet Aniruddh Chaudhary."

Once inside, he placed his mobile phone on the table.

"I do not have much time."

Rohit closed the door.

Aniruddh asked, "Why have you come?"

"Because I think everything is going to come down on me now."

"Everything means?"

"The company. The police. The people behind the company."

"Who is behind the company?"

Pranavesh laughed.

"If I knew the names, I probably would not be sitting here."

"Pravahi?"

"An outside pocket of Digant."

"Loksetu?"

"Another pocket."

"Is that a metaphor or a fact?"

Pranavesh looked at Aniruddh.

"You are a difficult man."

"I need precision."

Pranavesh leaned forward.

"Digant 'coordinates' among contractors. Someone does not bid. Someone withdraws. Someone pays to avoid local opposition. Someone pays in the name of an event. Someone in the name of consultancy. I used to make the paperwork fit."

"Six percent?"

Pranavesh's face tightened.

"Where did you get that figure?"

Aniruddh did not answer.

Pranavesh understood: someone else inside the network had already spoken—or the papers themselves were speaking.

"Six is not fixed. It changes with the work."

"Satyaprakash Karna?"

Pranavesh fell completely silent.

"Did you know him?"

"The name."

"His crash?"

"I know nothing."

Aniruddh watched his eyes.

"The Shivdhara yard?"

"No."

"Mohan Paswan?"

"No."

"Devanshu Rakshit?"

"The owner."

"Did he give the orders?"

Pranavesh laughed wearily.

"Sir, in a large network the word 'order' is used very little. People understand what is expected."

"Meaning?"

"No one says, 'Set the fire.' They only say, 'Make this man understand.' Then the person sent to 'make him understand' chooses his own method."

In Aniruddh's mind flashed the charred iron frame of Mohan's cot.

"That is the language of self-defence."

"It is reality."

"It can be both."

Pranavesh lowered his head.

After a while he said, "I want to become a witness."

Rohit opened his notebook at once.

Aniruddh did not.

"Why?"

"I am afraid."

"Guilt?"

Pranavesh was silent.

"Or only fear for your own life?"

For the first time, Pranavesh broke.

“Both.”



Pranavesh's statement was not written down immediately.

First, his claims were independently checked.

The travel records matched the dates of the three meetings he named.

The payment records existed for the two hotels he mentioned.

The general pattern he described for dividing the 'six percent' partially matched Mayank's calculations.

But regarding the killing, he had no direct knowledge.

Aniruddh made it explicit—

“You may be a witness concerning the financial network. Not concerning Satyaprakash's murder, unless you yourself saw something or possess reliable direct information.”

Pranavesh grew restless. “But it is all the same network.”

“Belonging to the same net does not give you knowledge of every knot.”

Mayank said softly, “Here lies the limit of testimonial evidence.”

Pranavesh snapped, “I did not come here to study philosophy.”

Aniruddh's voice hardened.

“And I am not sitting here to write a story. In court, one false sentence from you can contaminate an entire truthful statement.”

Pranavesh fell silent.

His protection was increased that day.

But Aniruddh understood—

for the first time, the network had begun to tremble from within.



Devanshu Rakshit sat in the Digant office until evening.

He had not yet received an official notice from the police.

Yet he already knew.

No one had seen Pranavesh at the office.

His phone was switched off.

He was not at home.

One of the two men sitting before Devanshu asked, “Run away?”

Devanshu shook his head.

“A man who runs switches off his phone. So does a man who goes to testify.”

The other man said, “Then?”

Devanshu looked out of the window.

“Nothing.”

“Nothing?”

“At this moment, whoever is in the greatest hurry will be the one the police notice.”

“Pranavesh knows a great deal.”

“As much as he knows, he does not know that much about us.”

“But the network?”

Devanshu said slowly—

“The network has to be larger than any individual. Otherwise it is not business; it is stupidity.”

No one in that room used the word murder.

No one said fire.

No one said threat.

That was the most terrifying quality of the network.

Crime had civilised its language.



In Garh Narikel, Ishaan spent that night arranging his father’s old papers with his own hands for the first time.

Mrinalini had given permission—“Do not tear anything.”

He separated bills, bank slips, machine receipts and workers’ accounts.

Inside an old envelope he found a small note in Satyaprakash’s handwriting.

Only three words—

“Ambar—called twice.”

Ishaan took the note to his mother.

Mrinalini did not recognise the name.

“Who is Ambar?”

“Perhaps a company.”

The next day the note reached Aniruddh.

Ambar Sports Media.

That same small name which had almost been removed from the board.

Naina reopened the file.

The company organised sporting events.

A local kabaddi league.

Cricket tournaments.

A plan to build a small mobile application carrying sports results, player statistics and tournament registrations.

So far, nothing illegal.

But why had Satyaprakash called it twice?

Aniruddh wrote the name on the board again.

This time, no circle.

Only a small arrow at the side, like a mongoose's mark.

Naina laughed. "What is that?"

Aniruddh said, "Nothing. Only a mark so I remember."

Years later, the meaning of that small mark would change.

For now, the story still moved among tenders, fear, percentages and the dead.

But beneath the water another current was approaching from very far away.



That night a mist descended on the floodplain of the Kamla-Balan at Garh Narikel.

Ishaan was not alone. Dhaneshwari was with him.

"Why did you bring me here?" Ishaan asked.

Dhaneshwari looked towards the water.

"When your father was little, he used to catch fish here."

Ishaan heard this for the first time.

"He never told me."

"People do not tell their children everything about their own childhood."

For a while both were silent.

A rustle in the grass.

Ishaan froze.

A mongoose crossed the narrow path.

A little farther away, from the bushes, came something like a hiss; then it ceased.

Dhaneshwari said—

"See? It is not necessary that a mongoose kill the snake. Sometimes its mere presence is enough to make the snake change its path."

Ishaan looked towards the water.

"And the monitor lizard?"

"The monitor lizard does not abandon the path. It changes the water."

"Then what should the mongoose do?"

Dhaneshwari remained silent for a long time.

"Do not leave the bank."

Ishaan kept the answer in his mind.

He did not know that much later in his life, when crime would leave guns and tender papers behind and descend into mobile screens, gambling

numbers, unknown bank accounts and invisible currents of money, he would remember again the four words from this night—

Do not leave the bank.

The waters of the Kamla-Balan vanished into the grey mist.

But on the bank remained the footprints of two human beings and a mongoose.

Tragedy was moving forward.

So was the vigil.

Ambar Sports Media's office stood in the part of the city where, after dusk, the lights from the shops drew bands of colour across the road. A sporting-goods shop occupied the ground floor; above it were two rooms, and on the roof a small hall under a tin shed.

Naina Verma went in first, alone, posing as an ordinary customer. No police vehicle, no identity card. Only a plain salwar-kameez and an old mobile phone in her hand.

The walls displayed photographs of local kabaddi tournaments. In one, adolescents held a trophy. Another showed a flood-relief cricket match. A third bore a banner: 'Ambar Youth Sports Festival.'

The young man in the office explained enthusiastically, "We are now working on bringing sports results, player statistics and tournament registration together on one mobile platform."

"How will you earn money?" Naina asked casually.

"Advertising. Sponsors. Premium services later."

"Prize money?"

"Not yet. There will be competitions later."

"With money staked on them?"

The young man laughed. "Then it would become gambling, didi. We do legitimate work."

Naina laughed too.

There was nothing immediately wrong in the answer.

But people accustomed to reading documents do not merely listen to an answer; they remember the manner in which it is given.

For a moment the young man's face had changed at the word 'gambling'. Not fear. Familiarity.

Naina stepped outside and caught a tempo.

That night she wrote only this in her notes—

'Ambar's declared business is lawful. Nevertheless, the concepts of "stake/prize" do not appear unfamiliar to the organisation. Independent verification required.'

That sentence was far too little to call anyone guilty.

But an investigation is often built from such small sentences—sentences that contain no judgment, only memory.



For his protection, Pranavesh Pathak was lodged in a government guest house outside the city.

His wife Ranjana arrived two days later.

The instant the door opened, she slapped Pranavesh.

Aniruddh and Rohit were both in the room.

Neither officer intervened.

Ranjana said in a trembling voice, “For six years I kept asking—where does so much money come from? You kept saying bonus. Project. Travel. What will our son say at school now?”

Pranavesh kept his eyes lowered.

“I was trying to keep you safe—”

“Lie.”

A single word.

Ranjana said again, “You did not keep me safe. You kept me ignorant.”

Aniruddh took note of the sentence.

Within a criminal network, secrecy is not merely a way of evading the police.

It builds walls inside the home as well.

Outside, the offender says, ‘The family knows nothing.’

Inside, the family says, ‘We were told nothing.’

The two statements sound alike, but their moral weight is different.

Ranjana was not willing to let their son remain near Pranavesh. She left him a few clothes and went away.

After the door closed, Pranavesh sat on the bed.

“Sir,” he said softly, “perhaps going to prison will not be this difficult.”

Aniruddh asked, “Why?”

“In prison, at least people already know whether you are a criminal or an accused man. At home, they discovered it after six years.”

Aniruddh felt sympathy for his pain, but it was necessary to keep that sympathy separate from fact.

“You are a witness,” he said, “not absolved. What you have done will also have to be accounted for.”

Pranavesh nodded.

“I know.”

Then, after a little while—

“I did not know before.”



A formal order was issued requiring Digant Project Group to produce its records.

Devanshu Rakshit appeared with his lawyer.

There was no haste in his manner. White shirt, ash-grey coat, thin spectacles over his eyes.

“I will cooperate fully,” he said.

Aniruddh replied, “That is what I expect as well.”

The lawyer continued reading the papers.

Devanshu continued watching Aniruddh.

“Chaudharyji, local coordination in government projects is not easy. You need labour, there are land disputes, panchayats, protests, transport, weather. People sitting outside see paperwork; on the ground, we take the risks.”

“That is possible.”

Devanshu smiled faintly.

“Do you call everything possible?”

“Until there is evidence to the contrary.”

“Then you do not consider me a criminal?”

“At present, I am examining your company’s role.”

Devanshu leaned back in his chair.

“People think the police choose the man first and then look for the crime.”

Aniruddh said, “Sometimes that does happen. That is why I try to read the line of the crime first.”

“And if that line leads towards me?”

“Then your name will be written down.”

“And if it does not?”

“Then it will be erased.”

Devanshu remained silent for a few moments at that answer.

As he left, he said only, “The world is very poor at erasing names, Chaudharyji.”

Aniruddh understood: it might be a complaint, or it might be a warning. Without evidence, it would be improper to choose either interpretation.



Digant’s records filled three rooms.

Papers, printouts of emails, contracts, travel bills, subcontracts, consultancy fees, cultural programmes, vehicle payments.

Naina and Mayank worked day and night making lists.

Rohit disliked this work more than anything else.

“To catch criminals, I have become an auditor.”

Mayank replied, “Criminal money prefers paperwork to guns.”

Three days later Naina noticed something peculiar.

On different dates, several of Digant’s clients had paid small amounts to Ambar Sports Media under the heading ‘regional sports promotion’. Each amount was so small that no individual payment attracted attention.

Twenty thousand on a five-lakh project.

One lakh on a two-crore project.

Fifty thousand in one place.

Seventy or seventy-five thousand in another.

“This is not part of the six per cent,” Mayank said.

“No,” Naina replied. “This comes after it.”

Aniruddh asked, “Meaning?”

“Wherever there are payments to Pravahi and Loksetu, small payments to Ambar also recur. As though a little current is branching away from the main channel.”

Rohit brightened. “Money laundering?”

“Not yet,” Naina stopped him at once. “The company really does organise sports. There are photographs, there are programmes. The question is: if a contractor is building a road in one district, why would he repeatedly sponsor a private kabaddi tournament in another?”

Mayank said, “Public relations.”

“Possible.”

On the board Aniruddh wrote beneath Ambar’s name—

‘Legitimate work + unusual sponsorship.’

Then he drew a line from Digant to Ambar.

The line was thin.

But it was there.



Meanwhile, Kanhaiya Rajak’s life was falling apart.

He was the vehicle broker whose name Kaushal Mahto had given them.

The police had been looking for him only for questioning, but somehow word leaked out—‘Kanhaiya suspected in sale and purchase of truck in Satyaprakash accident.’

Two local news pages printed his name.

Kanhaiya switched off his phone.

People came to his house and abused him.

Within a week, his small transport-brokerage business had fallen by half.

The worst blow was that negotiations for his daughter Neha's marriage were suspended.

The prospective groom's family said, "We will see after the investigation clears him."

When Kanhaiya appeared before the police, he was trembling with anger.

"Did you people say I was an accused man?"

Aniruddh said, "No."

"Then how did my name reach the newspapers?"

"We will investigate."

"Who will answer my daughter?"

Aniruddh was silent.

"I only brokered the sale of that truck. The papers were not completed; that was a mistake. But the accident? The fire? Murder? What do I know?"

He threw a slip of paper onto the table.

"Look at this. I knew the man who bought the truck only as 'Lala'. Payment came in three parts. One part cash, the second through a bank, the third as a draft from a cooperative credit institution."

Mayank picked up the slip.

The cooperative institution was 'Janvishwas Multipurpose Cooperative Society'.

The name had not appeared in the file before.

Kanhaiya stood up.

At the door he stopped and said, "Sir, it is good not to arrest the wrong man. But letting the wrong man's name go out is half a punishment in itself."

Aniruddh wrote the sentence in his notebook.

At the evening meeting he told the team plainly, "Find out who leaked the information about Kanhaiya. Confidentiality in an investigation is not only for preventing offenders from escaping; it is also for protecting the innocent."

Rohit lowered his head.

It was not yet clear whether the leak had come from the police or from an outside office.

But the damage had already been done.

Justice is not only the final judgment.

Justice must also account for those trampled along the road to it.



On paper, Janvishwas Cooperative Society was almost dormant.

Rural savings, small loans, self-help groups.

Yet on the date the draft was issued, a large sum entered its account for a single day and left the next.

The source of the money—a subcontractor linked to Digant.

The beneficiary—the vehicle seller.

Mayank said, “This is not an ordinary loan transaction.”

Naina added, “The cooperative account was used like an intermediate stop.”

Aniruddh asked, “Could there be a lawful reason?”

“There could. A tax dispute, adjustment of a debt, an old liability.”

“Then documents first.”

The society’s president, Basudev Mandal, was a seventy-year-old farmer.

Sitting in the office, he did not read the papers; the manager handled everything.

“This draft?” Aniruddh asked.

Basudev put on his spectacles and looked at it.

“That is my signature.”

“What was the payment for?”

“The manager said it was an adjustment of the society’s old vehicle loan.”

“Where is the manager?”

“He left the job three months ago.”

“Name?”

“Jitendra Pal.”

“Address?”

“His wife went to her parents’ home. I do not know where he himself is.”

Rohit’s expression changed.

In a crime story, a missing man is immediately attractive.

Aniruddh understood that attraction.

“Being missing is not guilt,” he said. “First establish whether he is actually missing or has merely left his job.”

Within three days they learned that Jitendra Pal had not fled.

He was suffering from kidney disease and was under treatment in a hospital in the capital.

Rohit was not disappointed. He was embarrassed.

“I jumped to a conclusion again.”

Aniruddh said, “The mind moves faster than a police vehicle. That is why it needs a rein.”



Jitendra Pal was very weak in the hospital bed.

He did not breathe like a criminal; he breathed like a sick man.

Aniruddh kept his questions limited.

“Why were Digant-linked payments routed through Janvishwas Society?”

Jitendra closed his eyes and thought for a few moments.

“I was told that the society’s old loan portfolio was being purchased.”

“Who told you?”

“A man from a chartered-accounting consultancy. His name may have been Surjit.”

“Documents?”

“There were documents.”

“Why did the money ultimately reach the vehicle buyer?”

Jitendra frowned.

“I understood that only later. I had prepared the signature sheet; the final beneficiary was changed.”

“Who changed it?”

“I do not know.”

Rohit wanted to ask another question, but Aniruddh stopped him.

It would have been easy, in the name of extracting truth, to torment a sick body.

He said only, “We will speak again when you are better.”

Jitendra gave a faint laugh.

“Better?”

He looked at his wasted hand.

“The doctors do not use that word often.”

Outside the room, Jitendra’s wife sat with their two children.

As Aniruddh walked out, he understood that a name that appears as a dot on a criminal network’s paperwork has an entire household behind it.

A few weeks later Jitendra Pal died.

He died of illness.

No one killed him.

Yet in the investigation file a small bracket appeared beside his name: ‘Deceased.’

Aniruddh found that bracket unbearable.

A human being spends a lifetime as a sentence.

A file reduces him to a single word.



One thing Pranavesh had described was finally confirmed by independent evidence.

Inside Digant, an ‘adjustment list’ was maintained—which contractor was cooperative, who was obstinate, who paid, who withdrew from a tender, who had political access.

It was not on the company’s official server.

One employee had left an old copy in a private cloud-storage account; after obtaining due consent and authorisation, Naina secured its backup.

The list contained no explicit order to commit a crime.

But its terse annotations were chilling—

‘Soft.’

‘Pressure required.’

‘Family-sensitive.’

‘Afraid of media.’

‘Political.’

‘Hard.’

Beside Satyaprakash Karna’s name were the words—

‘Hard. Not family-sensitive. Different measure.’

Silence settled over the room.

For the first time, Rohit said nothing.

Everyone remembered Mrinalini’s face.

Ishaan.

Dhaneshwari.

What did ‘different measure’ mean?

Aniruddh wrote the question on the board.

Mayank said, “It could mean murder.”

“It could.”

Naina said, “It could also mean obstructing the business, withholding payment, terminating a contract.”

“Correct.”

Rohit was uneasy. “How long will we remain this cautious?”

Aniruddh looked at him.

“Until evidence—not we—tells us what ‘different measure’ means.”



Satyaprakash’s call records were opened again.

Two calls to Ambar Sports Media.

The first—seven minutes.

The second—nineteen minutes.

Five days between the two calls.

After the calls, Satyaprakash had stopped a cheque at his bank. Beneficiary—Ambar Sports Media. Amount—one lakh twenty-five thousand rupees.

Mrinalini was questioned.

“Do you remember anything about this payment?”

She thought for a long time.

“One day he said, ‘Now they are asking for a share in the name of sports as well.’ I thought he meant a donation to a school.”

“Do you remember the exact words?”

“I cannot say word for word. The sense was like that.”

Aniruddh had the statement recorded exactly so: ‘Witness not certain of the words verbatim; remembers the substance.’

Mrinalini asked, “Is that so important?”

“Yes. In court it is wrong to say you remember what you do not remember.”

“And if the criminal escapes because of that?”

Aniruddh said quietly, “A punishment obtained through false evidence is not justice.”

Mrinalini turned her face away.

“Justice feels like a very hard thing to me now.”

Aniruddh did not answer.

Sometimes justice demands patience even from the victim.

To ask for that patience can itself feel like an injustice.



Ambar’s founder was Vihan Sarang.

He had once played district-level cricket. After an injury ended his playing career, he entered advertising.

Vihan tried to appear at ease before Aniruddh.

“Satyaprakashji was going to sponsor us. Later he stopped the payment.”

“Why?”

“He said there was no budget.”

“Two long conversations?”

“The terms of sponsorship.”

“Digant?”

“Our client.”

“Devanshu Rakshit?”

“I know him.”

“How closely?”

“Professionally.”

“Pranavesh Pathak?”

Vihan paused for a moment.

“I know him.”

Aniruddh continued making notes.

“What does Ambar want to do in the future?”

For the first time Vihan’s eyes lit up.

“A digital sports platform. Rural tournaments, player profiles, live results. People will create teams of their choice and earn points—entertainment.”

“Money?”

“Not at present.”

“Later?”

“As much as the law permits.”

“Wagers?”

Vihan answered immediately, “No.”

Naina was sitting in a corner of the room.

She noted that, like the first employee, Vihan too seemed to know the word in the question before it was asked.

But that could simply be professional knowledge.

Aniruddh asked his final question. “Why did Satyaprakash stop the payment?”

“Budget.”

“Certain?”

“Yes.”

Aniruddh did not challenge him.

After they left the room, Naina asked, “Was he lying?”

Aniruddh said, “I do not know.”

“But?”

“But his ‘yes’ may be weaker than Mrinalini’s ‘perhaps’ if the documents say something else.”

Mayank smiled. “Testimony again.”

From outside, Rohit called, “One day you people will make criminals surrender by teaching them philosophy.”



The first legal action against Digant was not for murder, but for financial irregularities.

On the basis of three suspicious consultancy payments, fabricated programmes, misuse of a cooperative account, and post-tender adjustments, transactions in several accounts were temporarily frozen.

The news became public.

Devanshu Rakshit stood before the press.

“We work for development. Rival business groups are making false allegations. We welcome the investigation.”

He did not name the police.

He did not criticise the government.

Civil language.

That night, anonymous accounts began posting about Aniruddh Chaudhary on social media—

‘Anti-contractor officer.’

‘Driving investors away.’

‘Targeting companies of one particular community.’

‘Action taken on political orders.’

Some posts included old photographs of his family.

Aniruddh’s wife called. “Where did these people get my photograph?”

Aniruddh did not answer.

“They have even written the name of the child’s school.”

At that moment it was not the investigator but the father inside Aniruddh who awoke.

Anger.

Fear.

The immediate desire to retaliate.

Then he restrained himself.

For months he had warned others against precisely this—‘Do not decide first.’ Now the same rule was being tested inside his own home.

It had not been proved that Digant had arranged the posts.

They might be supporters.

They might be opponents.

They might merely be rumour-mongers.

He increased security for his family, but he did not turn the posts into evidence against Digant.

He did not go home that night.

He sat alone in the darkened office.

Mayank brought tea late at night.

“Difficult?”

Aniruddh did not smile.

“When you apply the rule to someone else, it is philosophy. The moment you see danger to your own child, the same rule becomes a burden.”

Mayank remained silent.

“That is why justice must rest on institutions, not on individuals,” he said at last. “Every individual will break somewhere.”

Aniruddh looked out of the window.

“And institutions?”

“They are made by individuals. That is why it is difficult.”



The day Pranavesh was brought before the court to give his statement, the weather was bad.

Rain.

The courthouse verandah was packed with people.

Security had been tightened.

His testimony was not made public at once, but word travelled through the criminal world—the man from inside Digant was talking.

That evening his wife Ranjana called again.

“Our son has a fever,” she said. “He wants to speak to you.”

Pranavesh put the phone to his ear.

An eight-year-old voice came from the other end. “Baba, when are you coming home?”

Pranavesh could not answer.

“Baba?”

“Soon.”

A lie.

He knew that soon was impossible.

Testimony, investigation, possible prosecution—he himself might also become an accused.

The child asked, “Mummy says you worked with bad people?”

Pranavesh’s face went blank.

“I made mistakes.”

“Are you bad?”

At that question tears came to his eyes.

“I am your father.”

Whether that answer was enough for the child, no one knew.

The call ended.

Pranavesh remained silent for a long time.

This too is one form of tragedy: the law classifies crimes; a child classifies only the person.



An old vehicle coordinator from Digant unexpectedly presented himself—Rajan Chaurasia.

He said that during the week of Satyaprakash’s accident, a heavy vehicle had been arranged through him.

“For whom?”

“In the name of one of Digant’s subcontractors.”

“The driver?”

“Anil Mahto.”

“Where is he now?”

Rajan fell silent.

“Tell me.”

“Dead.”

“When?”

“About two months after the accident. A boat overturned across the river. Three people drowned.”

Rohit almost rose from his chair.

“Was that the truck in Satyaprakash’s accident?”

“I don’t know.”

“Did Anil ever say anything?”

“Once, when he was drunk, he said, ‘The work I was given wasn’t road work.’”

The room grew heavy.

Aniruddh continued questioning him.

“Those exact words?”

“That is all I remember.”

“Who was present?”

“Me and two drivers.”

“Who were the two drivers?”

One was alive. One had gone abroad.

The living driver was found.

He did not remember Anil making any such statement.

“He drank a lot. He used to say all kinds of things.”

Rajan’s testimony stood alone.

Anil was dead.

The vehicle was missing.

There was no direct evidence.

The line that seemed to lead toward murder vanished once again into fog.

When Mrinalini was told this, she asked only, “So Baba’s death is an accident again?”

Aniruddh said, “I am still not certain.”

She laughed.

A hard, exhausted laugh.

“Your ‘I am not certain’ has become the longest sentence of my life.”



Several months passed.

The economic-crime case against Digant grew stronger.

Several contractors gave statements—pressure to withdraw tenders, percentages, fictitious services.

Some remained silent.

Some said, “We paid voluntarily.”

Some had already burned their old slips.

Some slips survived, but their meaning was disputed.

There was still no direct evidence of murder against Devanshu Rakshit.

Pranavesh called him the centre of the economic network, but he had not heard Devanshu order the ‘different measure’ mentioned against Satyaprakash.

The prosecution team divided over the question.

Someone said, “Add Satyaprakash’s death to the conspiracy as well.”

Aniruddh opposed it.

“The suspicion is deep. The evidence is incomplete.”

A senior legal officer said, “There is no jury. Let the judge assess it.”

“But we are the ones who will bring the charge.”

“Look at the network as a whole.”

“My desire to see a complete network cannot fill the empty spaces in the evidence.”

The meeting ended in tension.

Outside, Rohit asked, “Sir, if we added murder, the pressure would increase.”

“It would.”

“Devanshu might break.”

“Possible.”

“Then why not?”

Aniruddh stopped.

“The law does not bring charges merely to manufacture pressure. If we do that, the difference between the methods of the criminal and the methods of the State grows smaller.”

Rohit said nothing.

The answer sounded idealistic.

But tragedy has another cause too: the right rule does not always produce an immediate result.



Devanshu Rakshit was eventually arrested on charges of economic conspiracy, documentary fraud, extortion, and manipulation of tenders.

The arrest took place in his office.

No gunfire.

No chase.

No dramatic cordon.

He called his lawyer, removed his watch and handed it to an assistant, then looked at Aniruddh.

“So at last you wrote my name down.”

Aniruddh said, “In the economic case.”

Devanshu smiled.

“Satyaprakash?”

“The investigation continues.”

“Meaning you still do not believe I am the one responsible?”

“What I believe or do not believe is irrelevant. What is proved—that is what matters.”

Devanshu looked at him for several moments.

“I cannot decide whether men like you are good for the State or dangerous to it.”

Aniruddh did not answer.

Devanshu got into the police vehicle.

The news spread through the city—‘A big man has been caught.’

Some people were pleased.

Some were afraid.

Some phones were switched off at once.

Some files disappeared during the night.

Some money moved from one account to another.

And that same week a small subsidiary of Ambar Sports Media—‘Ambar Interactive’—was registered.

Naina saw the information.

She merely circled the date.

Some changes are coincidence.

Some changes are reactions to fear.

It was too soon to decide.



For the first time after Devanshu’s arrest, people came to Satyaprakash’s house carrying sweets.

Mrinalini sent the box back.

“Nothing has been proved yet.”

A neighbour said, “The main man is in jail.”

“Has the court said why my husband died?”

“No.”

“Then why the sweets?”

The box went back.

Ishaan watched his mother.

That night he asked, “You aren’t happy?”

“One man going to jail does not bring your father back.”

“But justice has begun?”

After a long while Mrinalini said, “Perhaps.”

Ishaan did not smile.

He had learned the word ‘perhaps’ too.



The case went to court.

Hundreds of pages of accounts, contractors’ statements, proof of fabricated programmes, flows through the cooperative account, Pranavesh’s admissions.

The defence had a clear set of arguments—

‘Commercial consultancy has simply been renamed extortion.’

‘Rival companies have given statements out of revenge.’

‘Pranavesh is blaming his employer to reduce his own culpability.’

‘Fabricated programmes may amount to administrative negligence.’

None of these arguments was wholly false.

That was what made them difficult.

The true work of a court is often precisely this: a place where everything on one side is not false and everything on the other is not true.

One day Mayank explained to Ishaan, who was now in the final years of adolescence, “In Nyāya, *hetvābhāsa* is not merely foolish reasoning. Often the reason sounds true, yet is not fit to carry you all the way to the conclusion.”

Ishaan asked, “For example?”

“For example: Devanshu has proved to be a serious economic offender; therefore he also killed your father. It is possible, but it does not prove itself.”

Ishaan’s face hardened.

“I don’t like that.”

“Truth does not change according to what we like.”

“And justice?”

“Nor should justice.”

Ishaan looked out of the window.

“Then many truths will remain without punishment.”

Mayank drew a long breath.

“Yes.”

For the first time Ishaan understood that Nyāya was not a philosophy of victory.

At times it was a philosophy of acceptance—the acceptance that what has not been proved cannot be declared true merely because one longs for it to be true.

There was a deep tragedy in that acceptance.



Devanshu was convicted in the economic case.

Obstructing tender competition, extracting payments through fear, fabricated service records, financial fraud—the court accepted the prosecution's evidence on these points.

Some co-accused were acquitted.

Lesser offences were proved against some.

Pranavesh himself was not freed from punishment; his cooperation reduced the sentence.

Devanshu received imprisonment and a financial penalty.

But the death of Satyaprakash Karna—in a separate investigation—remained unresolved.

Murder was not proved.

Nor was the ordinariness of the accident wholly credible.

The file was marked: 'To be re-examined upon receipt of additional evidence.'

Mrinalini read the line.

She folded the paper.

"That is all?"

Aniruddh sat before her.

"For now, that is all."

"The men who pressured my husband are guilty. The network that surrounded him has been proved. But his death?"

"Not proved."

"Then what am I supposed to believe?"

Aniruddh had no answer to that question.

Mrinalini stood up.

At the door she turned back.

"Chaudharyji, you did not bring a false charge. Perhaps you were right. But that rightness gives me no peace."

Aniruddh lowered his head.

"I understand."

"No. You cannot understand."

She left.

Aniruddh accepted that she was right.

Correct legal process does not feel the victim's grief.

It can only try not to insult it.



Kanhaiya Rajak's name was formally cleared.

The police gave him a written letter stating that there was no criminal basis against him.

But Neha's former marriage arrangement did not return.

Kanhaiya's business remained half what it had been.

He did not frame the letter and hang it in his shop.

He put it in a drawer.

"No one asks to see proof that a name has been cleared," he told Rohit. "Everyone reads the news of the stain."

After this case, Rohit changed the way he spoke to newspaper people.

An innocent man had taught him a lesson in law that the training academy had not.



Mohan Paswan's family received compensation.

Sarojini opened a small shop.

Her daughter left school and sat with her mother for several months, then returned under pressure from her teacher.

In the file this was 'rehabilitation'.

In Sarojini's life it was only a new arrangement of deprivation.

Once she said to Aniruddh—

"The government gave money. Fine. But even now, when the children hear a door open at night, they think their father has come home."

Again Aniruddh had no answer.

Very often tragedy begins after the court has delivered its judgment.



Years passed.

The name Digant gradually disappeared from the market.

Some former employees went to other companies.

Some into politics.

Some into small businesses.

Pravahi closed.

Loksetu changed its name and became a social-communications organisation.

Ambar Sports Media, by contrast, kept growing.

The little digital plan that had existed at the time of Devanshu's arrest now carried live results of local sports, advertisements, sports communities, and competition registrations across many districts of the state.

Vihan Sarang became a publicly honoured entrepreneur.

He donated sports kits to schools.

Jobs to young people.

Sponsorships to small clubs.

On paper, his old financial relationship with Digant had ended.

Aniruddh's investigation too was almost over.

One day, while closing an old file, Naina looked at the page on Ambar.

"Shall we let this name go?"

Aniruddh asked, "Any crime?"

"No."

"Then let it go."

Naina closed the file.

The decision was lawful.

And incomplete in the light of the future.

But human beings cannot act in the present upon evidence that belongs to the future.

That limitation too is called justice.



In Garh Narikel, Ishaan reached the age for college.

He did not choose the construction business like his father.

He studied mathematics.

Then data science.

At first Mrinalini worried. "Will you sit in front of computers day and night?"

Ishaan laughed. "A computer is not a snake, Ma."

From the verandah Dhaneshwari said, "A machine is not a snake. But a snake can enter a machine."

Ishaan smiled at his grandmother's folk wisdom.

He did not know that a few years later his studies, his father's death, the little slip bearing Ambar's name, and that old mongoose beside the Kamla-Balan would all meet again inside the same story.

For now, the story was merely changing waters.



Ambar's new application was released to the public.

At first, only sports results.

Then: 'Build your own team.'

Choose players.

Score points according to performance.

Sponsored prizes for monthly winners.

Legal advice was obtained. The rules described it as a 'skill-based competition'.

For many people it was entertainment.

Young men in small towns spent their nights studying player statistics.

Scores were debated at tea stalls.

Local clubs began listing their competitions on Ambar.

Within a few months there were hundreds of thousands of registrations.

For the company, it was a success.

But success brought new questions—where would prize money come from? Should there be user fees? Which states had different laws? How far could advertising go with the word 'win?'

Ambar's new finance chief said, "We will not take direct bets. Entry fees, competitions, incentives—everything within a lawful structure."

An old colleague asked, "Will people play in order to win money?"

Vihan replied, "People will come for entertainment. Money is only an attraction."

The sentence sounded simple.

Not criminal.

Not unlawful.

Yet many tragedies begin with sentences that on the first day seem completely true.



A new institution joined the financial investors in Ambar Interactive —'Uttarayan Digital Holding'.

Ownership lay behind several layers.

On paper, the capital was legitimate.

The audits were regular.

By then Naina Verma had moved to another department. Aniruddh's joint cell had been dissolved.

The old files were in the archives.

No one saw any reason to connect this investor with Digant's old network.

There was no direct connection.

But one director of Uttarayan had once been a small shareholder in Loksetu Public Relations.

He had sold that share five years earlier.

In the eyes of law, the relationship had ended.

In the eyes of history, the thread remained.

The monitor lizard had left one landing place and descended at another.

This time there was no mud on its body—only the gleam of an application icon.



A year later, at half past midnight in a university hostel in the capital, a student said to his friend—

“I’ll put in just five hundred. If I lose, I’ll stop.”

His friend laughed. “It isn’t gambling, man. It’s a sports competition.”

The mobile screen glowed.

The money went in as an official competition fee.

The next day the student won two thousand.

On the third day he lost five thousand.

A week later he borrowed from a friend.

Nowhere in the company’s rules did it say, ‘Borrow money and play.’

No one compelled him.

But after every loss, the application showed him a new competition —‘Next opportunity.’

One screen.

One hope.

One small fee.

Then another.

The student’s name was Abhishek Jha.

He would not become the principal criminal of this story.

He was merely the first face through whom the reader would begin to feel the true temperature of the digital water.

That night his mother called from a village near Garh Narikel. “Is your study going well?”

Abhishek said, “Yes.”

A very small lie.

But this time the network was not outside the house. It was in the palm of the hand.



Dhaneshwari had grown very old beside the Kamla-Balan.

When Ishaan came home for the holidays, he went walking with her one evening.

In the distance a mongoose leapt from the bushes and crossed the path.

Dhaneshwari's eyes were weak now, but she recognised it.

"Did you see?"

Ishaan laughed. "Your mongoose still keeps watch?"

"Not mine. Its own."

A little farther away, the head of a monitor lizard rose from the water for a moment, then disappeared again.

Dhaneshwari said, "If the monitor lizard is in the water, the mongoose cannot catch it."

Ishaan asked, "Then the story is wrong?"

"No. The mongoose is not there to fight the monitor lizard. The mongoose keeps snakes from entering the house. For the monitor lizard, you need someone who knows the landing."

"Who knows the landing?"

Dhaneshwari looked at Ishaan.

"The one who can read the water."

Ishaan did not laugh at that answer.

His phone vibrated in the distance.

It was an email offering him a new job at a financial data-analysis company in the capital.

He did not know that one of the first major clients in that job would be Ambar Interactive.

He did not know that a small name written in the old investigation into his father's death would come alive before him again.

He did not know that the skill of reading water, which he thought of as a profession, would one day become a bridge between his family's unfinished grief, thousands of unknown bank accounts, online gambling, money laundering, and a national investigation.

Dhaneshwari kept looking at the river.

"Do not leave the bank," she said very softly.

Whether Ishaan heard her or not, the wind was strong.

But the mongoose's small footprints were clear in the mud.

The watch was no longer to be kept over the old crime, but over new water.



Ishaan's new office occupied a glass-fronted commercial building in the capital.

Its name was ‘Sutralekh Financial Analytics’.

The company examined data from banks, insurance institutions, digital businesses, and payment platforms to detect signals of risk. The job appealed to Ishaan. He had loved numbers since childhood. Numbers neither abused nor threatened. They remained what they were.

But by the third week of the job he understood: numbers themselves do not lie, yet the person looking at them can certainly manufacture a false meaning.

In the training room, senior analyst Sumedha Ghosh wrote on the board

—
‘Abnormal ≠ criminal.’

Then beneath it—

‘Normal ≠ innocent.’

Ishaan smiled.

Mayank Jha’s words came back to him.

Sumedha asked, “Something amusing?”

“No. It reminded me of something old from home.”

“Good. Bring as little of home as possible into this work. First listen to what the data says.”

Ishaan nodded.

Two days later his first major client file was placed before him.

The moment he read the company’s name, his hand stopped for an instant—

Ambar Interactive.

The same name.

His father’s old slip.

‘Ambar—called twice.’

Ishaan stared at the name in the light of the screen for a long time.

Sumedha read his face. “You know it?”

Ishaan could have lied.

He did not.

“The name appeared in an old family file.”

“A dispute?”

“Not certain.”

Sumedha did not immediately take the file out of his hands. She only asked, “Do you think this means you cannot remain impartial?”

Ishaan searched for an answer.

“I will try.”

“The question is not whether you will try. The question is whether you understand the bias.”

Ishaan said slowly, "I am suspicious of this name. I have no evidence."

Sumedha leaned back in her chair.

"Then make that sentence your rule. Do not turn suspicion into evidence."

The file remained with Ishaan.



Ambar Interactive was no longer merely an application for sports results.

Its advertisements appeared everywhere - cricket matches, kabaddi, football, mobile games. Users built their own teams, paid entry fees for contests, and received prizes according to the points they accumulated. The company repeatedly insisted that these were "skill-based contests", not gambling.

The paperwork of the main application was orderly. Taxes paid. User rules. Customer support. Advertising contracts.

Ambar itself had called in Sutralekh because, during the previous six months, banks had begun blocking many payments. Some users complained: "I won money, but I could not withdraw it." Some banks reported that unusual sums were entering numerous small accounts of the same kind and then moving elsewhere almost immediately.

Vihan Sarang, Ambar's founder, came to the meeting himself.

His beard was neatly trimmed. He wore a pale grey kurta and an expensive watch, though without ostentation. His voice was low and measured.

"Do not look at me as though I were a criminal," he said at the beginning of the meeting. "My problem is that our popularity has grown faster than our control over it."

Sumedha replied, "We are not looking at the person. We are looking at the flow."

Vihan smiled. "That is precisely why I called you."

Ishaan sat silently.

Vihan did not recognise him.

That was natural.

What significance could two telephone calls from a small contractor years ago have in the vast history of a company?

For Ishaan, those two words remained an unfinished question placed beside his father's death.

But to place a question and a memory together on the same screen was dangerous.

He pushed his father's slip out of his mind and opened the data.



Nothing remarkable appeared during the first week.

Two hundred thousand users. Thousands of contests. Hundreds of thousands of small payments. Most of the flows were ordinary.

But one category caught Ishaan's attention.

"Promotional-support payments."

The sums were not very large. They went into the accounts of different individuals. Sometimes five thousand. Sometimes twelve. Sometimes thirty. The descriptions read: local promotion, user support, contest operations.

Ambar said that it retained "community associates" in smaller towns.

That could be a perfectly reasonable business structure.

Ishaan noted only one thing: the occupations of some account holders did not seem to fit the work.

An elderly farmer.

A homemaker.

A student.

A rickshaw driver.

A small grocery-shop owner.

"People take on extra work," Sumedha said.

"Yes."

"Then?"

"Nothing. I am only grouping the accounts."

Ishaan placed them on a separate list.

Three days later a second pattern appeared.

In some accounts, money received from Ambar did not remain there. Within a very short time it moved onward.

Where it went, the data available to Ishaan did not fully reveal. Because of banking confidentiality, Sutralekh had been given only a limited view.

He could not draw a conclusion.

But he could write down a question -

"Why does the remuneration of a person doing promotional work move almost immediately into another account?"



Meanwhile, Abhishek Jha had not slept properly for three nights in his hostel room.

He had begun with five hundred rupees.

A few wins.

Then losses.

Then the desire to "win back what was lost".

On the mobile screen, every contest looked like a new beginning.
His friends said, "The team was wrong today. Wait till tomorrow."
Abhishek told himself that this was skill, not chance. Therefore, if he was losing, the flaw lay in his analysis. Next time he would improve.
There was a hidden trap in that reasoning.
If he won - talent.
If he lost - more effort was required.
In neither case was there any place for the word "stop".
By the end of the month, most of his scholarship money was gone.
His mother asked over the phone, "Do you still have money left?"
"Yes."
A second lie.
Then one day his hostel friend Ritesh Das said, "Want to earn something?"
Abhishek laughed. "Where is the work?"
"No work. I need an account."
"What?"
Ritesh lowered his voice.
"Promotional payments come from a digital company. There are limits on the accounts. They will use yours. You get a commission."
Abhishek became cautious. "Illegal?"
"Oh, no. The company pays you. You send the money onward. That is all."
"Why?"
"Business arrangement. How would I know?"
One voice inside Abhishek said no.
Another said that three weeks of losses could be recovered in a day or two.
He did not say yes immediately.
He thought about it through the night.
In the morning another contest notification appeared on his phone.
He remembered the money he had lost.
That afternoon he messaged Ritesh -
"How much commission?"
With that question, another door opened.



The expression "mule account" appeared nowhere in Ambar's official system.
Sumedha was the first to raise the possibility.

“Money-carrier accounts,” she said. “In many fraud networks, people effectively rent out their accounts. Some know what they are doing. Some think it is a job. Some do it only for the commission.”

Ishaan asked, “These accounts?”

“We cannot say that yet.”

“But the behaviour?”

“Worthy of suspicion.”

Sutralekh asked Ambar for a detailed list: contracts of all community associates, identity documents, descriptions of their work, and the basis of their payments.

The response arrived.

Some files were complete.

Some incomplete.

Some carried signatures of strikingly similar form.

Some telephone numbers had been disconnected.

In several cases Ambar itself said, “We did not appoint these people directly; they came through an external promotional agency.”

The agency was called “Lokvistar Digital Services”.

When Ishaan read the name, he remembered the old “Loksetu” from his father’s investigation.

The words resembled one another.

Nothing more.

Similarity of names was not a connection.

He wrote a note to himself -

“Do not treat similarity of names as evidence.”

Then he checked the company registration.

Lokvistar was five years old.

It had two directors.

One of them had previously worked as a contracted programme coordinator for Ambar Sports Media.

This time the connection was real.

But it was still not a crime.



Ritesh brought the first payment into Abhishek’s account.

Twelve thousand rupees.

Abhishek’s share was one thousand.

He was told to send the rest to a specified merchant account.

“Why does the company not send it directly?” he asked.

Ritesh snapped, “Do you want the money, or do you want to conduct an audit?”

Abhishek fell silent.

One thousand rupees was not a small sum for him.

He followed the instruction.

Two days later, again.

Then a third time.

The amounts changed.

The commission increased.

Abhishek recovered part of the scholarship money he had lost.

He felt as though he had found a way out.

When a person obtains a little relief through the wrong door, it becomes difficult to call that door wrong.

A week later Ritesh said, “We need another account. Any friend of yours?”

Abhishek refused at once.

Ritesh laughed. “You do it yourself. Why is it wrong for someone else?”

The question cut deep into Abhishek.

He did not answer.

But the next day he told an unemployed classmate, “There is some promotional work.”

At that moment Abhishek ceased to be merely a carrier of money.

He became a small knot in the network.



Sutralekh’s interim report was uncomfortable reading for Ambar.

“Weak identity verification in community-associate payments.”

“Unusually rapid outward movement in certain accounts.”

“Excessive dependence upon an external agency.”

“Several discrepancies between descriptions of work and the payments made.”

Vihan Sarang read the report in the meeting and remained silent.

Then he said, “You are criminalising us.”

Sumedha remained calm. “The word crime does not appear even once in the report.”

“You have written ‘mule accounts’.”

“We have written ‘possible money-carrier behaviour’.”

“A game of language.”

Ishaan spoke for the first time. “A difference of language can change an entire life in court.”

Vihan looked at him.

“You are new?”

“Yes.”

“And very certain.”

“No. That is precisely why those words were chosen.”

For an instant Vihan’s eyes hardened, then returned to normal.

“Very well. We will review the contracts. The external agency can be removed if necessary.”

The meeting ended.

Outside, Sumedha stopped Ishaan.

“No personal tone.”

“I -”

“What you said was not wrong. The tone was personal.”

Ishaan said nothing.

“The name Ambar is still your father’s file inside you.”

Ishaan admitted, “Yes.”

“Then be careful. Even if you find the truth, prejudice can diminish its value.”



Not everyone inside Ambar knew the same things.

The technical team that ran the main application worked on the rules of lawful contests. Customer-support staff struggled with delayed prizes, account verification, and errors of identity. The marketing team made advertisements.

But a parallel business was run by a separate group - the “Night Room”.

The name was not official.

It was used in private groups of trusted agents.

There, contests increasingly became only a pretext. Users put money on actual sporting results; the odds shifted; wins and losses were settled immediately. On paper, these activities lay outside Ambar’s main application. In practice, its agents, promotional structure, and network of money carriers traded upon the trust created by the same brand.

Whether Vihan knew every detail of this was not yet certain even within the narrative.

But Ambar’s finance chief, Keshav Mehta, knew.

Keshav’s reasoning was simple -

“Keep the main company clean. Let the external network bear its own risk.”

An associate asked, “But where does the money finally go?”

“Into business.”

“Whose?”

Keshav smiled.

“Wherever it becomes clean.”

The greatest illusion of money laundering is that dirty money becomes truly clean at some particular moment.

In reality, only its story changes.



One Monday morning, Abhishek’s bank froze his account.

A message appeared on his phone: “Debit restricted.”

He ran to the branch.

The manager said, “There is an instruction connected with a cyber complaint.”

“Whose complaint?”

“I cannot disclose the details.”

“My money?”

“Frozen for now.”

Abhishek’s face went white.

The account did not contain only Ritesh’s money.

It also contained eight thousand rupees sent by his mother.

The final instalment of his university scholarship was there as well.

Part of the money kept aside at home for his younger sister Manjari’s nursing admission had also been placed temporarily in Abhishek’s account because their father’s old account was inactive.

“Sir, this is my family’s money.”

The manager’s face was not hard, only helpless.

“Submit an application to the investigating officer.”

“I have done nothing wrong.”

The manager looked at him.

“Did you know about the money that was entering your account?”

Abhishek fell silent.

The answer to that question was trapped somewhere between yes and no.

He knew the money belonged to someone else.

He did not know whose crime it belonged to.

The law would investigate that difference.

But Manjari’s admission date would not wait for the law to finish its investigation.



Manjari lost her admission.

The college rejected the request for an extension.

His mother did not cry over the telephone. She merely said, "Son, it is all right. Next year."

That "all right" broke something in Abhishek's chest.

He went looking for Ritesh.

The hostel room was empty.

The phone was switched off.

The social-media account had vanished.

Friends said he had gone home two days earlier.

Where that home was, no one knew exactly.

For the first time Abhishek understood that the people above a network remain invisible; the accounts below are opened in their own names.

Whoever owns the serpent's fangs, the poison is first found in the body that can be caught.

That night he sat on the hostel roof for a long time.

The city lights below.

The bank's freeze message on his phone.

His mother's words: "Next year."

He did not make a decision to kill himself.

Tragedy does not always mean death.

Sometimes a person remains alive and carries the weight of one decision every day.

Abhishek sat there until dawn.

In the morning he decided to go to the cyber police station.



At the cyber police station in the capital city, Inspector Rachna Sinha took Abhishek's statement.

"You used to send the money onward?"

"Yes."

"For a commission?"

"Yes."

"Did you understand what the work was?"

"Promotion."

"Promotion for whom?"

"Ambar... I mean, people from a company, that is what I was told."

"Directly from the company?"

"No. Ritesh."

"Who gave it to Ritesh?"

“I do not know.”

Rachna looked at him for a long time.

“I am not going to tell you at this stage that you are innocent.”

Abhishek’s eyes filled.

“I am not a thief.”

“A thief and a money carrier are not the same thing. But if you kept forwarding money for a commission without knowing whose money it was, questions will arise.”

“Will I go to jail?”

Rachna did not answer.

“Tell the truth. Give us the phone, the messages, everything you have. The sooner you stop lying, the sooner we can understand what your role actually was.”

Abhishek handed over his phone.

Rachna saw a message from his mother: “Remember the date of Manjari’s admission.”

She switched off the screen.

For an officer, compassion cannot become judgment.

But without compassion, an investigation turns a human being into nothing more than an account number.



Abhishek’s phone did not immediately lead Rachna to any major criminal.

Ritesh’s changing numbers. A few group messages. Generic instructions from something called “Payment Support”. Several bank accounts.

Some of those accounts had already been flagged in unrelated cyber complaints from different parts of the country.

Rachna sent the information to the State Cyber Coordination Centre.

By then Sutralekh’s interim report had also reached the banks.

Two different roads were moving toward the same question.

On one side, private risk analysis.

On the other, complaints from victims.

So far the two did not know of one another.

In Nyaya philosophy, the force of inference depends upon vyapti - the dependable concomitance by which, where there is smoke, there is fire, if that relation has been reliably established.

In modern financial crime there are a thousand kinds of smoke. Not every rapid transfer is a crime. Not every new account is a mule. Not every game that resembles gambling is illegal gambling.

So the difficulty of investigation is not simply: “We have seen smoke.”

The difficulty is this - how many different plumes of smoke are in fact rising from the same fire?



Ishaan's team found a new pattern in the data.

Ambar's official contest payments and Lokvistar's promotional payments were said to be wholly separate.

But on certain days, an unusual rise in user fees was followed by a rise in Lokvistar's "associate payments" as well.

"It could be a seasonal effect," Sumedha said. "More users on match days, therefore more promotion."

"Yes."

This time Ishaan did not become excited.

He examined the data over a longer period.

Then by city.

Then by agent.

In some groups, the relation was ordinary.

But in three districts, "promotional payments" did not rise with user activity. They rose after certain unexplained waves of digital deposits.

"Here the promotional expenditure is not moving with the number of customers," Ishaan said.

Sumedha came closer to the screen.

"Then what is it moving with?"

Ishaan did not give a firm answer.

"Perhaps another source of income."

"Perhaps."

They remained silent for a while.

Then Sumedha said, "At this point we ask the client for an explanation."

Ambar replied that local campaigns operated on independent budgets.

Commercially, that was possible.

But when documents were requested, Lokvistar asked for three weeks' time.

Asking for time was not a crime.

But in Ishaan's mind, the water stirred again.



Mrinalini now ran a small bookshop in Garh Narikel.

After Satyaprakash's death, the construction business had gradually closed.

The shop was called "Satya Pustakalaya" - the Library of Truth.

People sometimes asked, “Named after your husband?”

She would answer, “Named after truth.”

One evening Ishaan telephoned her.

“Ma, do you remember Baba’s old slip? The one about Ambar?”

Mrinalini immediately fell silent.

“Why?”

“They are my client.”

“Are you working on a case?”

“No. Data review.”

“Stay away from that name.”

Ishaan was startled. “Why?”

“I do not want to see you in the same water again.”

“Ma, this is my job.”

“For your father too, it was only work.”

Ishaan wanted to answer that the two things were not the same.

But his mother’s fear was not an argument.

Fear was memory.

“I will be careful.”

Mrinalini said softly, “Carefulness does not save us every time.”

After the call ended, Ishaan stared at the screen for a long while.

In the story of the mongoose, the guardian does not fear the snake.

But in the guardian’s human home, there is a mother who fears for the guardian.



At the State Cyber Centre, Abhishek’s statement was compared with other complaints.

Some victims said, “I put money on online matches and did not receive the winnings.”

Some said, “For a ‘job’, I allowed my bank account to be used, and later the account was frozen.”

Some said there had been no gambling at all, only the renting of an account.

Some were themselves agents.

Different roles within one network.

Inspector Rachna Sinha wrote to the State Economic Offences Branch -

“Multiple complaints indicate common payment intermediaries and the same cluster of promotional agencies.”

The file reached Aditya Shekhar, an officer with an economics background.

When the name came up, an old service friend of Rohit's said, "A young man named Ishaan Karn is looking at similar data in a private firm."

Very slowly, the thread of the old investigation began to join itself again.

Aniruddh Chaudhary was no longer in active government service. After retirement, he gave guest lectures at a law-enforcement training institute in the capital city.

Aditya telephoned him.

"Sir, I need to ask about a name - Ambar."

Silence at the other end.

"Ambar Interactive?" Aniruddh asked.

"Yes."

"Pull out the old file."

"Was there something in it?"

"Nothing criminal was proved."

"Then?"

"There was history."

Aniruddh's first sentence became the rule of the new investigation -

"Do not turn old suspicion into new evidence; but do not forget old history."



Meanwhile, Ambar's "Night Room" was expanding rapidly.

Advertising by the main brand created trust. Agents moved familiar users into private groups. There, the line between skill contests and direct betting became blurred.

Laws differed from state to state. In some places there were explicit prohibitions.

Keshav Mehta sought the solution not by changing the law, but by changing the structure.

"The main company's accounts will not be used."

Money moved through small private accounts. Some of it took the form of business payments. Some became advertising. Some consultancy. Some purchases of goods.

The story changed.

The money remained the same.

Investigators would piece together these details later. For the moment, the people inside the network themselves called the arrangement "risk distribution".

In criminal language, money laundering often becomes "adjustment".

Words lighten the moral weight of crime.

Just as, in the old tender network, extortion had been called “local cooperation”.

The water had changed.

The language had not.



For the first time, Ishaan saw the old Digant file in digital form.

Aniruddh himself had called him.

They met in the library of the training institute.

Aniruddh’s hair was now almost entirely white. His gait had slowed. His voice remained measured.

“Do you remember when I came to your house?”

“I was very young.”

“You did not like me.”

“I am still not certain.”

Aniruddh laughed.

A question that had lived in Ishaan for years rose to the surface. “Why did you close Baba’s file?”

Aniruddh stopped smiling.

“Because I could not call proved what had not been proved.”

“Still the same answer.”

“Still the same truth.”

Ishaan remained silent for a long time.

Then he opened his laptop.

He showed Aniruddh the new Ambar data.

Aniruddh studied it carefully.

“This is not my field.”

“But the old names are.”

Aniruddh opened the file.

Scans from years ago. Ambar Sports Media. Digant’s sports festival. The former director of Uttarayan Digital Holding. Loksetu’s small shareholding.

“Only this much.”

“And Baba’s slip,” Ishaan said.

“That too - only this much.”

“Do you think there is a connection?”

Aniruddh looked into his eyes.

“I think there is a question.”

“An answer?”

“You want an answer too quickly.”

Ishaan’s voice turned bitter. “I have lived for twenty years without one.”

Aniruddh was silent.

Then he said quietly, "That is precisely why you should not become the centre of the investigation. Remain an analyst. Give them what you see. Revenge makes the intellect very sharp - and very blind."

Ishaan started to rise, then stopped.

"Does Nyaya philosophy teach every victim nothing but patience?"

"No. It teaches the investigator limits."

"And the victim?"

Aniruddh took a long breath.

"Sometimes only this painful fact - the desire for truth and the evidence for truth are not the same thing."



Abhishek was in the process of becoming a cooperating witness, but his life did not return to normal.

The university administration learned of the bank investigation. Whispers spread through the hostel.

"He sells bank accounts."

"Online gambling."

"Police informer."

No one knew the whole truth.

One friend stopped eating with him.

One teacher told him privately, "Focus on your studies."

Abhishek could not tell whether the sentence was sympathy or distance.

Manjari continued preparing for admission the following year, but at home she spoke less normally with Abhishek.

One day his sister said on the phone, "Bhaiya, I do not blame you."

Abhishek began to cry at once.

Because the sentence meant there was something for which he could have been blamed.

This too is one form of tragedy: words of forgiveness can themselves confirm the sense of guilt.



Rachna Sinha showed Abhishek a photograph.

"Ritesh?"

"No."

A second.

"No."

A third.

Abhishek hesitated.

“I have seen this man once.”

“Where?”

“With Ritesh. At the tea stall outside the hostel. I think they called him ‘Mannu Bhaiya’.”

“Full name?”

“No.”

The man in the photograph was Manoj Nayak.

Regional coordinator for Lokvistar Digital Services.

For the first time, a private witness, banking behaviour, and a company contract converged at a single point.

Rachna did not arrest him immediately.

No charge against Manoj had yet been proved.

But surveillance began.

He travelled through three districts. Organised sports competitions. Recruited local youths. Ran digital promotions.

And after each journey, several new bank accounts would appear on the list of “community associates.”

The pattern was becoming clearer.

Even so, Rachna wrote in her file:

“Correlation; causation yet to be established.”

Sometimes the language of investigation is less exciting than a story.

But it is precisely such dull words that protect an innocent person’s life.



Following Manoj Nayak, the police reached a place where, for the first time, gambling appeared in its actual form before them.

In the industrial outskirts of the capital stood a large rented hall. A board outside read: “Digital Customer Support Training.”

Inside were twenty young men. Laptops. Phones. Screens filled with games.

When the police raided the place, there were no guns. No violence.

Some of the youths were genuinely answering customer queries.

Some were recording wagers on games in private groups.

Some were contacting holders of money-mule accounts.

Some were merely typing data for a day’s wages.

Four different degrees of knowledge of the crime existed in the same room.

It would have been easy to call them all criminals alike.

Truth was harder.

Manoj was not found there.

But the computers were seized.

Rachna Sinha told her team, "Record separately what each person knew. Do not turn an employee into an organiser."

One constable asked, "Madam, they were all in the same place."

"A thief and an ordinary passenger can travel on the same bus."

Sometimes the simplest form of Nyāya philosophy descends into a single sentence in a police station.



News of the raid reached the media.

"Online gambling racket."

"Link to a company called Ambar?"

"Thousands of bank accounts?"

"Money laundering worth crores?"

Most of the numbers were estimates.

Ambar immediately issued a press statement:

"The company has no connection with illegal betting. Certain external agents may have misused the brand."

Legally, this was possible.

Vihan Sarang said on a news channel, "I myself will cooperate with the investigating agencies."

Ishaan kept watching the television.

Mrinalini called.

"Is your company involved in this?"

"They are our client."

"Leave it."

"Ma—"

"Your father too must once have said: for now, it is only work."

Ishaan stiffened.

"If I run away, should I abandon every question?"

Mrinalini said very softly, "The answer to some questions is not more important than a son's life."

Ishaan, angry, ended the call.

The moment he did, he regretted it.

He did not have the courage to call again.

That night Mrinalini did not call either.

The first crack opened between home and duty.



Examination of the seized computers brought up a strange name: “Uttarayan.”

Not the company directly. An internal label for a cluster of accounts.

Aditya Shekhar opened the old file.

Uttarayan Digital Holding.

Investor in Ambar.

An old connection to a former Loksetu shareholder.

The dried thread from the Digant investigation became wet again.

He called Aniruddh.

“Sir, history is returning to the present.”

Aniruddh replied, “Not history. A name is returning. Be careful.”

“The difference?”

“A great deal. There may be new people behind an old name.”

“But the former shareholder?”

“A fact. His present role is still a question.”

Aditya laughed. “Retirement has not changed your language.”

“After retirement the language becomes even more cautious. I no longer have a department in which to correct my mistakes.”



Manoj Nayak was finally caught—not while fleeing, but at his own home.

He said, “I conduct legitimate promotions.”

Rachna Sinha placed before him Abhishek’s statement, the account lists, and the messages recovered from the seized office.

Manoj supplied an alternative meaning for every fact.

“The youths were promoters.”

“The accounts were for payments.”

“Private betting happened without my knowledge.”

“Ritesh was a subcontractor.”

“Many people call me Mannu.”

Some of these answers could even be true.

Rachna did not grow impatient.

“Keshav Mehta?”

Manoj’s eyelid paused for a fraction of a second.

“An officer of Ambar.”

“Have you met him?”

“At events.”

“Privately?”

“No.”

Rachna made a note.

The flicker of an eyelid is not evidence.

But it can indicate the direction of the next question.

“The Night Room?”

Manoj looked directly into her eyes for the first time and laughed.

“Is that poetry?”

“Perhaps.”

Rachna laughed too.

“We can read poetry later. For now, read the documents.”



Ishaan’s final analytical report reached Ambar’s board of directors.

Sutralekh stated clearly:

Most payments within the principal competition system were consistent with ordinary commercial behaviour.

But the external promotional structure, behaviour resembling money-mule activity, Lokvistar’s incomplete verification, and certain unidentified revenue flows represented high risk.

“High risk” was not a declaration of crime.

Vihan Sarang stopped at those words.

“If we terminate the Lokvistar contract?”

Sumedha said, “That will not answer the questions raised by past transactions.”

“But the future?”

“The risk may decrease.”

Vihan looked at Ishaan.

“Your personal opinion?”

Ishaan was silent for a moment.

“My personal opinion is of no use in this room.”

Vihan smiled faintly.

“You have learned.”

Ishaan could not tell whether the sentence was praise or mockery.

After the meeting Vihan stopped him alone.

“Karn?”

Ishaan halted.

“Are you Satyaprakash Karn’s son?”

Ishaan’s body went cold.

“Did you know him?”

Vihan rested a hand on the back of a chair.

“Many years ago, he called me twice.”

His father’s slip began pounding in Ishaan’s ears: Ambar—two calls.

“About what?”

“He asked me who the payment for Digant’s sports festival was really meant for. I was a small vendor then. I gave him whatever documents I had received.”

“And then?”

“Nothing after that.”

“He died.”

Vihan lowered his eyes.

“I know.”

“Why did you not tell the police?”

“No one asked me.”

Ishaan’s voice sharpened. “And you did not think it necessary to tell them yourself?”

Vihan too hardened.

“Was any connection between your father’s death and my two phone calls established?”

Ishaan fell silent.

Vihan said quietly, “Does your Nyāya philosophy end here?”

The words struck Ishaan like a slap.

He walked out without answering.



That night, for the first time, Ishaan called not his mother but Aniruddh.

He told him everything.

Aniruddh listened calmly.

“Have Vihan’s statement formally recorded.”

“He knew my father.”

“Two phone calls.”

“Baba had asked him something.”

“Yes.”

“Is that not a major fact?”

“It is a major question.”

“Again the same thing?”

“You want an answer; I want evidence.”

Ishaan shouted into the phone, “I have been hearing these words for twenty years!”

Silence at the other end.

Ishaan’s breathing was rapid.

Aniruddh said softly, “Your anger is justified. Its conclusion is not necessarily so.”

Ishaan ended the call.

This time regret did not come immediately.

Some truths are understood through reasoning.

Some grief refuses to listen to reason.



That same night in Garh Narikel, Mrinalini was closing the shop when she saw a mongoose near the threshold.

Ordinarily she would have smiled.

This time she did not.

The mongoose stood a little distance away. In its mouth hung the lifeless body of a small snake.

Mrinalini watched for a long time.

Dhaneshwari could no longer walk. She lay inside on a cot.

Mrinalini went in and said, “Maaji, the mongoose has come again.”

Dhaneshwari’s eyes were half closed.

“A snake?”

“Dead.”

The old woman said very slowly, “One snake dying does not empty the burrow.”

“Ishaan is in that case.”

Dhaneshwari opened her eyes.

“Is he reading the water?”

“Yes.”

“Then he must remember the bank.”

Mrinalini wanted to cry, but no tears came.

Outside, the mongoose had dropped the snake and vanished into the dark.

Only a thin line of blood remained on the threshold.

A vigil is never entirely clean.

The guardian too must pass close to blood.



At the next meeting of the state investigation, the words “money laundering” were formally written down for the first time.

Aditya Shekhar drew three levels on the board:

Legitimate sports business.

Illegal private wagering.

Money-mule and disguised payments.

Then he said, “We have to establish whether these three merely exist side by side, or form parts of a single purpose.”

Rachna Sinha placed Abhishek’s statement before them.

“There is a connection at the lower level.”

A copy of Sutralekh’s report lay on the table.

“The financial behaviour indicates a connection.”

Aniruddh, present as a special invitee, listened silently.

Someone asked, “Sir, your view?”

“At present there are two possibilities.”

“The first?”

“External criminals are exploiting the brand of Ambar’s legitimate business.”

“The second?”

“Some people inside Ambar are knowingly operating the external network.”

“Which is correct?”

“At present, both remain possible.”

A young officer grew impatient. “Then when do we decide?”

Aniruddh looked toward the window.

“When we find a fact that does not merely weaken one possibility, but makes it impossible.”

Mayank Jha, attending the meeting by video, smiled.

“Bādhita hetvābhāsa.”

The young officer clutched his head.

“Sir, are we supposed to catch criminals or sit an examination in philosophy?”

The room burst into laughter.

For a moment the tension eased.

But outside, the files kept growing.



Five minutes after the meeting ended, Rachna Sinha’s phone rang.

A bank officer.

“Madam, there is something unusual in the account list you sent.”

“What?”

“Some final transfers from the money-mule accounts went to a construction-material company.”

“Name?”

“Neelkanth Aggregates Private Limited.”

Aditya immediately opened the old Digant file.

Neelkanth Aggregates—years ago a supplier of stone aggregate to one of Digant’s projects.

The owner had changed.

The directors had changed.

The company conducted legitimate business.

But the thread of history stood before them once again.

Aniruddh studied the document for a long time.

“This may be a connection.”

Rachna said, “Or a coincidence.”

Aniruddh nodded.

“Now all of you have caught the disease.”

No one in the room laughed.

Because everyone could feel it: the water was truly beginning to turn back toward the old landing-place.



Ishaan stood alone that night on the roof of his office.

Below him, the lights of the capital spread like inverted stars in a river.

On his phone was an unread message from his mother: “Eat on time.”

And a message from Aniruddh: “Vihan’s formal statement will be taken tomorrow. You will not be present.”

Ishaan’s first response was anger.

Then he understood: it was right.

He was the witness’s son. He was also an analyst.

Justice did not require every role to be placed in the same room.

He wrote back to his mother: “I am fine. Have you eaten?”

A few moments later came the reply: “Yes.”

Neither of them had lied.

It was a small thing.

But amid tragedy, ordinary truth too is a form of vigilance.

There were clouds far away in the sky.

Ishaan remembered the bank of the Kamla-Balan.

“The one who reads the water.”

He was beginning to understand: reading the water was not merely looking for the monitor lizard’s tracks.

It also meant reading the anger rising inside one’s own eyes.

Otherwise the investigator himself alters the current.



Vihan Sarang’s formal statement the next day lasted four hours.

He acknowledged the two calls from Satyaprakash.

He said Satyaprakash had asked about a payment for one of Digant's sports sponsorships because he suspected that money from construction work was being diverted into pointless events.

Vihan also produced an email from his old records.

The date: three weeks before Satyaprakash's death.

In the email Vihan had written to Satyaprakash: "I am attaching the invoices available to me; I cannot confirm whether the stated services were actually provided."

The record was new.

It had not been part of the old investigation.

Aniruddh stared at the screen for a long time.

"Why did this document not surface then?"

Vihan said, "No one contacted me. Later I learned that the accident had happened. I was afraid. Digant was a very powerful name at the time."

"You remained silent because you were afraid?"

"Yes."

"Was that morally right?"

Vihan's face hardened.

"No."

"Legally?"

"I do not know."

"Why are you saying it now?"

Vihan took a long breath.

"Because twenty years later the same name has come to my door again. And this time I cannot remain silent and still call myself innocent."

Aniruddh now had new evidence before him.

It did not prove Satyaprakash's death.

But it opened a new question: before his death, Satyaprakash had been examining a separate layer of Digant's flow of money.

Ambar had been a witness to that inquiry, not a proven offender.

This distinction would be difficult for Ishaan.

But truth does not change because it is difficult.



That same evening, the state Economic Offences Branch received information from the Centre.

Some money from the online-gambling network had crossed three states and reached accounts, a portion of whose financial trail was already under examination in a separate national-security investigation.

The information was extremely preliminary.

There was no conclusion.

But a possibility had arisen that the matter might no longer remain confined to illegal gambling and money laundering within one state.

Aditya Shekhar did not close the file.

Across the top he wrote: "Inter-agency coordination."

The name was kept internal for the time being.

Because the arrival of a national agency does not automatically make a crime larger.

Sometimes it merely enlarges the circumference of the question.

As they walked out, Aniruddh told Rachna, "From now on, check every word twice."

"Why?"

"When an investigation crosses the boundary of a state, the echo of a mistake also travels farther."

Rachna looked out of the window.

Night was settling over the capital.

Somewhere, on a mobile screen, a wager might still be being placed.

Somewhere, an unemployed young man might be considering giving out his bank account for a "commission."

Somewhere, a family's savings might unknowingly be entering the current of crime.

And very far away, beside the courtyard in Garh Narikel, a mongoose was silently sniffing the air.

The monitor lizard had changed the water.

The cobra was finding new paths into people's homes.

The vigil was no longer going to belong to one village, but to the entire network.



The inter-agency meeting was held not in the capital city, but in Delhi.

The room was plain. A long table. A map of India on the wall. On one side sat officers from the State Economic Offences Branch; on the other, officers of the NIA. There were fewer files in the middle than screens.

At the beginning of the meeting, NIA Superintendent of Police Apoorva Kashyap made one point clear—

"Online gambling is not our case."

Aditya Shekhar nodded.

"I understand."

“Nor does a money-mule account become a national-security matter merely by existing.”

“Yes.”

“We are here only because seven accounts on your list are connected to a financial route whose far end has already appeared in a separate investigation of ours.”

Rachna Sinha asked, “The same beneficiary?”

“No.”

“The same institution?”

“Not that either.”

Apoorva drew three circles on the screen.

First—online gambling.

Second—money-mule accounts.

Third—the NIA’s separate investigation.

Between the three circles lay one small point of overlap.

“That point is a group of financial intermediaries. At present we do not know whether this is a shared service, a shared crime, or merely a coincidence.”

No one in the room used the expression “terror funding.”

One unproved phrase can destroy many lives.

Aniruddh, seated at the back as a special invitee, said quietly—

“A common route does not prove a common purpose.”

Apoorva looked towards him.

“Exactly. And the fact that a national agency is sitting in this meeting does not automatically turn the matter into a national conspiracy.”

Aditya wrote the sentence in his notebook.

The history of investigation contains many tragedies in which the size of an institution was mistaken for the size of the evidence.

This time, they were writing down the limits first.



Of the seven accounts, five were in the names of small businesspeople.

One belonged to a student.

One to a homemaker.

The homemaker’s name was Sabina Khatoon.

She ran a tailoring shop in Madhupur. Bank records showed that over three months, sums many times greater than her ordinary business income had entered and left her account.

Rachna Sinha questioned her over video—

“Did you know about this money?”

Sabina shook her head.

"I was told that payments for an online clothing company would be routed through my account. I would get five thousand a month."

"Who told you?"

"Mehrun."

"Who is Mehrun?"

"My niece's friend."

"Who told her?"

Sabina fell silent.

"I don't know."

"You didn't ask?"

"I did. She said, 'It's digital work. Taxes are paid.'"

Rachna asked, "Why did you agree for five thousand?"

Sabina lowered her eyes.

"The tailoring shop wasn't even earning enough to cover the rent. My daughter was undergoing dental treatment."

One bank account.

Five thousand rupees.

One dental treatment.

In an investigation file, these remain separate lines.

In life, they form a single sentence.

Sabina was not the queen of a criminal network.

Nor could she automatically be declared wholly innocent.

Should she have been suspicious?

Does economic compulsion excuse a failure to know?

Is "I did not know" sufficient?

Nyāya philosophy gives no instant answers to such questions.

It merely insists: keep the questions separate.



The seventh account belonged to a young man who had died a month earlier.

Name—Pawan Raut.

Age—twenty-six.

Home—a small town roughly two hundred kos from the capital city.

Death—a road accident.

Aditya's face tightened.

"Another accident."

Aniruddh stopped him at once. "The word has repeated. The facts have not."

Pawan had fallen from his motorcycle while returning at night. Whether an animal or another vehicle had come in front of him was unclear. The local police had recorded it as an accident. No one in the family had expressed suspicion.

But his bank account now carried a new meaning.

Rachna said, "Do we reopen the death?"

Apoorva Kashyap replied, "Understand the account first. Our job is not to turn a death into a crime."

For an instant, the old road of Satyaprakash's death flashed in Aniruddh's eyes.

Twenty years earlier, the difficulty had been the same.

One death.

One financial network.

And the human mind wanting to join the two at once.

He had not been able to join them then.

The rule remained the same now.



Pawan's mother was drying grain in the courtyard when the team arrived.

"From the bank?" she asked.

"Investigation."

The old woman was frightened.

"Did Pawan do something wrong?"

Rachna answered plainly, "At present, I don't know."

The answer did not bring hope into the mother's eyes; it increased her fear.

For a poor family, "I don't know" often sounds much like "something very serious is wrong."

Pawan's younger brother took out a mobile phone and showed them several messages.

Four months before his death, Pawan had found digital-marketing work. He had been told that his only task was "payment coordination."

Seven thousand a month.

He had asked some of his friends for bank accounts too, but many had refused.

In one message Pawan had written—

"I don't like this work, but I'll do it for two more months. The debt will be paid off."

Rachna looked at the screen for a long time.

"Whose debt?"

His mother said, "His father's medical treatment."

The father lay on a cot inside. After a stroke, he could no longer walk.

Pawan was dead.

The debt remained.

And now there was a bank investigation.

The younger brother asked—

"If Bhaiya turns out to have been a criminal, will he be sent to prison even after his death?"

No one laughed.

Rachna said—

"Not the dead man. But the truth will be written down—as it was."

"And if he was used by others?"

"That will be written too."

The brother asked again—

"Can both be true at the same time?"

Rachna nodded.

"Very often."



At first sight, the office of Neelkanth Aggregates seemed determined to ruin every theory of the investigation.

A real mining licence.

Real trucks.

Real labourers.

Taxes.

Insurance.

Sales.

The company's present director, Arvind Ghosh, did not run from the paperwork.

"I don't understand anything about mule accounts," he said.

"Money entered your account."

"Customer payment."

"From whom?"

"A construction-material broker."

"Name?"

"Sahasra Tradelink."

Mayank Jha, now connected remotely as an adviser, asked—

"Were the goods delivered?"

Arvind immediately produced warehouse challans, weighbridge slips, and tax papers.

The goods had indeed been delivered.

The question became harder.

A money-laundering network does not always create wholly fictitious business.

It may hide a false purpose inside a real trade.

Yet calling a real trade “money laundering” merely because money passed through it would be equally wrong.

Rachna asked, “Do you know the owner of Sahasra Tradelink?”

“No. Employees handle purchases.”

“Which account did the money come from?”

“I don’t look at bank details. Accounts department.”

“Who?”

Arvind gave them a name—

“Pradeep Mahajan.”



Pradeep Mahajan had left his job three days earlier.

His phone was switched off.

His house was locked.

A neighbour said his wife had gone to her parents’ home with the children.

Where Pradeep himself was—no one knew.

Rohit, now far more experienced, said—

“He ran.”

Aniruddh looked at him.

Rohit corrected himself at once—

“He’s missing.”

Aniruddh smiled faintly.

“Better.”

Pradeep’s bank account looked ordinary.

Salary.

Home loan.

School fees.

Nothing unusual.

But a legally obtained copy of his old email showed that several invoices from Sahasra Tradelink had been sent directly to Pradeep’s personal email address.

Why?

That was not normal company procedure.

This time the question was not a small one.



On paper, Sahasra Tradelink was a three-year-old firm.

Its office was in an industrial area in another state.

When the team reached it, there was a signboard, a lock, and two tables inside.

A neighbour said, "People come once or twice a month."

Employees?

"No one permanent."

Electricity consumption was minimal.

Bank activity was heavy.

For the first time, Aditya's team was looking at an unmistakable front entity.

But this was not the point of overlap with the NIA.

That lay one line further on—

A payment from Sahasra Tradelink to a company called "Aaroh Transport Solutions."

Aaroh was under scrutiny in the NIA's separate investigation because one of its old vehicles had transported goods belonging to an accused in a national-security case.

This one connection was the reason money originating in the seven mule accounts had reached a national-level meeting.

Apoorva Kashyap looked at the file and said—

"One thing now seems clear to me."

Aditya asked, "What?"

"Your gambling money probably did not fund our crime."

Silence settled over the room.

"Then what is the connection?"

"Aaroh may be a common financial cover that provides services on paper to many customers. Our man used it for one reason; your network used it for another."

Rachna said, "The same drain, different houses."

"Exactly."

Aniruddh looked out of the window.

"That conclusion is extremely important."

A young officer asked, "Because the national-security link has broken?"

"Because a broken link is evidence too."

Justice is built not only from what connects.

It is built also from what breaks a false connection.



The NIA decided to limit its role.

But cooperation did not end.

Apoorva said—

“If, through lawful process in our separate case, we obtain records from the financial intermediary that contain material relevant to your investigation, we will share it according to procedure.”

Aditya thanked her.

It was not a victory.

No one had been arrested.

There was no press conference.

But a grave suspicion had been removed.

Merely because their names had touched a national-security investigation, thousands of users, Ambar employees, mule-account holders, and people who had gambled did not automatically become national-security offenders.

Sometimes the most ethical achievement of an investigation is that it prevents the limits of its knowledge from becoming a public spectacle.



Meanwhile, Keshav Mehta continued coming to the Ambar office, but his behaviour had changed.

Earlier, he spoke in every meeting.

Now, very little.

One night Vihan Sarang stopped him.

“What are you hiding about Lokvistar?”

Keshav laughed.

“Don’t bring the language of investigating agencies into the house.”

“This isn’t a house.”

“The company is mine too.”

“Then answer me.”

Keshav walked towards the window.

Below, employees were leaving the parking lot for home.

“Vihan, my mistake was that I did not stop the growth.”

“The Night Room?”

Keshav turned around.

“That wasn’t Ambar.”

“But Ambar people were involved?”

“Some.”

“Lokvistar?”

“External.”

“Manoj?”

“External.”

“Ritesh?”

“I don’t even know the name.”

Vihan’s voice hardened.

“And the money?”

Keshav said nothing.

“Keshav.”

“The money moved through many places. I only saw the aggregate settlement figures.”

“Did you know private betting was going on?”

A long silence.

“I suspected.”

“Since when?”

Keshav did not answer.

Vihan sat down.

The company, its reputation, employment, years of work—all of it stood before him.

But the question was very small—

Since when?

“Why didn’t you tell me?”

Keshav said quietly—

“Because the numbers kept growing every quarter.”

It was not a confession to a crime.

But it was a confession of character.

Many falls do not begin with greed.

They begin with silence.



The next morning, Ambar’s board placed Keshav Mehta on leave.

The press statement was brief—

“Pending completion of an internal compliance review.”

Vihan himself informed the state branch.

Rachna Sinha asked—

“Voluntarily?”

“Yes.”

“Why?”

“Because I no longer trust that what I did not know was truly unknown to me.”

Rachna paused over the sentence.

“Explain the difference.”

Vihan said—

“Sometimes a man does not know a fact. Sometimes he does not ask the question because he does not want to hear the answer.”

Rachna wrote in her notebook—

“Lack of knowledge” and “wilful blindness.”

The law may distinguish between them.

Morality does too.



Ishaan was formally removed from the Ambar account.

Sutralekh management had decided that the family history was now part of a public investigation; the conflict of interest had become too explicit.

Ishaan’s first response was not relief but humiliation.

“What about what I found?”

Sumedha Ghosh said, “It is in the file.”

“And from here?”

“Another team.”

“Why?”

“Because you are not a bad analyst. Precisely for that reason.”

Ishaan laughed bitterly.

“What sort of logic is that?”

“We trust your work. But now, for every correct conclusion you reach, someone outside will say—his father’s revenge. For every wrong one, they will say—bias. It won’t be you that gets contaminated. The investigation will.”

Ishaan fell silent.

“Then what am I supposed to do?”

“Live.”

“That simple?”

Sumedha looked at him for a long time.

“No. The hardest thing of all.”



That same week, Dhaneshwari’s health suddenly deteriorated.

Mrinalini called Ishaan.

His phone was off.

Ishaan was in a confidential presentation where all devices had been deposited outside.

Three hours later he got his phone back.

Seven missed calls.

Ma.

Mama.

A neighbour.

He ran outside at once.

Mrinalini answered.

For several moments there was only breathing at the other end.

“Ma?”

“Dadi...”

Ishaan gripped the wall.

“What?”

“She’s gone.”

How long?

Fifty minutes.

Dhaneshwari had remained conscious at the end.

She had asked only once—

“Is Ishaan reading the water?”

Mrinalini had said, “Yes.”

Dhaneshwari’s last clear words were—

“Tell him to remember the bank.”

Then her voice faded.

Ishaan took the night train.

He had been removed from the investigation.

And he had been absent from his grandmother’s final moments too.

Two separate decisions.

Both proper.

Both unbearable.

The cruelty of tragedy is not that every event is unjust.

Sometimes every correct procedure, taken together, still inflicts upon one human being a loss from which there is nowhere to appeal.



After the funeral at Garh Narikel, the house became very quiet.

Dhaneshwari’s cot was empty.

The hollow left by her head was still visible on the pillow.

Mrinalini did not blame Ishaan.

That made it harder for him.

“Why didn’t you keep calling me?” Ishaan asked.

“I did.”

“Earlier?”

“She worsened suddenly.”

“I should have left the meeting.”

“How could you have known?”

Ishaan did not answer.

“Dadi asked whether you were reading the water.”

Ishaan began to cry.

For the first time since childhood, in front of his mother.

“I can’t read anything, Ma.”

Mrinalini placed his head in her lap.

“Why do you make yourself responsible for reading everything?”

The question went deeper than the investigation.

Ishaan did not sleep.

At dawn he stepped outside the threshold.

Small tracks in the mud.

A mongoose had come in the night.

No snake.

No blood.

Only footprints.

Ishaan bent to look at them.

Dadi was gone.

The watch remained.



Time had not stopped in Abhishek Jha’s home either.

That year Manjari again sat for nursing admission.

This time she secured a seat.

But to pay the fees, the family sold a small piece of land.

Abhishek protested—

“I’ll earn it.”

His father did not smile.

“We’ve already learned a great deal from your earnings.”

The sentence was harsh.

Abhishek fell silent.

Later Manjari came to her brother’s room.

“Babu said it in anger.”

“Was he wrong?”

Manjari had no answer.

Abhishek continued cooperating with the bank investigation.

A group attempting to open another account using his identity was caught—which meant his name was circulating within criminal lists.

Rachna told him—

“Now if anyone offers you another ‘commission’ job, tell us immediately.”

Abhishek laughed.

“These days even the tea-stall owner won’t give me credit.”

Rachna had nothing to say.

Even if the law treats someone as an innocent cooperating witness, society keeps the smell of a bank investigation on him for a long time.



A month later, a small digital record from the NIA’s separate investigation was transferred to the state team through lawful procedure.

The phone of a financial manager at Aaroh Transport contained several customer codes.

Most were meaningless.

One line read—

“Night—K.M.—Uttarayan adjustment.”

K.M.

Keshav Mehta?

Perhaps.

Krishna Mohan?

Kavita Mishra?

Kunal Mehra?

Initials are not evidence.

But for the first time, “Night” and “Uttarayan” appeared in the same line.

Rachna Sinha opened the file.

Manoj Nayak had laughed at the phrase “Night Room” during questioning.

The seized computers had used “Uttarayan” as a marker for an account group.

Now there was a third source.

Three independent threads.

Still no name.

But the concomitance was growing stronger.

Aditya said—

“Call Keshav?”

Rachna asked, “On initials alone?”

“He’s already under compliance review.”

“Even so.”

Aniruddh, on the phone, said only one sentence—

“You have grounds to ask questions. Not to write guilt.”



Keshav Mehta appeared after receiving notice.

With a lawyer.

His voice was steady.

“K.M. is not me.”

“The Night Room?”

“I’ve heard the name.”

“From whom?”

“An internal complaint at the company.”

“When?”

Keshav gave a date.

It was far earlier than Vihan had guessed.

Rachna asked—

“What action did you take then?”

“I reviewed one external-agency contract.”

“Lokvistar?”

“Yes.”

“Terminated?”

“No.”

“Why?”

Keshav’s lawyer intervened. “A commercial decision.”

Rachna said, “I am asking for the reason.”

Keshav replied, “There was insufficient evidence.”

Rachna was silent for a moment.

“Interesting.”

“What?”

“In criminal investigation we say that sentence all day. It sounds a little different when heard in business.”

Keshav did not smile.

Rachna continued—

“Was Night Room money absorbed into Ambar’s main system?”

“I don’t know.”

“Whose responsibility was it to know?”

“Finance.”

“Meaning you.”

The room went still.

Keshav drank some water.

“I saw aggregate settlements, not source-level detail.”

“Why?”

“The system was built that way.”

“Who built it?”

Keshav answered—

“An external payments consultant.”

“Name?”

For the first time, he looked towards his lawyer.

Then he said—

“Pradeep Mahajan.”

No one in the room made a sound.

The missing accounts employee from Neelkanth Aggregates.

For the first time, a living person had emerged between the current gambling network and the old construction business.



Finding Pradeep Mahajan now became a priority.

His wife's statement was taken.

“Was he frightened?”

“Yes.”

“Of whom?”

“Of the work.”

“Did he say anything?”

“He used to say—‘I’ve written the wrong people’s money into the right books.’”

“Whose people?”

“He never said.”

“Where did he go?”

His wife began to cry.

“He didn’t tell me. He only kissed the children and told me to stay at my parents’ home for a few days.”

“Phone?”

“He left it behind.”

That was unusual.

People who flee often destroy their phones.

Pradeep had left his at home.

Which meant he knew a phone could be used to track him.

An experienced criminal?

Or a frightened accounts employee?

Both remained possible.

Examination of the phone produced no sensation.

Family photographs.

Bills.

Work messages.

In a notes application, only one line—

“Old mansion across the river—Birju.”

Who was Birju?

No one knew.

There was no person by that name in Aniruddh’s old file.

Digant?

No.

Ambar?

No.

Neelkanth?

No.

Mayank Jha said—

“At a point like this, the mind wants to manufacture an old story. Stop it.”

Rachna asked, “Then?”

“Find the name’s independent meaning.”



“The old mansion across the river” did not turn out to be a place in the capital city.

It was in a village three districts away, near an old sugar mill.

The moment an elderly constable of the local police heard the name, he said—

“Birju Sah?”

“Who?”

“There used to be talk that he did hawala-like work in the old days, but no case was ever proved. He must be around eighty now. The mansion is across the river.”

Rachna immediately caught hold of one word—

“Hawala-like?”

“That is what people used to say. I do not know it from direct knowledge.”

Good.

The rumour was kept separate.

Birju Sah was alive.

Not eighty, but seventy-six.

His body was frail.

His eyes were sharp.

When the team arrived, he showed no fear.

“Pradeep?”

At the name, his face fell.

“He came.”

“When?”

“Two months ago.”

“Why?”

“To leave papers.”

“What papers?”

Birju laughed.

“Have you people come for the papers, or for the man?”

Rachna said, “Both.”

Birju opened an old cupboard at the back.

Inside was a sealed envelope.

Pradeep had written—

“If I do not return within seven days, give this to the police.”

“Why did you keep it for two months?” Rachna’s voice hardened.

Birju remained calm.

“He called after seven days.”

“What did he say?”

“I am alive. Do not open the envelope.”

“Then?”

“He called again three weeks ago. Said—if anyone asks, say you know nothing.”

“Why are you giving it now?”

Birju looked at Rachna.

“Because last night there was a third call.”

“Pradeep?”

“No.”

“Who?”

“Someone said—burn the old papers.”

The air in the room changed.

“You did not burn them?”

Birju smiled faintly.

“I am old. I am not a fool.”



The envelope was not opened there.

Seal.

Seizure memorandum.

Witnesses.

Camera.

Procedure.

Rachna could have been impatient.

She was not.

For sometimes the criminal attacks not the evidence itself, but the procedure by which the evidence is secured.

Back in the capital city, the envelope was opened in an authorised room.

There were only a few pages inside.

A handwritten table.

Abbreviated names of several companies.

Dates.

Total amounts.

And four columns—

“Game.”

“Night.”

“Goods.”

“Old.”

At the very bottom—

“K.M. / P.M. / U.”

P.M.—possibly Pradeep Mahajan.

K.M.—possibly Keshav Mehta.

“U.”—Uttarayan?

The same rule again.

Possible.

Not proved.

But in one row, opposite the “Old” column, there was a figure closely matching an old amount in Digant’s court-seizure records.

Mayank Jha remained silent for a long time.

“This is impossible...”

Aniruddh asked, “What?”

“A disputed payment from the Digant period that was never seized. I had thought it belonged to another lawful party.”

“The match?”

“The amount and the date differ very little.”

“Meaning?”

Mayank exhaled.

“If this table is genuine, some capital from the old tender network may later have reached an investment layer like Uttarayan.”

Ishaan was not there.

Yet the old slip written by his father seemed to be speaking from inside the file.

Ambar.

Two calls.

Old money.

New water.



Aniruddh remained awake very late that night.

A retired officer.

No official power.

Yet the story had come back to his table.

He opened Satyaprakash's old file.

Vihan's email.

Digant's sports festival.

Ambar Sports Media.

Small then.

Now a vast digital company.

Had Satyaprakash, even then, glimpsed the early form of this money trail?

Possible.

Had he died because of it?

Still not proved.

Even after twenty years, the same answer.

Aniruddh closed the file.

The harshest form of some tragedies is not that the truth is hidden.

It is that fragments of truth keep surfacing, yet the decisive line never does.



In Garh Narikel, after Dhaneshwari's shraddha rites, Ishaan was preparing to return to the capital city.

Mrinalini packed food into his bag.

"Going back to work?"

"A different file."

"Not Ambar?"

"No."

Mrinalini breathed in relief.

Ishaan had not lied.

But neither had he told the whole truth—the Ambar investigation had not left his mind.

As he stepped across the threshold, a mongoose crossed the path in front of him.

Ishaan stopped.

From the bushes behind came the hiss of a cobra.

The mongoose held still for a moment.

The snake slid back into the grass.

No fight.

No blood.

The path changed merely because of a presence.

Ishaan remembered his grandmother's words—

“Sometimes the mere presence of a mongoose is enough.”

He left to catch his train.

He did not know that, at that very moment in the capital city, Pradeep Mahajan's envelope had already been opened.

He did not know that his father's unfinished question, Digant's old money, Uttarayan's investment, Ambar's digital success, the Night Room's gambling, Sabina's tailoring shop, Pawan's dead account, and Abhishek's guilt were all slowly turning toward one point.

But there was still no name for the centre.

Still no judgment.

Only a deep whirl in the water.

The monitor lizard had not surfaced.

The mongoose had not left the bank.



The next morning, local police guards were posted at Birju Sah's mansion.

He himself was not pleased by the arrangement.

“I am not a criminal,” he told Rachna Sinha.

“Protection is not only for criminals.”

“Keeping an old man like a prisoner?”

“You are not a prisoner.”

Birju laughed.

“Two constables outside the door, every phone call written down, a vehicle if I go out—call it whatever name you like.”

Rachna remained silent.

Birju was right.

On paper the line between protection and confinement is clear; in human experience, it is not.

A time was sought that day for recording his statement before a magistrate. Birju agreed, but said—

“I will say only what I myself saw. Not what people used to say.”

Rachna closed her notebook.

“That is exactly what I want too.”

Birju narrowed his eyes at her.

“Then you are the first police people I have met who want less of a story.”

“I do not want a story. I want evidence.”

“Will you be able to keep the two apart?”

Rachna answered—

“We will try.”

Birju slowly nodded.

“That is all. Justice is only this difficult.”



Birju admitted without evasion that, in the old days, he had been a broker.

“Hawala?” Rachna asked.

“That is the police word.”

“Yours?”

“I used to call it—getting money where it had to go.”

“For whom?”

“Traders, contractors, election people, sometimes families.”

“Legal?”

“Some of it. Some of it not.”

“Digant?”

Birju took a long breath.

“Digant came much later.”

“The old network?”

“The name you people give it is not the name by which I knew it.”

Rachna placed before him some of the institutions from Satyaprakash’s old tender investigation.

Birju recognised two names.

At the third he shook his head.

“These were not men. They were routes.”

“Meaning?”

“The same money might become a donation, a bill, goods, election expenditure. The man who creates the route does not need to know every name.”

“Why did Pradeep Mahajan come to you?”

Birju was silent for a long time.

“He said—the old route has opened again.”

“For what?”

“New money.”

“Online gambling?”

“He did not use that word.”

“Then?”

“He said—games on screens. Night accounts. Large sums through small accounts.”

Rachna wrote nothing. She only listened.

Birju continued—

“He was frightened. He said that the same method used twenty years ago to make contractors’ money look clean was now being used to make digital money look clean.”

“Who is running it?”

“He did not give a name.”

“Keshav Mehta?”

“He did not say.”

“Devanshu Rakshit?”

“No.”

“Uttarayan?”

For the first time, Birju went still at that word.

“He did say that name.”

The air in the room grew heavy.

“What did he say?”

“He said—Uttarayan is not the real company. It is the roof above. There are many rooms below it.”

Rachna asked—

“Owner?”

Birju closed his eyes, trying to remember.

“He said a name... something with ‘Shashi.’”

“Shashi who?”

“That is all. I did not write it down.”

Rachna did not immediately begin making a list of names.

Half a name can give birth to the most dangerous complete story.



That night Birju Sah suddenly fell ill.

The first complaint—heaviness in the chest.

A local doctor arrived.

He performed an ECG.

He advised that Birju be taken to the district hospital.

An ambulance came.

Rachna had already returned to the capital city; she received the information by phone.

Half an hour later came a second call.

Birju never reached the hospital.

He died on the way.

The local doctor considered a heart attack the preliminary cause.

And now the same crisis again—

The witness was dead.

The evidence was alive.

Rumour was born at once.

“Poison.”

“Murder.”

“Death under police protection.”

“Finished before he could reveal the secret.”

Rachna returned again at midnight.

A post-mortem was ordered.

Medicines, food, water—samples of everything.

Birju was old.

He had a pre-existing heart condition.

Yet at such a moment even a natural death looks like conspiracy to people.

Rachna knew: just as criminals construct evidence, society constructs meaning.

Both move faster than an investigation.



The post-mortem showed no immediate sign of poisoning.

His old heart disease was clear.

The final opinion was reserved.

Rachna felt no relief.

Birju had died before giving his statement to the magistrate.

His oral account existed in the police notes.

But its value in court might be limited.

“Testimony,” Mayank Jha said on the phone, “where the speaker can no longer answer questions.”

Rachna snapped—

“Not philosophy now.”

Mayank fell silent.

Rachna regretted it at once.

"I am sorry."

"It is all right."

"To me, the man was alive. Until yesterday. I thought—I would take the statement tomorrow."

Mayank said softly—

"In an investigation, 'tomorrow' is the most expensive word."

At that sentence they both fell silent.

Birju's envelope still existed.

His old ledgers were still in the mansion.

But the interpretations that had existed only in his mind had gone with him.

Tragedy is not always murder.

Sometimes it is merely time coming to its ordinary end—at precisely the moment when a human being most needed to speak.



After Birju's death, his son came to the mansion.

His name was Alok Sah.

A bank officer.

He had been distant from his father for years.

He was angry with the police.

"You people dragged him into this at his age."

Rachna said, "He was cooperating of his own accord."

"He cooperated with everyone. That was precisely his problem."

"About his heart condition?"

"He was on medication."

"Any new threats?"

Alok paused.

"Three months ago he said some old people had begun calling again."

"Names?"

"No."

"Why did he not tell you?"

Alok gave a bitter laugh.

"Were we father and son, or was I his investigating officer?"

Rachna understood the wound in that answer.

Even to think that distance within a family might later become an evidentiary void felt like another kind of injustice.

At last Alok opened an old iron chest.

“Look at whatever you need. But write one thing down—my father was no saint.”

Rachna said—

“I have not come here to make anyone a saint.”

Inside the chest were ledgers twenty years old.

Worms had eaten through some of the papers.

Some contained amounts.

Some contained code names.

One code name appeared again and again—

“Chandra.”



They began trying to determine what “Chandra” meant.

The first mistake was an easy one—

Shashi = Chandra.

Birju had said “something with Shashi.”

Were the two the same person?

Rohit grew excited.

Mayank stopped him at once.

“A possibility.”

Rachna added—

“Not a name.”

Aniruddh, on the telephone, said—

“And what if someone deliberately said ‘Shashi’ to leave a clue toward Chandra? Or what if Birju remembered it incorrectly?”

Rohit laughed.

“I understand. Nothing is proved.”

“Do not be angry at that sentence. Be proud of it,” Aniruddh said.

Beside Chandra in the ledger were three institutions from twenty years earlier.

One—an old supplier linked to Digant.

The second—a cooperative credit institution, now closed.

The third—“Udayrekha Public Trust.”

Udayrekha still existed.

Education, rural sports, scholarships, water conservation.

Gleaming photographs on its website.

Chairman—Shashank Devvrat.

Rachna went still when she read the name.

Shashi?

Shashank?

Chandra?

Again the mind rushed to manufacture a story.

She closed the file herself.

“First, the Trust’s records.”



Shashank Devvrat was an influential man of sixty.

A former industrialist.

No politics.

No public criminal record.

The Udayrekha Public Trust was associated with numerous universities and sports projects across the country.

The Trust did not appear on Ambar Interactive’s list of early investors.

But there was a fund called the “Uttarayan Social Investment Fund,” among whose initial donors was Udayrekha.

This was the first concrete institutional bridge.

Old ledger—Udayrekha.

New investment—Uttarayan.

Ambar’s early capital—Uttarayan.

Did this prove a crime?

No.

Donations, investments, business—all could be lawful.

But the path was now documentary, not conjectural.

Rachna said—

“Now I have grounds to question Shashank Devvrat.”

Mayank added—

“Not grounds to presume guilt.”

Rohit clutched his head.

“One day we are going to print that sentence on T-shirts.”

For the first time the room broke into loud laughter.

When the laughter ended, three decades stood in a single line on the board.

Old tenders.

Udayrekha.

Uttarayan.

Ambar.

Night Room.

Mule accounts.

Money had crossed the waters of time.



Shashank Devvrat himself gave them a time for the meeting.

He brought no lawyer.

"I understand this inquiry concerns donations and investments."

Rachna said, "Yes."

"Udayrekha's name appears in an old ledger."

"Whose ledger?"

"Birju Sah's."

A faint mark passed over Shashank's face.

"He was alive?"

"Not anymore."

"I read the news."

"Did you know him?"

"By name."

"His work?"

"An old financial intermediary."

"Did he route money to Udayrekha?"

Shashank leaned back in his chair.

"When the Trust was formed, many donations came in both cash and through banks. I cannot remember every source from twenty years ago."

"Chandra?"

His face was blank.

"Who?"

Rachna placed a copy of the ledger before him.

Shashank put on his glasses.

He studied it for a long time.

"This is not my handwriting."

"I did not say it was."

"I am not Chandra."

"I have not asked you that either."

Shashank paused for a moment.

He had no lawyer with him, but he had abundant experience.

"So you want me to construct the connection myself?"

Rachna smiled.

"I want you to tell me what you know."

Shashank pushed the paper back.

"The Uttarayan Fund was a lawful social-investment initiative of Udayrekha—young companies, sports, education, rural technology."

"Ambar?"

"An early investment."

"Keshav Mehta?"

“I have met him.”

“Pradeep Mahajan?”

“No.”

“Digant?”

“I have heard the name.”

“Devanshu Rakshit?”

For the first time, Shashank looked away.

Only for a moment.

Rachna saw it.

But looking away was not evidence.

“Did you know him?”

“We may have met at social programmes.”

“Satyaprakash Karn?”

“No.”

Rachna ended the meeting.

Outside, Rohit asked—

“Why did you not press him again on Devanshu?”

“Because he looked away for one moment?”

“Yes.”

“People look away for a thousand reasons.”

Rohit laughed.

“You never let me have any drama.”

“Courts do not sell tickets to drama.”



That same day, Ishaan was formally given a new assignment.

Not the Ambar investigation.

A broader state project on financial-crime data.

The task—to understand the social patterns of mule accounts.

Which groups were repeatedly targeted?

Small traders?

Students?

Homemakers?

The unemployed?

Debtors?

He was not to identify criminals, but to build a social map of risk.

Ishaan read the proposal and remained silent for a long time.

Sumedha Ghosh asked—

“Will you take it?”

“There is no Ambar data in this?”

“No.”

“People like Abhishek?”

“Yes.”

“Sabina?”

“Yes, if the data are legally anonymised and used in aggregate.”

Ishaan accepted.

For the first time, his work turned away from retribution and toward prevention.

Yet Satyaprakash was still inside him.

A person does not erase the dead merely by changing jobs.



The data told strange stories.

Many mule-account holders were not wholly criminal.

Nor were many of them wholly innocent.

Some knowingly gave their accounts in exchange for commission.

Some believed it was “work from home.”

Some were under pressure from debt.

Some were students who trusted the arrangement as soon as the first five hundred rupees arrived.

Some were small shopkeepers who believed that higher bank turnover would help them obtain loans.

Ishaan built a map.

Where unemployment was higher, account recruitment was higher.

Where families depended on migrant workers, remote banking activity was greater.

Where online-gambling promotion was dense, small loans and unusual account activity rose with it.

Correlation.

Not causation.

But a signal for prevention.

On the first page of his report he wrote—

“Mule accounts are not merely a banking problem; they are a confluence of four currents—economic insecurity, digital illiteracy, the lure of quick earnings, and organised recruitment.”

Aniruddh read the report and called him.

“You have written well.”

Ishaan said nothing.

“If your grandmother were here?”

Ishaan’s throat tightened.

“She would say—read the water.”

“You are reading it.”

“Not my father’s water. Not yet.”

Aniruddh was silent for a long time.

“No one person can read every water, Ishaan.”

“Then justice?”

“Sometimes the next generation completes the line.”

Ishaan ended the call.

That night, for the first time, he lifted Satyaprakash’s photograph from his desk and placed it inside the cupboard.

He had not forgotten.

He had only made room to breathe.



Pradeep Mahajan finally came forward on his own.

The police had not found him.

Through a lawyer, he sent a message—

“I will surrender.”

Place—the district court.

Conditions—distance from the media, protection for his family, and his first statement before a magistrate.

Rachna agreed, in accordance with procedure.

On the day in court, Pradeep arrived thin, bearded, and plainly dressed.

No cinematic chase.

No weapon.

He surrendered directly, accompanied by his lawyer.

The case concerned financial crime.

An application was made for judicial custody.

The magistrate asked—

“Why did you run?”

Pradeep answered—

“I was afraid.”

“Of whom?”

“Of those who gave me the work. And of those who would investigate it.”

“Did you commit a crime?”

Pradeep paused.

“I knowingly prepared some false papers.”

“Money laundering?”

“I did not know the term. I understood the work.”

Silence settled over the courtroom.

“Meaning?”

“I knew the money was not always for the purpose named on the paper.”

The magistrate remanded him to judicial custody.

District jail.

For the first time, the Indian crime story passed wholly through the gates of a prison.



The entrance to the district jail was smaller than Pradeep had imagined.

Outside—families, lawyers, tea stalls, rickshaws.

Inside—an iron gate.

Name entered.

Body searched.

Belongings separated.

Instructions for a new prisoner.

He was sent to the undertrial barrack.

He did not sleep the first night.

On paper, the categories of crime in the barrack were distinct; in bodily distance, they were not.

One man for theft.

One for assault.

One for fraud.

One insisting he was innocent.

One laughing as he admitted what he had done.

One merely counting dates.

Pradeep sat against the wall.

An elderly prisoner asked—

“First time?”

“Yes.”

“How long?”

“I don’t know.”

The old man laughed.

“That is the greatest punishment here—‘I don’t know.’”

Pradeep lowered his head.

For years he had moved money from account to account.

Now his own life would move from date to date.



His wife did not come to the first prison visit.

Only his brother did.
A telephone through glass.
His brother said—
“Your sister-in-law does not want to come yet.”
Pradeep lowered his eyes.
“The children?”
“At school.”
“What have you told them about me?”
His brother was silent.
“What did you say?”
“That their father is away because of work.”
Pradeep’s eyes filled.
“Why lie?”
His brother’s voice hardened—

“Which truth was I supposed to tell them? That their father is innocent? I don’t know that. That he is a criminal? The court has not said so. Should I teach a child Nyāya philosophy?”

Pradeep kept hold of the phone.
He had fabricated documents.
He had helped money appear clean.
Yet for his own daughter he could not construct a single clear sentence.
This was the beginning of his private punishment.



Pradeep’s detailed statement before the magistrate unfolded slowly.
Rachna kept her questions few.
“The Night Room?”
“Private online betting.”
“Ambar’s?”
“Not officially Ambar’s.”
“Keshav?”
“He saw the consolidated settlements.”
“Did he know?”
Pradeep was silent.
“Tell me only what you yourself know.”
“He did not ask questions.”
“That is not an answer. Did he know?”
“I cannot say from direct knowledge.”
Rachna nodded.
“Good.”

“Uttarayan?”

“A roof between old investment and new settlement.”

“Goods?”

“Some sums were absorbed into invoices for real trade.”

“Old?”

Pradeep’s face changed.

“Money left over from the Digant period.”

“Who supplied it?”

“Intermediaries.”

“Names?”

“I only ever heard ‘Chandra.’”

Rachna held her breath.

“Shashank Devvrat?”

“I cannot say.”

“Did you ever meet him?”

“Saw him from a distance at a function.”

“Spoke to him?”

“No.”

“Was Keshav Mehta Chandra?”

“I don’t know.”

“Then who was Chandra?”

Pradeep closed his eyes.

“Not a signature. More like a word of approval. When someone said, ‘Chandra is clear,’ the payment moved to the next layer.”

“So it might not have been a person at all?”

“Yes.”

That answer could alter the direction of the entire investigation.

What everyone had been searching for as a man might instead be a process, a signal, or a shared authorisation code.

There need not be a person behind every name.

Some criminal networks erase the individual and give authority to a word.



Pradeep disclosed one more thing.

He had seen Satyaprakash Karna’s name in an old file.

“Where?”

“In a scanned Digant ledger.”

“Why was his name there?”

“A payment had stalled.”

“Ambar?”

“Yes.”

Rachna’s hand went still.

“Say it clearly.”

“Digant had planned to route some money through a sports event. Ambar Sports Media was a small service provider then. Satyaprakash called twice to verify the payment.”

Ishaan’s slip of paper.

“What happened after that?”

“The payment was stopped.”

“On whose order?”

“I don’t know.”

“Satyaprakash’s death?”

Pradeep looked directly at Rachna.

“I have no information about it.”

“Suspicion?”

“I have suspicions.”

“I did not ask for suspicion.”

“Then no.”

The same wall again.

Twenty years.

Two generations.

Countless documents.

And yet, regarding Satyaprakash’s death—no.

Rachna recorded the answer exactly as it was.

Sometimes respect for truth means preserving its incompleteness.



Meanwhile, the crisis inside Ambar Interactive’s head office had broken into the open.

Keshav was on leave.

Vihan was cooperating with the investigation.

Investors were uneasy.

Employees lived among rumours.

Some said the company would shut down.

Some said the government would ban the gaming industry.

Some said every employee would be arrested.

On social media, accusation travelled faster than truth.

Vihan called a meeting of the entire staff.

“An investigation is under way. The company’s lawful products will continue. Whatever links to the private betting network are established will be isolated.”

An employee asked—

“Was the salary we were paid dirty money?”

Vihan fell silent.

A difficult question.

If some tainted money had entered a company’s total income, did every salary thereby become part of the crime?

The law would seek an answer.

But the employees’ guilt began at once.

Vihan said—

“Do not treat yourselves as criminals for wages earned through your regular work. Let the investigation separate the sources.”

A young designer began to cry.

Her father in the village had read the news and told her to resign.

The shadow of crime does not draw separate borders across the bodies of the guilty and the innocent.



The audit of the Uttarayan Fund uncovered a peculiar fact.

At the time of Ambar’s early investment, the fund had not received money only from Udayrekha.

Capital had also come from a defunct cooperative institution —“Samriddhi Gram-Finance Board.”

Samriddhi was the same old institution whose name stood opposite “Chandra” in Birju’s ledger.

The institution had closed twenty years earlier.

Its final liquidation papers were incomplete.

Some money was recorded as an “unclaimed fund.”

Yet in a later year it had been transferred to a private trust?

The paperwork was unclear.

Mayank Jha removed his glasses.

“This point does not prove that the money came from an old crime.”

Rachna said, “But the path?”

“The path is real.”

“Twenty years long.”

“Yes.”

“Should we tell Ishaan?”

Aniruddh’s answer came at once—

“Not yet.”

“Why?”

“He is not on the investigative team.”

“But his father—”

“Precisely why not.”

Rachna agreed.

Justice does not always tell the loved one first.



The liquidator of the Samriddhi Gram-Finance Board had died long ago.

His office records were in the district record room.

Dust.

Termites.

Bundles tied with string.

It took three days.

At last they found a list.

The unclaimed fund had been transferred not to the “Udayrekha Public Trust,” but to the “Udayrekha Welfare Committee.”

The names were almost identical.

The institutions were different.

The committee had shut down five years later.

Chairman—

Shashibhushan Lal.

Rachna went still as she read the paper.

Shashi.

Birju had said, “something with Shashi.”

Shashibhushan Lal was dead.

Ten years earlier.

Business—grain market, transport, at times local politics.

Any connection to Shashank Devvrat?

None immediately visible.

Once again, similarity of names could pull the investigation toward the wrong man.

Rohit remained silent for a long time.

Then he said it himself—

“A possibility.”

Rachna laughed.

“You are getting better.”



In the search for Shashibhushan Lal's family, they found a daughter—
Aditi Lal.

A retired university professor.

She spoke openly about her father—

"His business was not clean."

"Crime?"

"I do not know the evidence."

"Birju Sah?"

"He used to come to the house."

"Chandra?"

Aditi laughed.

"That was Father's name at home."

The room went completely still.

"Why?"

"Grandmother called him Chandra. In the family."

The pen in Rachna's hand stopped.

For the first time, the "Chandra" in a twenty-year-old ledger became a human being.

But a dead human being.

"Was Shashibhushan Lal connected with Digant?"

"At that time I had not heard the name Digant."

"Samriddhi Gram-Finance?"

"Yes. Father was associated with the committee."

"The Udayrekha Welfare Committee?"

"He ran it."

"Shashank Devvrat's Udayrekha Public Trust?"

Aditi shook her head.

"Different. Later there was even a dispute over the name."

The answer shattered a large misconception.

Half the suspicious bridge being built toward Shashank collapsed.

Similar name.

Different institution.

Different period.

Once again, justice had been saved from its own error.



But Aditi added one last thing—

"After Father's death, a young man handled some of his old business accounts."

"Who?"

“The name may have been Devanshu.”

Rachna held her breath.

“Devanshu Rakshit?”

“I do not remember the surname.”

“A photograph?”

They showed her an image from the old file.

Aditi brought it close to her eyes.

“It could be him.”

“Certain?”

“No.”

Rachna put the photograph away.

“All right.”

Aditi smiled.

“Disappointed?”

“No.”

“It would have been easier if I had said yes?”

“Much easier.”

“Then?”

“Easy justice is not always justice.”

For the first time, Aditi looked at Rachna with respect.



That night Ishaan telephoned the old house in Garh Narikel.

Mrinalini was alone.

“Food?”

“I have eaten.”

“Medicine?”

“Yes.”

A few ordinary things.

Then Mrinalini asked—

“Work all right?”

“Yes.”

“That same case?”

Ishaan fell silent.

“No.”

“Do not lie.”

“Ma, officially I am not in that investigation.”

“In your mind?”

Ishaan did not answer.

Mrinalini said softly—

“Your father too would sit at home going through papers. I would tell him—leave it. He would say—just let me understand it once.”

“And then?”

“Once was never complete.”

A shiver passed through Ishaan’s body.

“You want me to leave it?”

“I want you to stay alive.”

A simple sentence.

The hardest command in this novel.



At Pradeep’s second prison visit, his daughter came.

Fourteen years old.

Her name was Trisha.

She did not cry when she saw her father through the glass.

She only asked—

“Babu, are you a thief?”

Pradeep was not prepared to answer.

His wife stood beside her, her face hard.

“Answer her,” she said.

Holding the phone, Pradeep looked at his daughter for a long time.

“I did not steal money for myself.”

Trisha answered at once—

“Then?”

“I made papers that made wrong money look right.”

“Knowingly?”

Pradeep’s eyes filled.

“Sometimes, yes.”

Trisha was silent.

“Will you stay in jail?”

“The court will decide.”

“You lied to us that your work was clean?”

Pradeep lowered his head.

“Yes.”

Trisha put down the phone.

Visiting time still remained.

But she stepped back.

His wife picked up the receiver.

“Now my child needs truth, not philosophy.”

Pradeep had only the truth.

And this time the truth was not saving him.



The rains began over the Kamala-Balan.

Water rose along the banks at Garh Narikel.

One evening, when Ishaan came home on leave, the old burrow behind the courtyard had filled with water.

The mongoose's old footprints were gone.

He bent down and searched for something.

Nothing.

From the veranda, Mrinalini asked—

“What are you looking for?”

“Nothing.”

“The mongoose?”

Ishaan did not smile.

Mrinalini said—

“A creature does not die merely because its footprints are erased.”

Ishaan stood up.

A faint rustling came from the distant grass.

He could not tell whether it was the mongoose or the water.

By now he understood—

the absence of evidence and the absence of existence are not the same thing.

But a court does not ask for existence; it asks for evidence.

The tragedy of life begins there.

A human being knows something was there.

The law asks—show me.



At that same time in the capital, a new paper was being placed on Rachna Sinha's desk.

The final-year payment list of the Samriddhi Gram-Finance Board.

One line had been circled in red pencil—

“Special Project—Sports Promotion—Satyaprakash Karna.”

Rachna stared at it for a long time.

The money had not gone to Satyaprakash's company.

His name appeared as “verifier.”

The date—

nine days before his death.

Twenty years later, for the first time, Satyaprakash appeared directly in an official document on the old money trail.

This did not prove murder.

But one thing was now proved—

before the accident, Satyaprakash had not been looking only at the six percent in the tender network.

He was also examining the route by which old money moved through sports.

A new question opened in the file.

Had someone stopped him?

Or had the accident truly been an accident?

Both were possible.

The distance between them was still dark.

Rachna looked out of the window.

The rain was heavy.

Nothing could be seen on the water.

But the bank of the investigation had narrowed.

Somewhere, the monitor lizard was breathing.

And the mongoose's vigil was no longer merely a symbol.

It had become a question—

how long should truth be permitted to remain beneath the water?



When the twenty-year-old file for the “Special Project—Sports Promotion” was brought out of the record room, the first thing that spoke was not the paper but its smell.

Dampness.

Old dust.

Mould in places.

Wearing gloves, Rachna Sinha turned the pages: payment proposal, inspection note, signatures, and one thin letter—from Satyaprakash Karna.

The letter was brief.

“Payment is not appropriate without direct verification of the work. The photographs submitted do not match the conditions at the site. Clarification is required from the beneficiary institution.”

Signature below.

Date—nine days before his death.

Rachna read the letter three times.

This time there was no inference.

Satyaprakash had in fact stopped the payment.

But whether that payment became a motive for murder was still only inference.

The next page of the file contained something strange.

Four days after Satyaprakash's objection, a "special administrative approval" arrived and the payment was released.

The approving officer—Kripanand Verma.

Retired.

Alive.

Seventy-nine years old.

Rachna arranged the journey at once.



Kripanand Verma lived at his son's house.

His hands trembled.

Memory was sometimes sharp, sometimes misted.

Rachna did not show him the papers at first.

"Satyaprakash Karna?"

For an instant, the old man's eyes lit up.

"Yes... not a contractor... he did verification."

"You remember him?"

"A hard man."

"The sports-promotion payment?"

Kripanand placed a hand on his forehead.

"Very long ago."

Rachna waited.

Many investigators fill an empty space immediately with another question.

Some memories ask for silence.

The old man said slowly—

"There was a programme that happened on paper, not on the ground."

"Why did you approve the payment?"

Kripanand's face fell.

"I was told from above."

"By whom?"

"The name..."

He remained silent for a long time.

"A written order?"

"No."

"A phone call?"

"Perhaps."

“From whom?”

“I do not remember.”

Rachna could have stopped there.

But one question was necessary—

“Did Satyaprakash oppose it?”

The old man answered at once—

“Very strongly.”

“What did he say?”

“He said, ‘If we pay in the name of sport today, in whose name will we pay tomorrow?’”

Rachna did not rely on the literal wording of that sentence. Twenty years can polish remembered dialogue.

“Do you remember those exact words?”

Kripanand himself laughed.

“No, daughter. I remember the sense.”

That answer seemed more trustworthy to Rachna.

“And after that?”

The old man closed his eyes.

“He used to say that some old money was moving through a new institution.”

“Whose?”

“I do not know.”

“Ambar?”

“I do not remember the name.”

“Digant?”

The old man opened his eyes.

“I had heard that name.”

“From whom?”

“Satyaprakash?”

Then immediately—

“Perhaps.”

Rachna circled the word “perhaps” in her notes.

Memory may be evidence.

But confidence in a memory is not the strength of the evidence.



With the family’s permission, Kripanand’s old diary was examined.

It was not an official file.

A personal note.

Beside a date, only three lines—

“S.K. argued again. Wants to stop sports payment. D.R.’s people angry.”

D.R.

Devanshu Rakshit?

Digant Regional?

Dayanand Rai?

Once again, two letters wanted to turn themselves into a whole human being.

Rachna did not seize the diary; a lawful copy was taken.

As soon as Mayank Jha saw it, he said—

“This is a powerful indication.”

“But?”

“You already know.”

“Yes. D.R. is not proved to be Devanshu Rakshit.”

Aniruddh said over the phone—

“Be careful with old initials. The hunger for a name leads an investigation into darkness faster than almost anything else.”

Rachna asked—

“But what if it really is Devanshu?”

“Then another piece of evidence will give him his name. Do not force the initials to speak.”



By then Devanshu Rakshit had completed his prison sentence.

After his release, he had left the capital and was living in a small hill town.

No business.

No public life.

Rachna sent a request to meet him.

The reply came—

“Come.”

Devanshu had grown old.

Different from the figure in the first investigation—hair almost white, gait slow, voice still controlled.

At the mention of Aniruddh’s name, he gave a faint laugh.

“That man is still alive?”

“Yes.”

“Still saying, ‘Only what is proved?’”

Rachna answered—

“Yes.”

Devanshu leaned back in his chair.

“Then you have come to the right house.”

“Satyaprakash Karna’s sports payment.”

Devanshu’s face hardened.

“That death again?”

“I did not ask about the death. The payment.”

“Digant used to hold sports festivals.”

“On paper?”

“Some were real. Some were on paper.”

“An admission?”

“What is the point in hiding again what I have already served a sentence for?”

Rachna placed the letter before him.

Devanshu read it.

A long silence.

“Satyaprakash stopped this?”

“Yes.”

“I do not remember.”

“Kripanand Verma’s diary says D.R.’s people were angry.”

Devanshu looked directly at Rachna.

“You want me to say D.R. was me?”

“I want you to tell the truth.”

Devanshu laughed.

“Aniruddh’s disciple.”

“The answer?”

“D.R. could have been me.”

Rachna stopped her pen.

“Could have been?”

“Because inside Digant people sometimes wrote my initials that way. But ‘his people were angry’ is not an order.”

“About Satyaprakash’s accident?”

Devanshu turned his face away.

“I did not have the answer to that question twenty years ago either.”

“Could someone in your network have taken action?”

“Possible.”

“Without your knowledge?”

“Possible.”

“Can you give me a name?”

Devanshu remained silent for a long time.

“There was one man—Haricharan Mandal. He used to ‘solve’ local problems.”

“Alive?”

“No. Died eight years ago.”

“Satyaprakash?”

“I do not know.”

The same wall again.

Rachna was disappointed, but she could not use that disappointment against the truth.

Devanshu suddenly asked—

“Is Mrinalini alive?”

“Yes.”

“Tell her—I was punished for what I did. It would be a crime to give her peace by falsely confessing to what I do not know.”

Rachna kept looking at him after that sentence.

Even a criminal human being may sometimes preserve one boundary of truth.

Justice is not so simple that all evil can be placed in one body and all truth in another.



Haricharan Mandal’s old file was reopened.

Extortion.

Assault.

Vehicles.

Two cases closed for lack of evidence.

One conviction.

His location at the time of Satyaprakash’s accident?

No record.

The mobile-phone era was only beginning; the available data were incomplete.

An employee of an old petrol pump was still alive, but remembering one night from twenty years earlier was impossible.

Rachna read the original case diary of the road accident.

Brake marks.

Unknown heavy vehicle.

Night.

Rain.

One eyewitness—a tea-stall owner at a distance—had said at the time that the vehicle drove on without stopping.

No number.

Colour unclear.

No one gave chase.

Forensic science was not then what it is today.

Whether even what was possible at the time had actually been done was itself a question.

But twenty years later, the limits of reconstruction were harsher still.

Rachna closed the file.

The greatest void in the first plot remained a void.

But there were now more facts around that void.

Satyaprakash had stopped the payment.

Digant's interests had been affected.

It had been written that D.R.'s people were angry.

Haricharan had been the local "problem-solver."

The death came nine days later.

Taken together, none of this proved murder.

But it also made it difficult to forget the death as an ordinary accident.



Rachna went to see Mrinalini herself.

Ishaan was not present.

Rachna told her everything slowly, piece by piece.

Mrinalini listened.

At the end she asked only—

"Then it was murder?"

Rachna cleared her throat.

"Not proved."

Mrinalini did not laugh.

Nor did she grow angry.

"After twenty years, you have come to tell me that my suspicion was not foolish."

"Yes."

"And you still cannot tell me that it was right."

"Yes."

Mrinalini looked at Satyaprakash's photograph on the wall.

"Before, I had grief. Now I have a reason as well—but no answer."

Rachna remained silent.

"Has this brought justice nearer or farther away?"

Rachna had no prepared answer.

"Perhaps nearer."

Mrinalini looked at her for the first time.

"I have heard 'perhaps' for many years."

Rachna lowered her head.
Before many victims, the language of caution can sound cruel.
Yet it is less cruel than false certainty.



In the present gambling investigation, the first decisive searches of Keshav Mehta's home and private office were conducted at the same dawn.

Court orders.
Independent witnesses.
Digital devices lawfully seized.
No dramatic walls smashed open.
No secret cellar.
The office was orderly.
The house respectable.
Books.
Family photographs.
Awards.

Criminal networks are often found in places where nothing looks frightening from the outside.

A small notebook was found.
Half business.
Half personal.
Across several pages, the same phrases appeared again and again—
“Main clean.”
“Night outside.”
“Adjustment—P.M.”
“U. approval.”

Rachna felt no triumph on seeing the notebook.
The questions multiplied.
“U.” — Uttarayan?
“P.M.” — Pradeep Mahajan?
Initials again.
But this time with context.

The lawful forensic examination of the computers recovered several messages between Keshav and Pradeep.

In one, Keshav had written—
“Do not bring this flow inside the main application.”
Another—
“Keep the Night settlement separate.”
A third—

Not an operational sentence such as “keep changing accounts,” but a general instruction: “Reduce dependence on any single outside channel.”

Within the context of the investigation, the meaning of that sentence might become clear; by itself, it was not a crime.

Then another message appeared—

Pradeep: “What basis should I write for this payment?”

Keshav: “Write the service that was actually performed. Adjust the remaining amount separately.”

Rachna stared at that line for a long time.

For the first time, Keshav’s knowledge was no longer merely a silence.

He had written the language of separation himself.



Keshav was arrested.

Economic conspiracy, financial deception linked to the illegal betting arrangement, acts intended to conceal the source of funds—the charges were limited to what the available evidence supported.

Not the NIA.

The State Economic Offences Branch.

Apoorva Kashyap was merely informed because some records concerning a shared financial intermediary overlapped with her separate investigation.

The press waited outside.

Rachna gave a brief statement—

“An arrest is not a conviction. The investigation is continuing.”

A reporter asked—

“Is this a national-security case?”

Rachna answered plainly—

“Our present case is a state investigation concerning online gambling, financial deception, and suspected money laundering. The existence of a separate national investigation must not be treated as an allegation against this accused.”

Only half of that sentence appeared in the news.

“NIA link?”

The headline was made anyway.

A complete sentence of truth becomes small in the marketplace.

Half a word of insinuation becomes large.



Keshav was remanded to judicial custody.

A separate barrack in the district jail, but within the same compound where Pradeep was held.

The two were not allowed a direct meeting.

When Pradeep heard the news, his body went cold.

An elderly prisoner asked—

“Your boss?”

“Not my boss.”

“Then?”

Pradeep did not answer.

On paper the relationship had been “finance head—external accounts.”

In life, the hierarchy had been obvious.

After Keshav’s first week and his meeting with counsel, a message came through the lawyer—

“Pradeep is lying.”

Pradeep’s lawyer asked—

“Your response?”

Pradeep said—

“In court.”

That small sentence marked a change inside him.

Before, he had made papers in order to alter reality.

Now he wanted the papers to record reality.



In the prison library, Pradeep met a new inmate.

His name was Soumitra Paswan.

Age twenty.

An ITI student.

His case: his bank account had been used in three separate cybercrime complaints.

He kept saying—

“I only gave them the account.”

“How much money?”

“Three thousand a month.”

“Did you know?”

“They said it was digital business.”

“Did you suspect anything?”

Soumitra fell silent.

Pradeep looked at him.

The experience of seeing himself was unbearable.

“Did you read the papers?”

“No.”

“The OTPs?”

“Brother, don’t ask all this. The police have already asked everything.”

Pradeep fell silent.

He was not trying to understand the method of the crime. He was trying to understand its consequence.

“Home?”

“My mother is alone.”

“Bail?”

“Granted. The problem is the bond and finding a local surety.”

Pradeep gave him the name of a volunteer in the prison legal-aid room.

The next day he helped prepare the application.

The same hand that had once chosen false headings for bills now corrected the wording of a poor young man’s bail petition.

This was not atonement.

It did not erase history.

But a human being’s next act need not be identical to the last.



Soumitra walked out three weeks later.

His mother was waiting at the prison gate.

Pradeep remained inside.

That night he understood for the first time that judicial process did not move at the same speed for two people.

The person whose family could arrange a lawyer, a surety, documents, and travel expenses got out sooner.

The one whose family could not remained inside “process” for longer.

The law could be the same.

Capacity was not.

Here the propositions of Nyāya philosophy collided with economic sociology.

Pradeep wrote in his prison diary—

“Equal rules do not produce equal outcomes.”

The page was not meant for anyone else to see.

It was for himself.



For the first time, Vihan Sarang found himself alone in the boardroom of Ambar Interactive.

Some investors wanted the company sold.

Some wanted the brand changed.

Some said, “Keshav acted on his own.”

Vihan put a hand on the table and asked—

“Do we truly believe that sentence?”

No one answered.

“We kept the main product running. Night kept growing outside. Compliance warnings came. We asked questions, then accepted ‘outside agency’ as the answer.”

One director said—

“Legal responsibility is a separate question.”

“I am not asking a legal question.”

The room fell silent.

Vihan’s face looked tired.

“We may be able to save the company. But if saving it means pouring every stain onto Keshav, then the culture that made all this possible will survive.”

The speech did not make him a saint.

He too had seen warnings earlier and failed to stop.

But in a story of crime, the possibility of reform is not the same thing as simple heroism.



Vihan voluntarily handed the state investigation team a collection of internal emails.

The legal team reviewed them first, within the limits of lawful authority.

One email connected unexpectedly with Satyaprakash’s old history.

An elderly adviser from the founding period of Ambar Sports Media had written—

“Do not use the source of the disputed payment from Digant’s old programme. The S.K. objection is part of the history.”

S.K.

Satyaprakash Karna?

The email had been written years after the event.

But it meant that some people inside the company knew of the old objection.

The adviser’s name was Nalin Barua.

Alive.

Rachna arrived at yet another old door.



Nalin Barua said—

“S.K. was Satyaprakash Karna.”

This time the initials became a name immediately—the speaker himself confirmed it.

“How do you know?”

“At the time I was a junior member of Digant’s external audit team.”

“Did you meet Satyaprakash?”

“Once.”

“What did he say?”

“He was asking about the source of the money.”

“Whom was he asking?”

“Our team.”

“Ambar?”

“Ambar was only a service provider then.”

“Digant?”

“Yes.”

“His death?”

Nalin fell silent.

“I heard the news of the accident.”

“Did you suspect anything?”

“Everyone did at the time.”

“Evidence?”

“No.”

“Haricharan Mandal?”

Nalin frowned.

“I had heard the name.”

“His role?”

“I don’t know.”

“Devanshu?”

“He was angry.”

Rachna’s pen stopped.

“Did you witness that directly?”

“In a meeting.”

“What did he say?”

Nalin thought for a long time.

“The sense was—this man is stopping the work.”

“Murder or a threat?”

“No.”

“Any talk of a different measure?”

“I did not hear any.”

The answer strengthened the economic motive against Devanshu, not a murder case.

Rachna was not disappointed.

By now she knew the value of that distinction.



Nalin added one more thing.

“While tracing the source of the payment, Satyaprakash reached the old funds of Samriddhi Gram-Finance.”

“Chandra?”

Nalin looked startled.

“How do you know that name?”

“Answer the question.”

“Yes. Shashibhushan Lal.”

“Alive at the time?”

“Yes.”

“Connection with Digant?”

“No direct ownership. He arranged money.”

“Did Satyaprakash meet him?”

“I had heard that he did.”

“Direct knowledge?”

“No.”

The boundary again.

But a new direction for inquiry.

Shashibhushan was dead.

His daughter Aditi was alive.

Was there any paper recording a meeting between her father and Satyaprakash?



This time Aditi Lal brought out an old trunk herself.

“After you left last time, I kept thinking all night.”

Inside were her father Shashibhushan’s private papers.

Business letters.

Invitations.

A diary.

On one page—

“S. Karna came. Too many questions about the sports money. Devanshu will be angry. Explained—keep away.”

The date—twelve days before Satyaprakash’s death.

Rachna stared at the sentence, stunned.

“Explained—keep away.”

To whom?

To Satyaprakash?

To Devanshu?

To himself?

The grammar was ambiguous.

Aditi said—

“Father wrote in short fragments like that.”

“Do you remember anything?”

“I was studying away from home at the time.”

Rachna obtained a lawful copy of the page.

The picture of Satyaprakash’s final days was now clearer—

He had reached the source of the old money.

He had met Shashibhushan.

A private note said Devanshu would be angry.

Nine days later, Satyaprakash was dead.

But the final link—someone sending a vehicle, someone planning the act—remained blank.

The story felt sufficient to prove murder.

Not in a court of law.

Here literature and justice parted ways.

A reader of a novel may join meanings together.

Before the state punishes a human being, it needs the link.



On the strength of this new material, Rachna recommended formally reopening the old death investigation.

“A murder case?” the senior officer asked.

“Suspicious death—re-examination.”

“After twenty years?”

“New documentary evidence.”

“Against whom?”

“Against no one yet.”

The senior officer laughed wearily—

“The press will eat us alive.”

Rachna replied—

“The appetite of the press is not an FIR.”

Permission was granted.

Ishaan learned of it only after the public order had been issued.

On the phone he asked Aniruddh only—
“Now?”

Aniruddh said—

“Now the investigation will run again.”

“Murder proved?”

“No.”

Ishaan drew a long breath.

“I knew you would say that.”

“Do you hate that answer less than you used to?”

“No.”

Then, after a few moments—

“But I understand it more.”

That was enough for Aniruddh.



After Keshav’s arrest, the private gambling network did not shut down at once.

Some groups resurfaced under new names.

Some agents disappeared.

Some users moved to other applications.

But the banks received a risk list.

Many mule accounts were frozen.

Then came the problem—

the same freeze trapped both criminal money and a family’s wages.

Sabina Khatoon’s account too was completely frozen.

Her daughter’s dental treatment was on the verge of being postponed.

At a bank-coordination meeting, Rachna said—

“The investigation must not be obstructed, but we need a fast mechanism to verify indisputably personal income.”

An officer said—

“It is difficult to examine every account separately.”

Ishaan, invited from the risk-mapping project, spoke for the first time—

“Then criminals will choose the poorest account-holders—because the state has no facility for quickly separating the innocent portion.”

The room fell silent.

This was not merely a humanitarian argument.

It was also an argument for crime prevention.

A new procedure was created—for rapid examination of claims arising from clearly identifiable sources such as basic living expenses, wages, scholarships and medical treatment.

It was not a complete solution.
 But some money was released for Sabina's daughter's treatment.
 Sabina wept on the phone as she said—
 "I made a mistake. But what did my child do?"
 That question remained unanswered in the investigation file.



One evening in Garh Narikel, Mrinalini sat alone on the verandah.
 Ishaan was in the capital city.
 Dhaneshwari was gone.
 Satyaprakash's photograph was inside.
 The grass was wet after the rain.
 A cobra emerged at the rear of the courtyard.
 Mrinalini froze.
 She did not scream.
 The snake moved slowly towards the threshold.
 Just then the bushes burst apart.
 The mongoose sprang out in front of it.
 For one instant, the two bodies held still.
 A hiss.
 The fur along the mongoose's back stood on end.
 Mrinalini held her breath.
 There was no fight.
 The cobra changed direction and vanished into the grass.
 The mongoose remained beside the threshold for a few moments.
 Then it too went away.
 Mrinalini kept looking at the empty space for a long time.
 Then she said softly—
 "Not every battle has to be won. Sometimes it is enough not to let it reach the house."
 That night Ishaan called.
 Mrinalini did not tell him about the snake.
 She asked only—
 "Have you eaten?"
 "Yes."
 "Work?"
 "It is going on."
 "Your father's?"
 Ishaan paused.
 "Reopened."

Mrinalini closed her eyes.
“This time, do not leave the bank.”
Ishaan’s throat tightened.
“You sound like Dadi.”
“I live in the same house.”



At night, Rachna Sinha sat alone in the investigation room in the capital city.

Two lines were drawn on the board.
One, twenty years old—
Samriddhi.
Shashibhushan.
Digant.
Satyaprakash.
The accident.
The other, present-day—
Uttarayan.
Ambar.
The Night Room.
Mule accounts.
Pradeep.
Keshav.
There were several bridges between the two lines.
Some proved.
Some possible.
Some turned out to be nothing more than similarities of names and broke apart.
Rachna picked up a red pen.
Then put it down again.
Red assigns guilt too quickly.
With a black pen she wrote only one word—
“Purpose?”
Among the sixteen categories of Nyāya philosophy, purpose is no small term.
Why does a human being act?
Profit?
Fear?
Revenge?
To save an institution?

Family?

Debt?

Honour?

Ishaan wanted an answer because of his father.

Keshav had kept silent because of profit.

Pradeep had altered papers because of work and fear.

Sabina had given her account because of medical treatment.

Satyaprakash had asked questions because of responsibility.

And someone—perhaps—had stopped him.

But the state cannot write a punishment after a ‘perhaps.’

Rachna added one line beneath the word on the board—

“Purpose gives direction; evidence proves guilt.”

The night outside was deep.

The Kamala-Balan was far from here.

But the story was moving once again towards those waters.

The monitor lizard had still not surfaced.

But this time the mongoose was not alone.

On the bank now stood questions, papers, data, prison statements, the memories of victims, and disciplined doubt—all keeping watch.



As soon as the investigation into Satyaprakash’s death was reopened, the newspapers of the capital city searched out old photographs.

One newspaper devoted half a page to the question: “Was a twenty-year-old accident murder?”

Another asked: “From the black money of the contract network to digital gambling?”

A third carried the sharpest headline—

“A Family’s Twenty-Year Wait for Justice.”

Mrinalini folded the newspaper the moment she saw the headline.

Whether she had in fact been waiting all this time was not a simple question either.

For the first five years, every telephone call made her start.

Until the tenth year, she kept wiping the dust from Satyaprakash’s file.

After the fifteenth year, she changed the place where his photograph stood.

Around the twentieth year she had begun to think: if no answer was going to come, why keep life locked inside the room of a question?

Now the state had opened the door again.

Reporters stood outside the house.

One asked, “Did you suspect murder from the beginning?”

Another: “What do you say about Devanshu Rakshit?”

Another: “Is the old case connected with online gambling?”

Mrinalini answered none of them.

On the phone Ishaan said—

“Ma, come to the capital city for a few days.”

“Why should I leave my own house?”

“The media.”

“They will tire.”

“And if they do not?”

Mrinalini said calmly—

“If the cobra is outside the house, one does not abandon the house.”

Dhaneshwari’s voice rose in Ishaan’s mind.

Within the same house, a sentence remained alive as generations changed.



Rachna Sinha went to re-examine the old accident site.

The road had changed.

The two lanes of those days were now four.

The tea stall was gone.

A petrol pump stood on the adjoining field.

The old culvert had been removed and replaced by a new drain.

Where Satyaprakash’s vehicle had fallen, there now stood an iron advertising pole.

“Can anything be reconstructed here?” Rohit asked.

Rachna looked around.

“Physically, very little.”

The measurements in the old case diary, the site sketch, the vehicle examination and the post-mortem report were all laid out.

A present-day accident-reconstruction expert examined the old data.

“An impact by a heavy vehicle is possible.”

“Deliberate?” Rachna asked.

The expert shook his head.

“This material cannot tell us that.”

“The brakes?”

“Satyaprakash’s vehicle shows signs of a sudden swerve and braking. Some obstruction may have appeared in front of him.”

“A truck?”

“Possible.”

“A plan?”

“Science does not read purpose.”

Rachna wrote down that sentence.

Physics can read a collision.

Not the intention of a mind.

For purpose, one must return to the human world.



One of Haricharan Mandal’s old associates was found alive—Basudev Marik.

Twenty years earlier he had been a driver.

Now he kept a grocery shop in his village.

His face fell the moment he saw the police.

“I left all that behind.”

Rachna said—

“I have not come to arrest you.”

“Then?”

“Haricharan Mandal.”

The tea in Basudev’s hand trembled.

“Dead.”

“Satyaprakash Karna?”

He was silent.

Rachna waited.

“I had heard the name.”

“The accident?”

“In the newspaper.”

“Where was Haricharan at that time?”

“I do not remember.”

“Devanshu Rakshit?”

Basudev lowered his eyes.

“Contractor people.”

“Did Haricharan work for Digant?”

“Sometimes.”

“Solving problems?”

Basudev laughed bitterly.

“Big people use words like that. For small people, the work is different.”

“What kind of work?”

“Frighten someone. Stop someone’s vehicle. Drive away someone’s labourers.”

“Beat someone?”

Basudev looked directly at Rachna.

“Shall I say only what I have seen?”

“Yes.”

“A beating once. Not a killing.”

“Satyaprakash?”

“I do not know.”

Then, after a long silence, he added on his own—

“But before the accident, Haricharan was looking for a heavy vehicle.”

Rachna’s body went taut.

“For what?”

“I do not know.”

“Whose vehicle?”

“A transporter he knew.”

“Name?”

Basudev closed his eyes.

“Kaushal...”

Rohit’s pen began to move.

Basudev immediately said—

“Not Mahto. Some old transporter named Kaushal. I do not remember the surname.”

The shadow of the false suspicion that had fallen on Kaushal Mahto at the beginning of the investigation twenty years earlier rose again.

Rachna looked at Rohit.

Both were thinking the same thing—
the hunger for names.

“Would you recognize his face?” Rachna asked.

“Perhaps.”

“‘Perhaps’ is enough. Do not force yourself to say yes.”

Basudev visibly relaxed.



The old transport-licensing records produced five men named Kaushal.

Two were dead.

One was abroad.

One had taken up farming.

One—Kaushal Kishore Chaubey—had then operated ‘Chaubey Freight Carriers.’

The company later closed.

Kaushal Kishore Chaubey was no longer alive.

But his son—Rajat Chaubey—now ran a motor-parts business in the capital city.

Rajat grew uncomfortable when questioned about his father.

“Babu rented vehicles to many people.”

“Haricharan Mandal?”

“I have heard the name.”

“Digant?”

“Yes.”

“The night of Satyaprakash’s accident?”

“I was in college.”

“Old ledgers?”

Rajat was silent for a few moments.

“There may be some in the warehouse.”

A ledger was found in the warehouse.

And on one page, beside the date—

“H.M.—night—heavy.”

No vehicle number.

The hire paid in cash.

‘H.M.’—Haricharan Mandal?

Possible.

The other part of the page had been eaten by rats.

Basudev was not simply shown the ledger; under proper procedure, a separate photographic identification was conducted first.

He was not certain when shown an old photograph of Kaushal Kishore Chaubey.

“Could be.”

Again, the same limit.

But the ledger was an independent indication.

For the first time in the old investigation, there was a documentary thread suggesting that a heavy vehicle had been sought on the night of the accident.

The final vehicle number was still unknown.



Rachna did not immediately tell Mrinalini about this discovery.

Because every new indication could become ‘now it is proved’ for the family.

Verification first.

The age of the paper in Rajat’s ledger, the handwriting, and its consistency with other business pages were examined.

Everything matched.

There was no sign that the entry had been fabricated.

What did 'H.M.' mean?

On two other pages, 'Hari' had later been written beside 'H.M.'

An old bill named the client as 'Haricharan M.'

The possibility was now stronger.

Rachna wrote on the board—

Haricharan → heavy vehicle → night of death?

The question mark remained.

Rohit said—

"This looks like murder."

Rachna replied—

"It does."

"That is the first time you have accepted the word."

"Because now there is a cluster of indicators."

"Then an FIR for murder?"

"Not yet. The use of the vehicle has not been proved."

Rohit laughed.

"Another half-step."

"Justice often moves in half-steps."



Pressure on Manoj Nayak was mounting within the present-day gambling network.

Keshav had been arrested.

Pradeep was giving his statement.

The financial image of the Night Room computers had been secured.

Manoj had so far remained outside arrest because the available evidence did not go beyond recruitment and promotion.

But a new witness appeared—Ritesh Das.

Not by himself.

He was found admitted to a private hospital.

Not a road accident.

A beating.

Two ribs broken.

His face swollen.

The hospital had already informed the police.

When Rachna arrived, the first thing Ritesh said was—

"I will not say anything."

"All right."

Rachna pulled up a chair and sat down.

"I will not even question you just now."

Ritesh looked surprised.

“Then why have you come?”

“Because your name is in my file. And someone has beaten you. The two things may be connected—or they may not.”

Ritesh turned his face away.

“I fell.”

“The hospital doctor has reported an assault to the police.”

Silence.

“If you wish, you may have a lawyer.”

Silence.

“Family?”

Ritesh’s eyes filled.

“My mother.”

“Where?”

“In the village.”

“Have you told her?”

“No.”

Rachna asked the nurse to bring him water.

As she rose to leave, Ritesh said softly—

“Manoj was looking for me.”

Rachna sat down again.

“Did Manoj beat you himself?”

“No.”

“Then?”

“Two men came.”

“On whose word?”

“They said Manoj-bhaiya was angry.”

“Why?”

“I had stopped recruiting accounts.”

The first direct link.



Arrangements were made for Ritesh’s statement to be recorded before a magistrate.

He admitted—

It was he who had proposed the account arrangement to Abhishek.

Lokvistar’s regional team gave him targets for recruiting “payment associates.”

A commission for every active account.

“Did you know it was illegal?” the magistrate asked.

Ritesh remained silent.

“Not at first.”

“Later?”

“Yes.”

“When?”

“When one account-holder came with a police complaint.”

“Then why did you not stop?”

Ritesh lowered his eyes.

“Money.”

One word.

“Manoj Nayak?”

“He gave me the targets.”

“The Night Room?”

“He did not run it directly. But he knew about it.”

“Keshav?”

“Never met him.”

“Pradeep?”

“No.”

“Who was above Manoj?”

“Manoj used to say—do not ask about the people above me.”

“A name?”

“Once he said ‘Uday Babu.’”

Another half-name.

Uday.

Uttarayan?

Udayan?

Udayrekha?

The investigative mind wanted to leap again.

Rachna wrote only this in her notes—

Uday Babu—Ritesh’s statement; independent corroboration required.



Manoj Nayak was summoned for questioning again.

This time with a lawyer.

Rachna placed the assault issue before him directly.

“I know nothing about it.”

“Ritesh says you were angry with him.”

“Is being angry a crime?”

“No.”

“Do you have proof that I had him beaten?”

“It is under investigation.”

Manoj’s face remained calm.

“Uday Babu?”

An eyelid flickered slightly.

“There are many Udais.”

“Above you?”

“The company structure.”

“The owner of Lokvistar?”

“Viraj Chaudhary.”

“Uday?”

“Perhaps an adviser.”

“Full name?”

Manoj laughed.

“I do not remember.”

Rachna closed her notebook.

“Has your memory also become twenty years old now?”

The lawyer intervened—

“Please, no sarcasm.”

Rachna apologized.

Sarcasm is not argument.

Nor is anger at a suspect evidence.

Manoj was allowed to leave—for now.

But the legally available records of his calls, travel and financial activity went back under scrutiny.

The work was now to find one name—

Uday.



Lokvistar Digital Services’ corporate records listed no director named “Uday.”

But an old consultancy agreement named one man—

Udaynath Mishra.

Profession—business-expansion consulting.

Age fifty-two.

He had earlier worked in marketing for a foreign company associated with sports betting; after returning to India, he had advised several digital companies.

Nothing criminal on paper.

Udaynath’s current address was in a quiet residential complex on the outskirts of the capital city.

A summons was issued.
The reply—
“One week’s time on health grounds.”
The medical certificate was genuine.
Rachna accepted the delay.
Rohit asked—
“What if he runs?”
“Surveillance is in place within lawful limits.”
“Can we arrest him immediately?”
“For what offence?”
Rohit fell silent.
Rachna said—
“The name of a suspicion is not an arrest warrant.”



Meanwhile, the tragedy of online gambling broke open in another home.

Name—Shailesh Mandal.

Assistant teacher in a government school.

Wife—Aarti.

One son, one daughter.

At first he merely watched cricket.

Then small contests on his phone.

Then private wagers.

A win in the first month.

Losses in the second.

Then the attempt to win back what had been lost.

Debt.

Jewellery pawned.

A lie to his wife—“I invested in a friend’s business.”

The investigation team found Shailesh’s name through a bank complaint, not as an offender but as a victim.

When Rachna reached his house, Aarti opened the door.

Shailesh was not at home.

Missing for three days.

Phone switched off.

The family had already filed a missing-person report.

In a table drawer lay one sheet of paper—

“I have ruined everything.”

Nothing more.

No one could declare him dead.

No one could assume suicide.

Only a missing man.

Rachna immediately coordinated with the local search team.

The river?

Bus stand?

Railway?

Hospitals?

No conclusion.

Aarti asked—

“Was he a criminal?”

Rachna said—

“He was gambling online. He had borrowed money. At present I do not know whether he committed any crime or merely ruined himself.”

Aarti broke down—

“‘Merely?’”

Rachna stopped.

The wrong word.

“I am sorry.”

Aarti said through tears—

“He ruined the house. Stopped the children’s fees. My jewellery. Lies. This is not ‘merely.’”

Rachna lowered her head.

Even the word victim is not singular.

The gambler may himself be trapped.

His family may be victims of his actions.

And the network may be the predator feeding on his weakness.

One person can be both culpable and victimized at the same time.



Four days later, Shailesh was found alive.

In a distant dharamshala.

Hungry.

Exhausted.

He had fled—not to die, but because he could not face his family.

The police began the process of restoring him to his family.

Rachna did not interrogate him; she only took his statement.

“The Night Room?”

Shailesh looked up.

“I do not know that name.”

“Where did you play?”

“In a private group.”

“Did anyone ask you to provide an account?”

“To pay off my losses.”

“Did you?”

“No.”

“Why?”

“My government salary comes into my bank account.”

“Then?”

“They told me to bring other people and I would get a commission.”

Rachna went still.

From gambler to mule recruiter.

A user crushed by debt was being turned into a recruiter of the next account-holder.

The network was turning its customer into its worker.

Shailesh said—

“I asked a boy in my neighbourhood.”

“Did he give his account?”

“No. His father abused me.”

He began to cry.

“I am a teacher.”

He said the words for himself, not for Rachna.

The distance between his profession and his conduct was breaking something inside him.

The tragedy here was not death.

It was having to remain alive and look at his own face.



A new category was added to Ishaan’s mule-risk report—

“Secondary recruitment by indebted gambling users.”

He examined the data.

Among those who entered hoping to recover gambling losses, some later accepted commissions for procuring accounts.

Recruitment into the criminal network was no longer driven only by unemployment.

Addiction itself was becoming a labour market.

Ishaan wrote in the report—

“The economic damage caused by a gambling network can become double: first the individual loses money; then, in order to recover those losses, he begins to serve the network.”

Sumedha Ghosh read the sentence and asked—

“Is this conclusion supported by the data?”

“Small sample.”

“Then soften the language.”

Ishaan revised the sentence—

“In the preliminary sample, a tendency of this kind is visible...”

He laughed.

“Evidence has changed the language again.”

Sumedha said—

“In scientific writing, that is not a weakness.”

“In life?”

“There people prefer definite sentences.”

Ishaan remembered the newspaper at his mother’s house.

“Was it murder?”

One question.

But inside the answer lay twenty years of caution.



Udaynath Mishra arrived on the appointed day.

No suit.

A plain kurta.

A lawyer with him.

He was self-assured.

“Manoj Nayak?”

“Worked with us.”

“Ritesh Das?”

“I do not know him.”

“The Night Room?”

“I have heard of unauthorized activity in the market.”

“Keshav Mehta?”

“A professional acquaintance.”

“Uttarayan?”

“An investor group.”

“Pradeep Mahajan?”

“I have heard the name.”

“The structure of Ambar’s external private-betting network?”

“My work was lawful user-growth strategy.”

Rachna asked—

“A model in which losing users were turned into payment associates?”

For the first time, Udaynath’s face went still.

“Is that an accusation?”

“A question.”

“I designed no such model.”

“Manoj says—”

“What Manoj says is Manoj’s responsibility.”

“Ritesh says ‘Uday Babu.’”

“There are thousands of Udays in this country.”

Rachna turned a page in the file.

“Lokvistar training presentation—‘User Value Recovery.’ Author initials:
U.M.”

Udaynath’s lawyer leaned forward.

“Show us the presentation.”

A lawfully obtained copy was shown.

Its language was entirely that of legitimate marketing—

reactivate dormant users;

referrals;

community associates;

payment facilitation.

Nowhere did it say “mule.”

Nowhere did it say “gambling.”

Rachna asked—

“Is this yours?”

Udaynath read it.

“Yes. For lawful promotion.”

““Payment facilitation?””

“Customer support.”

“Accounts?”

“I did not write ‘recruit bank accounts.’”

True.

Sometimes the deceit of words belongs to the person who writes the document.

Sometimes to the person who reads it.

This page did not prove a crime.

But the question remained alive: what had the blueprint become on the ground?



Udaynath’s financial activity looked clean.

Consultancy fees.

Taxes.

A house.

No unusual cash.

Rohit was disappointed.

Rachna was not.

“If he supplied the intellectual framework, the money could have travelled by another route.”

Mayank said—

“Or he may truly be an innocent consultant.”

“Both possibilities remain.”

Aniruddh said over the phone—

“Now reason it out.”

Rachna asked—

“Reason it out?”

“If Udaynath is at the centre of the crime, what independent facts should we expect to find?”

Rachna made a list—

Manoj’s instructions.

The name Ritesh had heard.

The presentation.

Contact with Keshav.

An introduction to the Uttarayan investors.

“And if he is innocent?”

“Legitimate marketing; people lower down distorted the instructions.”

“At present, how many facts fit both theories?”

Rachna was silent.

Almost all of them.

Aniruddh said—

“Then a decision now would be premature.”

In Nyāya, tarka—reasoned supposition—is not merely a way to defeat an opponent.

It is the discipline of constructing two possible worlds and asking which facts can survive inside which one.



The old Satyaprakash investigation was also set out as two such worlds.

First—

Satyaprakash uncovered a payment network; Digant was angered; Haricharan procured a heavy vehicle; the crash was planned.

Second—

Satyaprakash did block the payment, and Digant was indeed angry; Haricharan procured the vehicle for some other work; Satyaprakash's crash was an independent event.

Which fact fit only the first world?

Nothing decisive yet.

"H.M.—night—heavy" was possible in both.

Motive existed in both.

Timing existed in both.

No vehicle number.

No instruction.

No payment.

No witness.

Rachna stood before the board for a long time.

"Will history allow me to call it murder?"

Aniruddh said—

"History, perhaps. A court, perhaps not."

"The family?"

"The family will hold its own belief."

"The State?"

"The State needs more."

The answer was just.

It was not satisfying.

In another word—

tragedy.



A new fact appeared in Manoj's phone records.

Two hours before the attack on Ritesh, Manoj had called the operator of a security agency.

The operator was Raghubir Tanti.

His agency supplied private security for Lokvistar events.

Later, Raghubir's phone had been in contact with the phone of one of the two men whom hospital-area camera footage placed near Ritesh on the night of the assault.

The link was not direct, but it was strong.

Manoj was called in again.

Rachna put the call timings before him.

"Raghubir?"

"Event security."

"On the day of the attack?"

“Coincidence.”

“Raghubir, then those two men?”

“I do not know.”

“Ritesh?”

“I was angry with him.”

“Why?”

“He walked away from the work.”

“Threats?”

“No.”

“What did you tell Raghubir?”

Manoj was silent.

He consulted his lawyer.

Then he said—

“To find him and talk to him.”

“To beat him?”

“No.”

“Why did two men go?”

“Raghubir’s decision.”

For the first time Manoj had reached the edge of the incident itself.

The question of criminal responsibility was now sharper—

say “go talk to him”;

the men sent to talk beat him;

where does the boundary of the order lie?

The investigation now needed Raghubir.

Raghubir was not at home.

His phone was switched off.

His vehicle was gone.

This time the word “missing” really did feel heavy.



Raghubir was caught three days later at the state border.

The arrest was ordinary.

No gunfire.

No chase.

Only a vehicle-document check at a checkpoint.

At first he said—

“Manoj Bhैया only told me to talk to him.”

“Why two men?”

“Ritesh might have run.”

“The beating?”

“I did not tell them to do that.”

“Then who did?”

“They did it on their own.”

“So there is no responsibility?”

Raghubir was silent.

Rachna asked—

“If you send two strong men to ‘explain’ something to someone and they beat him, does changing the word change the act?”

The lawyer objected—

“A philosophical question.”

Rachna nodded.

“Fair.”

She withdrew the question.

The law would frame its own language for responsibility.

But the question remained inside the story.

Deceit is not only a false word.

Sometimes it is a word whose meaning everyone understands, though no one writes it down.



Across the separate statements of Keshav, Manoj and Raghubir, a new name did not recur again and again; it appeared only once in each place—

“Saurabh Bhaiya.”

Who was he?

In an old message from Manoj—

“Saurabh Bhaiya says reduce the Night targets.”

In Keshav’s note—

“S.B. unhappy—protect the main brand.”

Raghubir said—

“Saurabh Babu was one of the big people behind the programmes.”

And in the distribution list for Udaynath Mishra’s presentation—

“S. Bardhan.”

Full name—

Saurabh Bardhan.

Head of operations at the Uttarayan Social Investment Fund.

Not a member of Ambar’s board.

Not Lokvistar’s formal owner.

But the investor side’s representative.

For the first time, one person from “above” was emerging from several independent sources.

Rachna did not immediately seek his arrest.

First the documents.

Travel.

Emails.

Meetings.

Financial interest.

Saurabh Bardhan was not abroad; he was in the capital.

The next day, through his lawyer, he himself said—

“I will cooperate.”

Whether the monitor lizard had raised its eyes above the water for the first time—or whether this was merely another shadow—was still too early to say.



That night in Garh Narikel, Mrinalini held Satyaprakash’s old spectacles in her hand.

They had lain in the desk drawer for twenty years.

Fine scratches on the lenses.

The frame loose.

No one used them.

She put them on.

The world blurred.

Satyaprakash’s prescription was not hers.

She took them off and laughed—for a moment.

Then she began to cry.

A person wishes to see the world through the eyes of the dead.

But wearing their glass does not give you their sight.

What had Satyaprakash seen?

How much had he seen?

Whom had he recognized?

The papers now said this much: he had seen something.

But his final view had gone with him.

A small sound came from the doorway—the kind the mongoose sometimes made.

Mrinalini opened the door.

No mongoose was visible.

Only the night.

She did not return the spectacles to the drawer.

She placed them beside Satyaprakash’s photograph.

Whether an answer came or not—

memory would now live openly in the house again.



Rachna Sinha opened Saurabh Bardhan's file.

First page—
education;
finance;
social investment.

Second—
the Uttarayan Fund.

Third—
Ambar's early capital expansion.

Fourth—
approval of Lokvistar's strategic contract.

Fifth—
meetings with Keshav Mehta.

Sixth—
a private email from the period when the Night Room was expanding, its
subject line simply—

"Risk to the Main Brand."

The message was short—

"Whatever cannot be placed on a public platform must remain within
limits of expansion. The profit is useful, but the core institution must not
sink."

Rachna fell silent after reading it.

Was this a confession to crime?

No.

But what was "whatever cannot be placed on a public platform"?

A lawful private experiment?

Regulatory risk?

Illegal betting?

Context was still required.

Then the final line—

"Keep the accounting for the old source separate from P.M."

P.M.

Pradeep Mahajan?

Old source.

Once again the present and the past occupied the same sentence.

Rachna did not close the file.

It was very late.

But this time a different fear had entered the exhaustion of the investigation—

perhaps the centre was truly beginning to come into view.

And if it did, this would no longer be the story of arresting a single offender.

Twenty-year-old money; a dead contractor; families submerged in online gambling; poor people trapped in mule accounts; an accountant sitting in prison; a director trying to save a brand—all of them would condense into one question—

how many people's small silences have to gather before they become a monitor lizard?

Rachna went to the board.

Beneath "Purpose?" she wrote a new word—

"Conjunction."

Many parts joining to form one structure.

Justice is not merely the search for one guilty name.

Sometimes it is the work of understanding an entire structure.

The first light of dawn stood outside.

The watch on the bank continued.



Saurabh Bardhan arrived fifteen minutes before the appointed time.

He had no need to be late.

Running from the inquiry was not his strategy.

Perhaps he believed that so long as he remained within what existed on paper, he would remain safe.

Rachna Sinha placed the file before him.

"Uttarayan."

"Yes."

"Ambar."

"An investee company."

"Lokvistar."

"An external marketing partner."

"The Night Room."

For the first time Saurabh gave a faint smile.

"That phrase has become famous now."

"Do you know it?"

"I saw it in an internal risk report."

"When?"

He gave a date.

Rachna checked her notes.

The date was much later than Keshav's private note.

"Not before that?"

"No."

"This email?"

Rachna placed a printed copy before him.

"Whatever cannot be placed on a public platform must remain within limits of expansion. The profit is useful, but the core institution must not sink."

Saurabh read it.

"Mine."

"What did 'cannot be placed on a public platform' mean?"

"Regulatory ambiguity."

"Illegality?"

"No."

"Private betting?"

"I did not have full information at that time."

"The profit is useful?"

"Investor language."

"Keep the accounting for the old source separate from P.M.?"

Saurabh's face hardened slightly.

"The old source was investor capital."

"Whose?"

"Uttarayan's."

"P.M.?"

"Pradeep Mahajan."

"Then you did know Pradeep."

Saurabh paused for a moment.

"Very little personally. I knew his role."

Rachna stopped her pen.

The first small contradiction.

Earlier: "I had heard the name."

Now: he knew the role.

"Earlier you said you had only heard his name."

"Perhaps I understood the context of the question differently."

"Perhaps."

Rachna returned the word to him.

Saurabh did not smile.



Nothing decisive emerged in the next hour of questioning.

But a structure began to take clearer form.

At the investor level, Uttarayan watched profit.

Ambar was the main brand.

Lokvistar drove user growth.

The Night Room handled private betting outside the official system.

Pradeep handled financial adjustments.

Keshav preserved the clean appearance of the principal accounts.

Manoj recruited in the field.

Raghubir supplied pressure.

It was a structure in which every person could say—

“I knew only my part.”

Conjunction.

Rachna remembered the word on the board.

She asked Saurabh—

“If everyone knew only his own part, who knew the whole network?”

Saurabh answered—

“Perhaps no one.”

“Then how did it run?”

“The system.”

“Does a system make decisions by itself?”

“In many companies, explicit orders are rare.”

“And in crime?”

Saurabh looked at his lawyer.

“I am not admitting to a crime.”

“I am asking a question.”

“Then my answer is this: people make rules, and then the rules begin to move the people.”

Rachna saw what the sentence was doing.

It was philosophical.

It was also a defence.

If “the system” was guilty, the individual blurred.

A court cannot send a system to prison.



The lawful examination of Saurabh’s phone and emails revealed the record of an important meeting.

Location—the Uttarayan guest house.

Present—

Saurabh.

Keshav.

Manoj.

Udaynath.

Pradeep.

Date—approximately six months before the Night Room's financial activity accelerated.

The subject recorded on paper—

"Secondary User Circulation."

An odd phrase.

Rachna called Udaynath in again.

"Secondary user circulation?"

Udaynath read the document.

"Customer reactivation."

"Account recruitment?"

"No."

"Losing users?"

"Some."

"Payment facilitation?"

"Some."

"Manoj was at the meeting."

"Field operations."

"Pradeep?"

"Finance."

"Keshav?"

"The company."

"Saurabh?"

"The investor."

"Then why were all those roles present at an ordinary marketing meeting?"

Udaynath was silent.

Rachna asked—

"After this meeting, the number of Night Room accounts rose."

"I do not know the data."

"Ritesh says targets were raised during this period."

"His statement."

"Pradeep says old-source money was routed into new settlements."

"His statement."

"Keshav's note."

Udaynath's lawyer intervened—

"Please leave the interpretation of evidence to the court."

Rachna nodded.

“Fair.”

Then only one question—

“Was private betting discussed at the meeting?”

Udaynath was silent for a long time.

“Yes.”

The room went still.

“At whose initiative?”

“I do not remember.”

“Did you understand it to be illegal?”

“It was discussed as an area of legal ambiguity.”

“Mule accounts?”

“That term was not used.”

“Other people’s bank accounts?”

“Payment alternatives were discussed.”

“Meaning?”

“I cannot state it clearly.”

Rachna wrote—

Private betting acknowledged as a subject of the meeting.

This time the story moved one step from conjecture toward fact.



Udaynath was not arrested immediately.

Participation and criminal intent were separate questions.

Rachna repeated that point not to the press, but to her own team.

Rohit asked—

“If betting was discussed at the meeting, then?”

“Discussion of betting does not prove agreement to commit a crime.”

“But afterward that is exactly what happened.”

“Then show the chain of causation.”

“How much of a chain do we need?”

Rachna laughed wearily.

“As much as is necessary before taking away a person’s liberty.”

Rohit fell silent.

It is easy to complain that rigorous procedure benefits criminals.

But the same rigour also protects the innocent.

At the beginning of an investigation, no one knows which of those two kinds of person is being protected.

That is why rules cannot change according to the face before them.



Pradeep was now in his third month in the district jail.

He had begun helping regularly in the legal-aid room.

Drafting papers.

Checking dates.

Simplifying the language of letters for prisoners' families.

One day a prison guard brought in a new inmate—

Shailesh Mandal.

The same schoolteacher.

The man whom Rachna had once had returned home after he went missing.

Why was he here now?

The matter had not remained small.

Under the pressure of debt, Shailesh had later recruited two bank accounts; fraudulent funds had entered one of them. The police said he had knowingly taken commission.

Shailesh said he had been under pressure to repay gambling debts.

Pradeep did not recognise him, but when he heard the case, he fell silent.

"A teacher?" he asked.

Shailesh lowered his head.

"I was."

"Your job?"

"Suspended."

"Home?"

"My wife does not speak to me."

Pradeep remembered his own daughter, Trisha.

"Bail?"

"The lawyer says I will get it."

"Then?"

"I am afraid to go outside."

Pradeep stared at him.

"You want to stay in jail?"

Shailesh laughed—hollowly.

"Outside there are my children's eyes."

Pradeep could say nothing.

Prison is punishment.

Sometimes a person turns it into shelter, because shame outside is harsher.

It was a form of tragedy for which the law had no section.



Trisha came again at the next visit.

This time she picked up the telephone.

“Babu.”

Pradeep’s face brightened.

“Yes, child.”

“Everyone at school knows now.”

Pradeep said nothing.

“One girl said, ‘Your father used to wash money.’”

Pradeep closed his eyes.

“What did you say?”

“Nothing.”

“I am sorry.”

Trisha’s voice hardened.

“Why are you apologising to me? Tell the school.”

Pradeep had no answer.

“Ma says the case will go on for a long time.”

“It may.”

“Did you do it?”

“What I told you before—I knowingly made some papers false.”

“For whom?”

“People in companies.”

“Why?”

“At first, because it was my job. Later, because I was afraid. Then it became habit.”

Trisha asked—

“Can habit become a crime?”

Pradeep thought for a long time.

“When wrongdoing begins to feel normal—yes.”

Trisha held the receiver.

“I do not hate you.”

Pradeep began to cry.

“But I do not trust you either.”

That sentence was truer than forgiveness.

Pradeep bowed his head.

“All right.”

On the two sides of the glass, father and daughter did not weep at the same time.

Trisha remained silent.

Pradeep kept crying.



No proceeds of crime had been found flowing directly into Saurabh's personal accounts.

Salary.

Investment returns.

Taxes.

Property.

Everything was orderly.

But one subsidiary of the Uttarayan Fund—Kshitij Asset Management—showed unusual profits in the year when the Night Room was surging.

The source of the profit—

business loans.

To whom?

Three companies that Mayank Jha had earlier identified in the “goods” layer.

Not Neelkanth Aggregates.

Other real businesses.

A grain-trading concern.

A plastic-packaging company.

A small transport business.

Goods were genuinely being sold.

But the interest on the loans was unusually low compared with the market.

Why?

What if the objective was not profit, but getting money into the system?

Mayank said—

“This could be a possible method of money laundering.”

Rachna asked at once—

“Proved?”

“No.”

Mayank laughed.

“Now you ask my question before I do.”

A deeper examination of the accounts showed that the three companies had repaid portions of their loans ahead of schedule, even though their business cash flows were not strong enough to explain it.

Where had the money come from?

In two of the accounts, funds had arrived from intermediaries linked to the mule network.

A financial circle was beginning to close.

Gambling money → intermediary → real business → loan repayment → clean income for the investment company.

The story did not need technical elaboration.
 Its moral meaning was clear—
 dirty money changes roads again and again until, at last, it wears clothes
 in which even a bank may mistake it for an ordinary customer.



Rachna questioned Saurabh again about this structure.

“Kshitij Asset Management?”

“A Uttarayan subsidiary.”

“Loan policy?”

“The committee decided it.”

“You?”

“A member.”

“The loans to these three companies?”

“Three decisions among thousands.”

“Unusually low interest?”

“Strategic investment.”

“Early repayment?”

“The businesses succeeded.”

“Money from the mule network?”

Saurabh fell silent.

His lawyer intervened—

“Show us the evidence of source.”

Rachna placed the table before them.

Saurabh studied it for a long time.

“I did not know transactions at this level.”

“Whose responsibility was it?”

“The finance head’s.”

“Name?”

“Alok Bhasin.”

A new name.

Rachna felt the weariness rise in her.

Was there another centre behind every centre?

Or was responsibility genuinely layered, one level beneath another?

Conjunction again.

“Where is Alok?”

“He resigned two years ago.”

“Now?”

“Singapore, perhaps.”

Rachna wrote only the word “perhaps.”

No drama of an international arrest.
First, the truth.



A lawful backup of Alok Bhasin's old company laptop was available.

Some emails had been deleted.

Some remained.

One email to Saurabh read—

"To ensure that the Night flow has no direct connection, the subsidiary-loan route will be useful."

Saurabh had replied—

"Keep both the main brand and the fund separate."

That was all.

Two lines.

Rachna read them and leaned back in her chair.

Criminal intent?

The defence could say: regulatory separation.

The prosecution could say: concealment of source.

Context, other documents, meetings, the financial route—all of it would have to be joined.

But Saurabh's claim that he "did not know" had weakened.

Rachna prepared a proposal for arrest.

Aditya Shekhar asked—

"Enough?"

"Not enough to prove the offence. Enough for custody, questioning, and a prima facie basis for charges—yes."

The court issued the order.

Saurabh Bardhan was arrested.

No slogans.

No television cameras inside.

There was certainly a crowd outside.

A man once presented as a "respected social investor" was now an accused.

But Rachna told the press again—

"Accused, not guilty."

One reporter muttered—

"That line has become permanent with you."

Rachna heard him.

She did not reply.

Some sentences have to be repeated because society repeatedly forgets them.



News of Saurabh's arrest reached Garh Narikel.

Ishaan was at his mother's house.

The name was on television.

Uttarayan.

Ambar.

Old money.

A brief mention of Satyaprakash's file.

Mrinalini switched off the television.

"Did this man have Babu killed?"

Ishaan was silent.

"I do not know."

"How old was he then?"

Ishaan looked it up.

At the time of Satyaprakash's death, Saurabh had been very young, probably only beginning in the investment world.

Mrinalini laughed—not bitterly, but tiredly.

"Then again, a new man."

"The network may have come into his hands later."

"And Babu?"

"The old people."

"Dead."

"Many of them."

Mrinalini closed her eyes.

"Do you see? The monitor lizard kept changing. I used to think we would find one man—and that would be all."

Ishaan said softly—

"Perhaps there was never only one man."

Mrinalini looked at him.

"Then whom do we give justice to?"

Ishaan had no answer.

Retribution for one person's crime is possible.

Justice for a structure is harder.



In the old investigation, another ledger was found in Rajat Chaubey's warehouse—from the year after the first ledger.

This time one entry for "H.M." also carried a vehicle number.

The date was the day of the night on which Satyaprakash died.

Heavy goods vehicle.

The registration number matched the old transport-department records.
Owner—Chaubey Freight.
The vehicle had later been declared wrecked and sold as scrap.
The date—two months after Satyaprakash's death.
Where had it been wrecked?
The record was unclear.
Insurance claim?
None.
Scrap buyer?
A dealer who was now dead.
Rachna felt her heart beating harder.
For the first time, there was the possibility of an actual vehicle.
But again—
was this the vehicle that struck Satyaprakash?
Colour?
The old witness had said "dark."
The vehicle record said green.
Size—consistent.
Damage?
No scrap record survived.
The forensic physical evidence was gone.
Rachna wrote the vehicle number on the board.
After twenty years, the first concrete object.
But the object itself had vanished.
History's cruel irony.



Basudev Marik was shown an old photographic lineup of vehicles.
He paused at one photograph.
"A vehicle like this."
"This one?"
"I cannot say."
Rachna felt relief that he did not manufacture certainty.
"Haricharan took a vehicle like this?"
"Yes, like this."
"Where?"
"Outside the city at night."
"Were you with him?"
"No."
"Any driver?"

Basudev thought for a long time.

“Fat Ram.”

“Full name?”

“Ramavatar... perhaps.”

Another search began.

Ramavatar Yadav.

Dozens of them.

Twenty years.

Some dead.

Some untraceable.

An old drivers’ union register yielded one Ramavatar Yadav, address—a village across the Kamala-Balan.

Alive?

The village headman said yes.

Over seventy.

Rachna left the next day.



At Ramavatar Yadav’s house, his grandson opened the door.

“Dada cannot speak.”

He had suffered a stroke five years earlier.

The right side of his body was weak.

Memory?

Sometimes.

Rachna went inside.

The old man lay on a cot.

She showed him a photograph.

Haricharan.

His eyes changed.

Ramavatar raised his left hand.

He tried to say something.

The words were indistinct.

His grandson tried to understand.

“‘Hari’...?”

The old man nodded.

The vehicle photograph.

The green goods truck.

The old man’s eyes filled with tears.

He repeated the same gestures—

his hands as if holding a steering wheel.

Then a hand to his chest.
Then he closed his eyes.
The scene could have pushed Rachna's mind toward murder.
But the communication was unclear.
She requested the help of a speech therapist and a magistrate.
The police would not give their own story to the old man's gestures.
The next day came a structured signal test.
Yes/no signals were fixed in advance.
Names.
Vehicle.
Direct memory of the date was difficult.
"Satyaprakash?"—no recognition.
"Haricharan?"—yes.
"Green truck?"—yes.
"Night?"—yes.
"Accident?"—the old man became agitated; the response was unclear.
"Collision?"—he closed his eyes and began to cry.
The magistrate stopped the session.
A human limit.
The hunger for evidence must not become an assault on an old man's health.
Rachna came outside and remained silent for a long time.
Perhaps the last living driver stood before her.
But his body could no longer give words.
Tragedy again.
Truth close.
Language far away.



Three days later Ramavatar's grandson called Rachna himself.
"Dada wants to show you a paper."
Inside an old trunk was a photograph.
A green truck.
On the back, in handwriting—
"Hari Babu's night work—never again."
The date was unclear, but the year matched.
Rachna lawfully seized the photograph.
What did "never again" mean?
Was the work dangerous?
Immoral?

An accident?

Simply exhausting?

No one knew.

But the photograph linked the vehicle, Haricharan, and the driver.

The murder hypothesis had grown much stronger.

There was still no final order.

Devanshu?

Shashibhushan?

Someone else?

Rachna thought: perhaps one day the investigation would prove the crime but not the criminal.

For law, that is an intolerable condition.

For history, it is ordinary.



Saurabh Bardhan was sent to judicial custody.

Not to the district jail, but to the central prison in the capital city.

His lawyers immediately moved for bail.

Health.

Reputation.

The evidence was documentary.

The risk of flight was low.

The prosecution opposed.

The court heard the matter in part and reserved its order.

Outside, the media had already called him the “gambling emperor.”

Rachna saw the reports.

Saurabh might indeed be an important accused in the criminal network.

But the word “emperor” was not evidence.

Once again, the story wanted to turn one man into the entire monitor lizard.

Rachna wrote on the board—

“Conjunction $\neq$ one king.”

One of the safest defences of a criminal network is society’s desire to find a single face.

Once that face falls, society assumes the network has died.

The network’s rules, greed, market, recruitment, silence—remain alive.



Meanwhile, Ishaan was presenting his mule-account risk report before the State Bankers’ Association.

There was no offender's name on any slide.

Only patterns.

Suddenly a senior banker asked—

“Was your father killed during that old contract investigation?”

The room grew uncomfortable.

Ishaan went still for a moment.

“The investigation into his death has been reopened.”

“Is that why you are involved in this subject?”

The question might have been innocent curiosity.

But it cut deep into Ishaan.

“It is possible that, because of that history, I see the human side of risk sooner. But the conclusions in this report are based on anonymised data. Examine my method, not my family.”

The room was silent.

Sumedha Ghosh sat at the back.

There was a faint approval in her eyes.

For the first time in public, Ishaan did not create distance from his father; he created a boundary.

Personal grief can have a use in knowledge.

But grief is not evidence for knowledge.



That night Mrinalini heard about Ishaan's presentation over the phone.

“You did well.”

“Was I too harsh?”

“It was necessary.”

“Ma...”

“Yes?”

“What if Babu's case is never fully proved?”

Silence.

The distant sound of the Kamala-Balan was not in the phone; it was in memory.

Mrinalini said slowly—

“At first I wanted a name. Then I wanted punishment. Then only the truth. Now I understand—the truth too may never become complete.”

Ishaan's throat tightened.

“Then?”

“Whatever you find, do not spoil it with a lie.”

After Dadi's rule about the bank, this became the new rule of the house.

As much truth as there is.

Say only that much.
No less.
No more.



At the last meeting of the night, Rachna Sinha placed two files before the team.

Old.

New.

“We will not turn these into one case.”

Rohit asked—

“Why? The money is connected.”

“The history is connected. The elements of the offences are different.”

“But the story in court?”

“The court will hear charges, not a story.”

Mayank nodded.

“The old investigation—Satyaprakash’s suspicious death, economic motive, Haricharan’s vehicle connection.”

“The new one—online gambling, mule accounts, financial layering, Keshav, Saurabh, Manoj and the others.”

“The old money entered the new network—that is context and financial evidence.”

“But the crimes in the new gambling network will not be used to prove murder.”

Rachna began clearing the board.

“We can write the history of a crime. Sentences must rest on separate proof.”

Rohit asked—

“Then is it one monitor lizard or two?”

Rachna stopped.

“Perhaps the water is the same.”

No one laughed.

Because the answer was not light.

Greed.

Fear.

Silence.

Illegal gain inside lawful institutions.

The poor person’s compulsion.

The official’s compromise.

The glitter of reward.

The delay of punishment.
All these make the water.
The monitor lizard changes its name.



Ramavatar's health deteriorated again.
He died before Rachna could reach the hospital.
No further statement.
One photograph remained.
One unfinished gesture.
One pair of tearful eyes.
The last living possible driver in the old investigation was gone as well.
Rachna leaned against the wall in the hospital corridor.
Rohit stood beside her.
"I went to him only a few days ago."
"Yes."
"Why not earlier?"
Rohit had no answer.
The twenty-year delay was not Rachna's personal failure.
Yet an investigator takes the whole weight of time upon herself.
"If he could have spoken..."
Rohit said softly—
"Then perhaps."
Rachna closed her eyes.
That word again.
Perhaps.
At a distance, Ramavatar's grandson wept while filling out the family paperwork.
In the State's file it would say: "Potentially important witness deceased."
In the family's file—
"Dada is gone."
Both true.
Their weights different.



That night there was a violent downpour at Garh Narikel.
The Kamala-Balan was near the danger mark.
Mrinalini was pulling the courtyard things indoors.
The mongoose's old burrow was completely under water.

The cobra, the monitor lizard, the mongoose—all of them must have been seeking their own higher ground.

Nature does not behave as a symbol for crime.

It merely raises the water.

Ishaan arrived at dawn.

“Ma, the embankment is under pressure. Come.”

“Where?”

“The school relief camp.”

Mrinalini picked up Satyaprakash’s photograph.

Then his spectacles.

Then one of Dhaneshwari’s old shawls.

Three objects.

As she left the house, she turned at the threshold and looked back.

Ishaan said—

“Hurry.”

Mrinalini asked softly—

“If the house goes under?”

“We will build again.”

“Memory?”

Ishaan did not answer.

They stepped outside.

Behind them, water was entering the courtyard.

On the upper branch of a shrub, a mongoose stood with its body soaked through.

Ishaan saw it.

Perhaps the mongoose saw him too.

Then it leapt onto a higher wall.

A guardian does not always fight.

Sometimes survival is the first duty.



At that same time in the capital city, Rachna Sinha was reading the last group of Saurabh’s seized emails.

Her eyes stopped on one line.

From Saurabh to Alok Bhasin—

“Do not let the old dispute’s name surface again. Do not open the S.K. case in the investor records.”

S.K.

This time the context matched the file.

Satyaprakash Karna.

Rachna held her breath.

The email had been written long after Satyaprakash's death.

But its meaning was clear—

people around Saurabh knew about the old "S.K. case."

How much did they know?

From whom?

Why did they want to conceal it?

Rachna did not write a conclusion at once.

Only three questions.

And a new direction—

how had the decision been made to keep the old records deliberately separate from the new investment history?

Had someone spent twenty years laundering not only money, but memory?

More dangerous than money laundering, at times, is the laundering of history.

Lay a clean story over a dirty event.

The new generation will see only the brand.

Not the blood behind it.

On the board, beneath "Conjunction," Rachna wrote one more word—"Memory."

The monitor lizard does not hide only in water.

It hides in history as well.

Then the mongoose's watch is needed not only at the threshold.

It is needed along the edges of the paper too.



The first task in understanding what the "S.K. case" meant was not to decide all over again that Satyaprakash's death had been murder.

Rachna Sinha arranged Saurabh Bardhan's seized emails in chronological order.

One line.

Then another.

Then a six-year gap between them.

An old draft sent to Alok Bhasin mentioned the "S.K. case," but not the full name. A third document contained a risk note—

"The dispute over the old sports-promotion payment and the death of the contractor associated with it raise unnecessary questions in the brand's history."

Rachna sat upright in her chair.

“The death of the contractor associated with it.”

So someone inside the company had known not only about the payment, but about the death as well.

But the question returned—

Knowing was not a crime.

How much of concealing it was a crime?

And what, exactly, had been concealed?

An investor prospectus?

An internal risk issue?

A fact material to a government investigation?

Those were different things.

Rachna called in the legal team.

“I can use the phrase ‘laundering history’ in literature,” she said, “but not in a prosecution. We have to see who had a duty to disclose the truth, from whom it was concealed, and what legal consequence that concealment carries.”

Law is not moved by metaphor.

That was a good thing.

Metaphor turns the human eye toward truth.

Law asks: under which provision?



Saurabh’s questioning was brief this time.

Rachna placed the risk note before him.

“The death of the contractor associated with it.”

Saurabh read it.

His face did not change.

“This came from Nalin Barua’s audit note.”

“So you knew Satyaprakash’s name?”

“Later.”

“When did you first learn it?”

“While organizing Uttarayan’s investment history.”

“Organizing?”

Saurabh realized at once that the word had landed badly.

“Systematizing.”

“Why did you instruct that the S.K. case should not be opened in the investor records?”

“Because it was an old, settled dispute.”

“Was the death settled?”

“The death investigation had called it an accident.”

“Then why did it need to be removed?”

“Why burden new investors with the context of a twenty-year-old dispute?”

Rachna was silent for a few moments.

“If it was only a dispute, why such insistence that ‘the old dispute must not surface again?’”

“Reputation.”

“Whose?”

“Uttarayan’s. Ambar’s.”

“Is telling investors where old money came from merely a question of reputation?”

Saurabh’s lawyer intervened.

“You are framing the question as though the allegation has already been established.”

Rachna nodded.

“Fair.”

She changed the question.

“Did you know that some of Uttarayan’s original fund had come indirectly from Samriddhi Gram-Finance?”

“Later.”

“Shashibhushan Lal?”

“I had read the name.”

“Devanshu Rakshit?”

“From the media after his imprisonment.”

“Satyaprakash?”

“From an internal file.”

“His death?”

“An accident in the official record.”

“Were you afraid that questions about that accident would arise again?”

Saurabh took a long breath.

“Not afraid. Trouble.”

One word.

Rachna stopped her pen.

“Trouble.”

“Yes. Investors want a clean story.”

“A clean story.”

Saurabh himself seemed to hear how heavy his words sounded.

“What I mean is—”

“I understand what you mean. Say clearly what you want placed on record.”

Saurabh fell silent.
 After a while he said,
 "I did not want the disputed sources to be expanded upon in the brand's early history."
 "Were those sources lawful?"
 "On paper."
 "Meaning?"
 "Some of the older records were unclear."
 "And so investors were not to be told?"
 "At the time I regarded it as risk management."
 This time Rachna wrote down the phrase—
 "Risk management."
 Whether money laundering was ultimately proved or not, memory had certainly been managed.



Thirty families were living in the school relief camp at Garh Narikel.
 Mrinalini could not sleep on the first night.
 Multiplication tables were written on the classroom wall.
 Four families had spread their bedding beneath them.
 A child was crying.
 An old woman was coughing.
 Rain fell outside.
 Ishaan had gone out at night with a volunteer team inspecting the embankment.
 Mrinalini kept Satyaprakash's photograph in her bag and tried to sleep.
 Suddenly there was shouting outside.
 "Snake!"
 People ran.
 A small cobra had slipped into the veranda, seeking a dry corner.
 Someone came running with a stick.
 Mrinalini shouted—
 "Children, get back!"
 The snake turned along the wall.
 At that moment the mongoose sprang out of the darkness outside.
 This time it was not merely a confrontation of presence.
 For an instant the two bodies tangled on the ground.
 A hiss.
 Fur flew.
 Everyone froze.

The mongoose twisted the snake around and drove it out of the veranda.
The cobra fled toward the grass.
The mongoose did not pursue it.
It returned and stood near the doorway, panting.
There was a small wound on its shoulder.
Two drops of blood.
Mrinalini gently placed a bowl of water some distance away.
No one dared go closer.
The mongoose sniffed the water.
It did not drink.
Then it disappeared into the dark.
A child asked—
“Did it save us?”
Mrinalini said,
“Yes.”
“Did it know?”
Mrinalini thought for a long time before answering.
“Perhaps not. But protection is in its nature.”
As she spoke, she remembered Satyaprakash.
Human beings too do not always perform their duty because they have studied a principle.
Something in their nature may compel them to stop what they know is wrong.
And sometimes the body itself pays the price of that nature.



By dawn the Kamala-Balan had risen further.
The rear part of the old house at Garh Narikel went under water.
Ishaan went by boat to see what had happened to the house.
The main room had survived.
The courtyard had not.
The mongoose's burrow had not.
The lower part of Satyaprakash's old table stood in water.
Some papers had already been moved to safety. Some had not.
Ishaan pulled out a soaked chest.
His mother's wedding photographs.
Some of his father's receipts.
Dhaneshwari's old book.
The ink was spreading.
For a moment he panicked.

Then he remembered—the documents needed for the official investigation had long ago been copied.

What remained here was not evidence for a court.

It was family memory.

The value of the two kinds of paper was different.

Ishaan separated the wet photographs.

In one photograph Satyaprakash was young.

Mrinalini was laughing.

Behind them was the old ghat of the Kamala-Balan.

The current in the photograph was still.

Outside, the real river was eating the house.

Memory too is a kind of embankment.

There is no guarantee how long it will hold.



In Rajdhani Nagar, a new thread concerning the vehicle in the old accident investigation emerged from insurance records.

There had been no scrap claim on the green goods carrier, but there was an invoice from a private workshop after the accident.

The date—two days after Satyaprakash's death.

The repairs—

Left front section.

Lamp.

Metal panel.

Wheel alignment.

Rachna held her breath as she looked at the document.

The part of the vehicle that could have borne the impact.

The workshop was now closed.

Its owner was dead.

But his son had preserved the old ledgers.

The invoice number matched.

"Where did the accident happen?" Rachna asked.

The son said,

"My father did not write that down. Only the work."

"Do you remember who brought the vehicle?"

"I was a child."

"Haricharan?"

"I don't remember."

The nature of the repair, by itself, did not prove that this was the vehicle in Satyaprakash's crash.

The truck could have struck something somewhere else.

But now there was the timing, the vehicle, Haricharan's night booking, Ramavatar's photograph, and the repair.

The chain of indications was becoming stronger.

Mayank Jha said,

"The vyapti of the inference has grown denser."

Rachna said,

"But there is still no final point of direct evidence."

Aniruddh was silent on the phone.

Then he said,

"Many cases are proved by circumstantial evidence without direct evidence."

"Yes."

"The question is whether the chain is complete."

Rachna looked at the board.

One space was still blank—

Whose instruction?

Haricharan acting on his own?

Someone from Digant?

Devanshu?

Someone else?

The vehicle link was beginning to establish the manner of the killing.

It did not establish the summit of the conspiracy.



Rachna decided to question Devanshu Rakshit once more.

It was raining in the hill town this time.

Devanshu sat by the window.

Rachna placed a copy of the repair invoice before him.

He read it.

His face remained still.

"Haricharan took the vehicle."

"That is what the document indicates."

"It was repaired two days later."

"Yes."

"Satyaprakash died in between."

"Yes."

Devanshu closed his eyes.

"You want me to get frightened now and say something."

"I want you to say what you know."

A long silence.

Then Devanshu said slowly,

“Haricharan sometimes crossed the line.”

“Did you stop him?”

“Sometimes.”

“In Satyaprakash’s case?”

“I told him to ‘make him understand.’”

Rachna’s body tightened.

“Whom did you tell?”

“Haricharan.”

“When?”

“Before the death.”

“What did ‘make him understand’ mean?”

Devanshu laughed bitterly.

“Now an entire case will be built around the meaning of those words.”

“Then tell me what they meant.”

“Make him stop talking. Make him withdraw his objection to the payment. Make him stop obstructing Digant’s work.”

“Assault him?”

“I did not say that.”

“Use a vehicle?”

“No.”

“Frighten him?”

Devanshu was silent.

“Mr. Rakshit.”

“Yes. I told him to put pressure on him.”

The room grew heavy.

“Lawfully?”

“No.”

“By what means?”

“I left that to him.”

Rachna asked the next question slowly.

“Did you know Haricharan used violence?”

Devanshu looked away.

“Yes.”

The answer arrived across the distance of years.

“Then if you tell a violent man to put ‘pressure’ on someone—”

The lawyer intervened.

“Do not put a legal conclusion into the question.”

Rachna stopped.

Correct.

“What did you do when you heard Satyaprakash had died?”

Devanshu was silent for a long time.

“I asked Haricharan.”

“What did he say?”

“He said—the job went wrong.”

Rachna’s pen stopped.

“Those exact words?”

“Yes. I remember those words.”

““The job went wrong.””

“Yes.”

“And then?”

“I asked him—what did you do?”

“And he?”

“He said, ‘It became more than was necessary.’”

Devanshu’s voice broke.

Whether a twenty-year-old door had opened before Rachna, or a new trap of memory, was not yet for her to decide.

“Why did you not tell the police?”

Devanshu looked at her.

“Because I would have implicated myself.”

The answer was brutally clear.

“Did you think it had been murder?”

“From that day.”

“And you kept silent?”

“Yes.”

“For twenty years?”

“Yes.”

Rachna remained seated.

At last one form of the tragedy had found its name—

Silence.



Devanshu’s new statement was not accepted as truth merely because he had made it.

He was a person previously convicted of crimes.

He might have reason to reduce the weight upon himself.

Haricharan was dead.

Corroboration was difficult.

But the statement matched other independent links.

Haricharan's search for a vehicle.

The green truck.

The repair.

Ramavatar.

Satyaprakash's objection to the payment.

Digant's financial interest.

Devanshu's admission that he had instructed Haricharan to apply pressure.

"The job went wrong."

"It became more than was necessary."

The final two sentences rested only on Devanshu's word.

But the chain was now almost complete.

The legal team was divided.

Some said a conspiracy charge against Devanshu was possible.

Others said a conviction would be difficult after twenty years, with the principal actor dead and memory carrying so much of the evidence.

Rachna said,

"Difficult is one question. Whether there is sufficient prima facie basis is another."

A senior officer asked,

"Do you want to arrest him?"

Rachna was silent.

Devanshu was old.

The risk of flight was low.

Most of the evidence was documentary.

He was cooperating voluntarily.

"Arrest is not a reward for an investigation," Rachna said. "We will assess necessity."

In the end: summons, formal status as an accused, appearance before the court.

No immediate handcuffs.

The press was furious.

"Leniency for the mafia?"

Rachna issued no statement.

Legal process lived apart from television's hunger for drama.



Mrinalini learned the news not from Ishaan, but from Rachna.

They sat in an empty room at the relief camp.

Rachna said,

“Devanshu has admitted that he told Haricharan to exert unlawful pressure on Satyaprakash.”

Mrinalini’s face went white.

“And the murder?”

“He says he did not order a killing. He says Haricharan later told him—the job went wrong.”

“Then?”

“The investigation team believes the death may have resulted from a planned pressure operation. The court will decide the extent of legal responsibility.”

Mrinalini was silent for a long time.

“What have I received after twenty years?”

Rachna did not try to answer.

Mrinalini answered herself.

“One man says—I ordered pressure. Another man died. The driver is dead. The man who applied the pressure is dead. The man above the order says he did not want murder.”

She laughed without tears.

“Is justice also like a flood? By the time it reaches you, half the house has already washed away?”

Rachna lowered her eyes.

There was no legal answer to that question.



In the new gambling case, Manoj Nayak was arrested.

Ritesh’s statement.

Raghubir’s contacts.

The mule-recruitment targets.

Financial gain.

The promotional network.

Night Room activity.

The Saurabh-Keshav meeting.

A sufficient preliminary chain.

Outside Manoj’s house, his elderly father shouted at the reporters—

“My son is not a murderer!”

No one had said he was a murderer.

But to a family’s ears, cameras, police, and arrest merge into one accusation.

Manoj’s mother fainted.

Rachna was not at the scene.

She watched the video later.

She understood that arrest may be a judicial necessity, while its effect on a family is written in no separate book of justice.

A relative of an accused is not thereby an accused.

But society's informal machinery of punishment often reaches the household anyway.



Saurabh's bail application came up before the High Court.

The prosecution argued that the financial structure was complex, that the accused was influential, and that there was a risk of interference with witnesses.

The defence argued that the evidence was documentary, that arrest was not punishment, that Saurabh had cooperated, and that he had made no attempt to flee abroad.

The court asked pointed questions.

"Prosecution—what custodial interrogation remains?"

"Some financial links."

"Have the documents been seized?"

"Yes."

"Any direct threat by the accused?"

"No."

"Then what is the necessity of continued incarceration?"

In the end, bail was granted subject to conditions.

Passport surrendered.

No contact with witnesses.

Regular appearance.

The media split—

"The rich man walks free."

"Justice from the court."

Rachna read the order.

She was not angry.

Bail was not innocence.

Incarceration was not conviction.

The story had to repeat this distinction again and again.

Because society kept merging the two.



Pradeep too was later granted bail.

On the day he was to leave, he stood for a long time at the prison gate.

His wife came.
Trisha did not.
Pradeep sat in the car.
They were silent the entire way.
At home he found his room clean, but some of his belongings had been put away in a separate box.
His wife said,
“You may stay here for now. But the case will continue.”
“I know.”
“Trisha will need time.”
“Yes.”
“Work?”
Pradeep laughed sadly.
“Who will give me any?”
His wife did not become harsh.
“That is not a question for me.”
On his first night home, Pradeep slept as though he were still in prison.
The door was open.
Trust was closed.
Some prisons are not made of iron.



After the flood receded, Ishaan found a soaked book while cleaning the house.

It had belonged to Dhaneshwari.
The pages were stuck together.
In the middle, an old sentence was written in Maithili—
“Do not leave the house merely out of fear of a snake; but do not decide that a snake is in the house until you have seen it.”
Ishaan laughed and cried at the same time as he read it.
Grandmother had probably never studied Nyaya philosophy.
But life had taught her the language of evidence.
Mrinalini asked from behind him,
“What did you find?”
Ishaan showed her the page.
Mrinalini read it.
“Your grandmother wrote this herself.”
“When?”
“Long ago. Once, after a rumour of a snake, half the village spent the night sleeping outside.”

They both laughed.
Laughter in the midst of tragedy was not a crime.
It was evidence of being alive.



Rachna Sinha wrote the interim report on the old investigation.
There was not a single metaphor in its language.
No monitor lizard.
No mongoose.
No water.
Only facts.
Satyaprakash Karna had stopped a disputed payment.
Digant's financial interest had been affected.
Devanshu Rakshit had admitted instructing Haricharan Mandal to exert unlawful pressure.
Haricharan had a prior record of violent methods.
There was documentary evidence of a heavy-vehicle booking for Haricharan on the night of the death.
There was a repair invoice for damage to the front of the probable vehicle shortly after the crash.
There was an old handwritten note on a photograph linking the probable driver to Haricharan.
There was Devanshu's new statement that Haricharan had said "the job went wrong" and "it became more than was necessary."
The limitations too were set out clearly—
Haricharan, the principal operative, was dead.
The probable driver was dead.
The original vehicle was unavailable.
There was no forensic sample.
There was no independent corroboration of the final conversation described by Devanshu.
There had been twenty years of erosion in memory.
The report concluded—
"In light of the newly available material, the earlier conclusion closing the death as merely an ordinary road accident is unsatisfactory. The hypothesis of a deliberate vehicular collision during a planned pressure operation is sufficiently supported; the specific criminal liability of living persons is a matter for judicial determination."
Rachna wrote the final line and put down her pen.
For the first time in twenty years the State was saying—

It was not right to dismiss this as an accident and forget it.
But the State was still not saying—
We know everything.
That was the tragedy of this story.



Mrinalini read the public summary of the report.

After a long time she lit a lamp before Satyaprakash's photograph.

It was not worship.

Not victory.

She said softly,

"You were not lying."

Ishaan could not tell whether the sentence was meant for Satyaprakash or for herself.

Mrinalini spoke again.

"But I still do not have the whole answer."

Ishaan sat beside her.

"Perhaps we never will."

Mrinalini held his hand.

"Then we will keep what we have found."

The flood mark was still visible on the wall of the house.

The courtyard had new earth.

The mongoose's old burrow had washed away.

There was a small hole in the new shrubbery.

No one knew whether it was the same mongoose or another.

The guardian's name need not be permanent.

The watch must be.



The charge sheet in the new gambling case began to take shape.

Rachna gave the team clear instructions—

"The old Satyaprakash case will not become a dramatic prologue to this charge sheet."

Rohit asked—

"But the history is connected."

"Only to the extent that the financial path is relevant."

"And the story?"

"When we write a book."

Everyone laughed.

Rachna did too.

Then she grew serious—

“One more thing. Do not put every mule-account holder into a single category of accused. Knowledge, benefit, repetition, role—each must be treated separately.”

Sabina Khatoon.

Abhishek.

Shailesh.

Ritesh.

Soumitra.

All their bank accounts had become “channels.”

Not all the human beings were the same.

Justice requires classification.

A criminal network wants simplification—“We need an account; it does not matter whose.”

If the State makes the same simplification, what is the difference?



Another list was made—

Victims.

Families that had lost money in gambling.

The original account-holders defrauded of their money.

Mule-account families whose legitimate income had been frozen.

Innocent employees of the company.

Ritesh, the victim of assault.

Manoj’s family—not victims in the legal sense, but victims of social consequences.

Rachna paused over that last category.

“The family of an accused on a victims’ list?”

An officer asked.

“Not on the legal-compensation list. In the social-impact study.”

“Why?”

Ishaan, who had been invited as a special data adviser, said—

“Because the cost of crime is larger than the State’s list of prosecutions.”

Rachna nodded.

Tragedy is difficult to measure.

But what is not measured does not cease to exist.



That night, when Rachna left the office in the capital city, the rain had stopped.

Small pools of water lay on the road.

She was tired.

Her phone rang.

Apoorva Kashyap.

“The NIA’s separate case is not closed, but the final analysis has come in on the link it shares with your gambling investigation.”

“What does it say?”

“What we thought earlier. A shared intermediary. Different purposes.”

“Meaning there is no evidence of national-security financing?”

“Not in the material presently available.”

Rachna let out a breath of relief.

“Thank you.”

Apoorva laughed—

“People often want the NIA’s presence to mean a grand conspiracy.”

“Not this time.”

“The correct conclusion can sometimes seem small.”

“But for innocent people, it can be enormous.”

The call ended.

The story had let go of an easy sensation.

That might make the novel less thrilling.

But it made justice more truthful.



The night at Garh Narikel was clear.

The floodwater had receded considerably.

Mrinalini sat on the threshold.

Ishaan had returned to the capital city.

There was a rustle in the shrubbery.

A mongoose emerged.

This time it did not appear injured.

Perhaps the same one.

Perhaps another.

It did not stop before the threshold.

It went straight toward the edge of the field.

Far away, something heavy moved in the waters of the Kamla-Balan.

A monitor lizard?

A fish?

A piece of timber?

Mrinalini did not rise.

She watched from a distance.

The mongoose stood at the bank.
 Whatever was in the water did not surface.
 After a few moments, the mongoose vanished into the grass.
 Mrinalini said softly—
 “Keeping watch does not mean solving every mystery.”
 Some mysteries will be solved.
 Some only halfway.
 Some never.
 But abandoning the watch does not turn darkness into truth.
 Inside the house was Satyaprakash’s photograph.
 Outside was the Kamla-Balan.
 Between them, an old woman.
 And at the bank, the mongoose’s new footprints.
 The story was not over yet.
 Because the new criminal case still had to reach the courtroom.
 And in court, it would not be the story that spoke. It would be the evidence.



The first detailed hearing in the new criminal case began in the Special Court of the capital city.

Cameras waited outside.
 Wooden benches inside.
 The accused sat in separate rows.
 Keshav Mehta.
 Manoj Nayak.
 Raghubir Tanti.
 Saurabh Bardhan, present on bail.
 Pradeep Mahajan as well.
 A few minor accused, a few account-holders, and a few people whose roles were still disputed.
 Rachna Sinha sat near the witness row.
 Ishaan was not a party to the case.
 He sat at the back in the public gallery.
 Mrinalini had not come.
 She had said—
 “I will not go to the court of the new crime looking for answers about your father.”
 Ishaan understood.
 The two stories were connected, certainly.

But laying one over the other would not be justice.



In its opening submission, the prosecution said—

This was not a case of a single gambling empire run by one person.

It was a case of an organization built in layers.

A legitimate digital company.

An external marketing group.

A private betting circle.

Recruitment of mule-account holders.

Financial adjustments.

Money mixed into real businesses.

An investment structure.

But the prosecution would not treat all of these as one and the same offence.

The knowledge, role, and intent of each accused would have to be proved separately.

The defence seized upon that sentence at once.

“So the State itself admits that no central conspiracy has been proved.”

The prosecutor replied—

“The State says the scope of the conspiracy will be proved according to the evidence, not according to assumption.”

The judge made a note.

From the beginning, the trial was becoming a war of words.

Vāda.

Jalpa.

Vitaṇḍā.

But a court’s task is not merely argument and counterargument.

What matters is which side carries the burden of proof.



The first witness was a bank compliance officer.

He did not bring a thousand pages of records into court.

Only certified tables, references to the original records, account chains, and the procedure for freeze orders.

The prosecution asked—

“Were all the account-holders criminals?”

“No.”

“Does an unusual transaction by itself prove a crime?”

“No.”

“Then what are you establishing?”

“In some accounts we observed transaction patterns inconsistent with ordinary income behaviour. In the later investigation, some of those accounts were linked to the recruitment network.”

The defence rose—

“Meaning the bank itself could not say there was a crime.”

“Banks do not decide criminality.”

“Thank you.”

The defence smiled.

As though it had won a point.

The judge asked—

“So a bank alert means only that there is a basis to begin an inquiry?”

“Yes.”

That small question cut through an entire *hetvābhāsa*.

Unusual = criminal.

That conclusion was false.

Unusual = worthy of investigation.

That was correct.



The second witness was Sabina Khatoon.

She entered the courtroom trembling.

She was not in the row of accused.

She was a witness.

The prosecution asked—

“Whom did you allow to use your account?”

Sabina described the connection.

“How much were you paid?”

“Five thousand rupees a month.”

“Did you know where the money came from?”

“No.”

“Did you suspect anything?”

Sabina was silent.

The judge said—

“Take your time and answer.”

“Not at first. Later I felt something was wrong.”

“Why?”

“Too much money began moving through the account.”

“Did you stop then?”

“No.”

“Why not?”

Sabina lowered her eyes.

“My daughter’s treatment.”

The defence rose.

“You admit that even after you became suspicious, you continued taking the money?”

“Yes.”

“So there was benefit?”

“Yes.”

“Then you were not an innocent victim?”

The prosecution objected.

The judge stopped the question—

“The court will determine the witness’s legal status. Keep the questions to facts.”

The defence tried again—

“Did anyone threaten you?”

“No.”

“Did anyone tell you to violate banking rules?”

“No.”

“Then you made the decision yourself?”

After a long pause Sabina said—

“Yes.”

The answer did not echo through the courtroom.

But it echoed inside Ishaan.

Sabina was also a victim.

And also a person who had made a choice.

Both at once.

Justice was being tested on its power to classify.



Abhishek’s testimony was harder still.

He admitted—

Ritesh had offered him commission.

At first he had understood it as legitimate payment assistance.

Then he had become suspicious.

Yet he continued for some time.

“Why?”

“Debt.”

“Did you give Ritesh another account-holder?”

“I suggested a friend’s name. I regretted it later.”

“Was that account used?”

“No.”

The defence asked—

“Mr. Abhishek, the police could have made you an accused?”

“Perhaps.”

“So by becoming a government witness, you received a benefit?”

Abhishek’s face reddened.

“I cooperated.”

“Answer the question—did you benefit?”

The prosecution objected.

The judge allowed the point—

“If there is any formal immunity, agreement, or prosecutorial decision, produce the document.”

The document was produced.

Abhishek’s role was limited; there was insufficient evidence of criminal intent; he had been used as a witness.

The defence said—

“So the State chooses who is an accused and who is a witness.”

The prosecutor replied—

“According to the evidence.”

The judge intervened—

“Arguments on that point belong to the final stage. For now, facts.”

Again and again, the court was forcing the story back within its limits.



Ritesh Das’s testimony lasted all day.

He did not hide his own wrongdoing.

“I used to recruit accounts.”

“For commission?”

“Yes.”

“Did you know?”

“Later, yes.”

“Manoj Nayak?”

“He gave targets.”

“How many?”

Ritesh gave a general range, not details.

“When did you stop?”

“When the police complaints increased.”

“And then the assault?”

“Yes.”

“Who came?”

“Two men.”

“What did they say?”

“Manoj bhaiya is angry.”

The defence rose—

“Those words were spoken by the two men. Not by Manoj himself.”

“Yes.”

“So you never heard Manoj order the assault.”

“No.”

“Raghubir?”

“I learned the name later.”

“Uday Babu?”

“Manoj mentioned that once.”

“Full name?”

“No.”

The defence smiled.

“So you have brought half a name into court.”

Ritesh was silent.

The judge said—

“Witness, say only what you yourself heard. Do not infer.”

Ritesh nodded.

The same lesson kept returning throughout this trial—

Know the limits of words.



The assault case against Raghubir Tanti was comparatively direct.

Phone contact.

The statements of the two young men.

Ritesh’s medical record.

Raghubir’s admission that he had sent them.

But there was a dispute over any “order to beat him.”

The defence said—

“They were sent to talk.”

The prosecution replied—

“In what context? To whom? How many men? What prior threats? What was Ritesh’s role? What was said afterward?”

The judge said—

“One word will not be read in isolation. The totality of the circumstances will be considered.”

The facts were joining like the five limbs of inference.

Proposition.

Reason.

Not example here, but coherence of circumstances.

Application.

Conclusion.

But the court was not reciting a Sanskrit formula.

It was merely practicing the same discipline.



When Pradeep Mahajan entered the witness box, the atmosphere in the courtroom changed.

Because he was both a witness.

And an accused.

He had made a statement admitting the allegations against himself, but according to the prosecution his cooperation warranted separate consideration.

The defence was harshest with him.

“You fabricated false documents?”

“Yes.”

“False accounts?”

“Yes.”

“And now, to save yourself, you are accusing others?”

“I am saying what I know.”

“Keshav Mehta was your senior?”

“Indirectly.”

“Saurabh Bardhan?”

“On the investor side.”

“Did anyone give you a written order saying, ‘Launder the proceeds of illegal gambling?’”

“Not in those words.”

“Thank you.”

The defence stepped back.

The prosecution re-examined him—

“Not in those words. Then how did you understand the work?”

Pradeep cleared his throat.

“Night Room settlements were kept separate from the main account. Where there were bills for real services, some amounts were adjusted there. There were instructions to keep the old source separate.”

“From whom?”

“Messages from Keshav. Saurabh’s risk instructions. Alok Bhasin’s financial plan.”

“When did you realize this was illegal?”

“Gradually.”

“And yet you did not leave?”

“No.”

“Why?”

Pradeep looked toward the back of the courtroom.

Trisha had not come.

Nor had his wife.

“First the job. Then fear. Then habit.”

The courtroom was silent.

That sentence was not a legal defence.

It was a human admission.



The defence sought to introduce a passage from Pradeep’s prison diary—

“Equal rules do not produce equal outcomes.”

The prosecution objected—

“Personal reflection, irrelevant to the charges.”

The judge agreed.

The diary was excluded.

Pradeep was not shaken.

He had come to understand that the court was not reviewing his whole life.

Only the specific offences.

A human being is larger than a court file.

But punishment rests on what the file proves.

That limit was frustrating.

And necessary.



Keshav Mehta’s defence strategy was clear—

The Night Room operated outside the main company.

People at lower levels had expanded the illegal activity.

Keshav had only tried to protect the brand.

The prosecution placed his messages before the court—

“Let Night settlements remain separate.”

“Do not bring this flow inside the main application.”

“Write only the real service that was actually performed; keep the remaining adjustment separate.”

The defence said—

“Keeping regulatory risk separate is not a crime.”

The prosecution replied—

“What if the activity being kept separate was itself illegal private betting, mule accounts, and disguised financial adjustments?”

The defence said—

“First prove that Keshav knew all of that.”

That was the centre of the trial.

Knowledge.

Not merely position.

Not merely benefit.

Not merely silence.

Knowledge and intent.

Sitting at the back, Rachna understood that months of investigation had contracted into two words in court.

“Did he know?”



Saurabh Bardhan’s position was more complicated.

He did not directly operate the system.

But there was Uttarayan’s money.

The risk emails.

The old source.

Kshitij Asset Management.

Alok Bhasin’s plan.

“Keep both the main brand and the fund separate.”

The defence said—

“Corporate separation is normal.”

The prosecution replied—

“Correct. That is why a single sentence is not a crime. But what if the thing being separated is income from private betting, mule-linked payments, and concealment of source?”

Again, context.

One fact in isolation may be innocent.

Many facts together can change meaning.

That is the power of inference.

And its danger.

Hetvābhāsa is born there too.

Several innocent facts can be assembled into a criminal story.

That was why the court was testing the independent reliability of every link.



Udaynath Mishra had not, at this stage, been made an accused.

He appeared as a witness.

He had admitted that private betting was discussed at the meeting.

But he denied planning mule accounts.

The prosecution asked—

“You prepared the presentation titled ‘Secondary User Circulation’?”

“Yes.”

“Reactivation of losing users?”

“Yes.”

“Referrals?”

“Yes.”

“Payment facilitation?”

“Yes.”

“Did mule recruitment increase after that presentation?”

“The data may say so.”

“What was your objective?”

“Legitimate customer growth.”

“If people below you used it for crime?”

“I am not responsible.”

The defence was pleased.

The prosecution continued—

“You heard private betting discussed at that meeting?”

“Yes.”

“And the presentation was updated after that meeting?”

Udaynath paused.

“Yes.”

“So you knew private betting was operating?”

“Yes, but I understood the legal position to be unclear.”

“Did you seek legal advice?”

“Perhaps the company did.”

“You personally?”

“No.”

That answer weakened his moral position.

It did not prove a legal offence.

The court was recording the two separately.



As the trial continued, the world outside kept making its own story.

One channel—

“The philosophical defence of a gambling syndicate.”

Another—

“Billions through the accounts of the poor?”

The amount was exaggerated.

A third—

“NIA also investigating.”

Wrong context.

Apoorva Kashyap had to issue an official clarification—

“This prosecution is by the State agency. In a separate NIA case there was limited information-sharing regarding a common financial intermediary; it is incorrect to describe the present charges as a national-security case.”

The clarification became a small news item.

The sensation was larger.

Rachna stopped watching television.

The court moved slowly.

The market of opinion delivered judgment fast.

Sometimes society convicts before the court does.

Sometimes it acquits before the court does.

Neither is justice.



At Garh Narikel, Mrinalini watched workers applying fresh limewash over the flood stains on the house.

Half the wall was old.

Half new.

Satyaprakash’s photograph had been taken down for the limewash.

It lay on a table.

A worker asked—

“Is this Babuji?”

“Yes.”

“The one whose case was reopened?”

Mrinalini paused.

By now everyone in the village knew.

“Yes.”

The worker said—

“I read about it in the newspaper. Has the criminal been caught?”

Mrinalini said quietly—

“Not completely.”

“Then why was the case reopened?”

It was an ordinary question.

Mrinalini thought for a moment.

“Because what was called an accident no longer looks so simple.”

The worker nodded.

Perhaps he did not fully understand.

He went back to work.

Mrinalini picked up the photograph.

“See?” she said softly to Satyaprakash. “People want a complete answer.”

The lime on the wall was drying.

New colour was covering memory.

But this time the place of the old stain had deliberately been kept marked.



The old Satyaprakash case reached the preliminary stage of consideration of charges in court.

Devanshu was present.

Old.

With his lawyer.

The prosecution said—

Devanshu admitted instructing unlawful pressure.

He knew Haricharan’s violent background.

Satyaprakash’s financial objection affected Digant’s economic interests.

There were independent records showing Haricharan had arranged a heavy vehicle.

The vehicle evidence corresponded with the day of death.

There had been repairs soon afterward.

And there was Devanshu’s account of the later conversation.

The defence said—

There had been no order to kill.

There was no direct identification of the vehicle.

The principal actor was dead.

The memories were twenty years old.

There was no independent corroboration of “the job went wrong.”

The court said—

“At this stage, the question is not conviction but whether there is a triable basis.”

Limited charges concerning unlawful pressure and possible criminal conspiracy against Devanshu were accepted for trial.

The court remained cautious about final liability for the killing.

The media again—

“Murder case to go to trial.”

The order was more nuanced.

The headline was not.

Mrinalini read a copy of the order.

“Is this a victory?”

Ishaan did not ask.

Mrinalini answered herself—

“No.”

Then, after a few moments—

“But the door has not been closed.”

That might be enough.

Perhaps.



As Devanshu descended the courthouse steps, he stumbled.

Reporters surrounded him.

“Did you have Mr. Karna killed?”

“Do you admit it?”

“Why did you remain silent for twenty years?”

Devanshu’s lawyer tried to clear a path.

Devanshu suddenly stopped.

He did not look at the cameras. He looked at the ground and said—

“I told them to put pressure on him. That is true. What happened cannot be separated from my burden.”

His lawyer pulled him away.

How much that amounted to a legal admission was for the court to decide.

But the public statement spread everywhere.

Mrinalini heard it on television.

She did not cry.

Before Satyaprakash’s photograph she said only one line—

“Twenty years.”

Nothing more.



In the new trial came the decisive testimony of the digital expert.

He said plainly—

“I authenticate the material—which device yielded which message, record, or file and when; indications of tampering; the chain of custody.”

The prosecution asked—

“Do you determine the meaning of the messages?”

“No.”

“Is ‘Night outside’ a code for crime?”

“I cannot say.”

The defence smiled.

“So even the technical expert cannot say.”

“Yes.”

“Then the prosecution is imagining the meaning?”

The expert remained calm—

“The court will consider meaning together with the other evidence. My task is to establish that the message exists in an authentic record.”

The judge made a note.

A division of labour in proof.

The technical expert establishes existence.

The witness supplies context.

The financial expert traces the flow.

The court determines meaning.

No one person owns the whole truth.

Conjunction exists in justice too.



Mayank Jha appeared as a financial expert witness.

The defence’s first question—

“You are not the investigator in this case?”

“A consultant.”

“An expert in criminology?”

“No.”

“Then what qualifies you to speak of money laundering?”

“I analyse accounting flows. The legal conclusion belongs to the court.”

“Very well.”

Mayank explained the chart—without operational detail.

Money from different sources.

Real businesses.

Loans.

Early repayments.

Investor income.

“Could this structure also be lawful?” the defence asked.

“Each stage, taken separately—yes.”

“Then where is the crime?”

“If the source, purpose, and accounting context are lawful, there is none.”

“And if they are not?”

“Then those same stages can be used to conceal the true source of money.”

The defence—

“So you are speaking of a possibility.”

Mayank—

“If one looks only at the structure. In this case there is additional material: links to the source, messages, meetings, and statements from account holders.”

Ishaan, seated at the back, smiled.

He remembered his father's kitchen story about fire and smoke.

Smoke is inference.

Go to the kitchen and look.

Here, the court was inside the kitchen.



Outside the court, Shailesh Mandal's wife Aarti came to meet him for the first time.

Shailesh was out on bail, but still suspended.

The two sat behind a tea stall.

“Will you come home?” Shailesh asked.

Aarti said—

“Meet the children. We will decide later whether you will live at home.”

Shailesh lowered his eyes.

“I will change.”

“To pay your losses, you sold my lies too.”

“I know.”

“No. Do you know now?”

Shailesh was silent.

Aarti said—

“I was sad when you went to jail. Now that you are out, I am afraid.”

“Why?”

“Whether the same man will come back into the house.”

Shailesh's throat tightened.

“I am not the same man.”

Aarti did not answer.

The claim of change is easy.
Time is the evidence of trust.
The court will decide guilt.
A home watches for recurrence.



Ritesh Das too returned to his village after becoming a witness under state protection.

But there was no work.

People said—

“Police man.”

Old companions said—

“Traitor.”

His family said—

“Don’t go to the city.”

He opened a small mobile-phone repair shop.

There were few customers in the first month.

One day Abhishek appeared before him.

The two remained silent for a long time.

Ritesh said—

“Forgive me.”

Abhishek—

“For what?”

“For what I did to you.”

“Will my sister get that year back?”

“No.”

“Will the stain on the bank record disappear?”

“No.”

Ritesh bowed his head.

After a long while Abhishek said—

“Maybe forgiveness will come later. For now, only this—never sell anyone else’s account again.”

Ritesh did not smile.

“I won’t.”

Abhishek walked away.

Forgiveness too is not an order of the court.

It belongs to the victim.



One day during Saurabh Bardhan's period of bail, the Uttarayan Fund itself announced—

An independent external review.

A public summary of old investment sources.

A revised investment history for Ambar.

Risk notes that had previously been removed would be placed in an archival appendix.

Some people said, "Image management."

Others, "Reform."

Rachna said—

"It can be both."

Whether an institution is repenting or managing risk is difficult to read from the mind.

But the public record improved.

Satyaprakash's objection entered the files of a new generation.

Mrinalini heard the news.

"His name?"

Ishaan said—

"Yes."

"Good."

That was all.

Twenty years later, a dead man's small objection returned to corporate history.

Some justice is not punishment.

It is the restoration of memory.



One day in court, the judge stopped both the defence and the prosecution and said—

"The phrase 'the whole network' is being used repeatedly in this trial. The court reminds both sides: a system may be abstract, but liability must be determined by evidence against a person or a legal entity. A collective environment is not a substitute for individual culpability."

Rachna asked for a copy of that sentence.

It seemed like the heart of the novel.

Conjunction mattered.

But one could not dissolve individual guilt into Conjunction.

Nor could one find an individual and then forget the Conjunction.

Justice lay between the two.



One evening Ishaan went to Aniruddh Chaudhary's house.

Aniruddh had grown very old.

There were no old files on the table.

Only tea.

"Where is the story now?" Aniruddh asked.

"In court."

"Stories count for less there."

"Yes."

"Your father?"

Ishaan took a long breath.

"Devanshu will stand trial."

"Satisfied?"

"No."

"Angry?"

"Not as much as before."

"Then?"

Ishaan looked out of the window.

"I am beginning to understand that justice does not answer every question."

Aniruddh smiled.

"That is painful to understand."

"Does that make justice smaller?"

"No. Human expectation was larger."

Ishaan fell silent.

Aniruddh said—

"Justice is the discipline of truth, not omniscience."

Ishaan held the sentence in his mind.

"Dadi used to say—the bank."

"They may be the same thing."



The mongoose appeared again at Garh Narikel.

This time there were two.

One large.

One small.

Mrinalini watched from the veranda.

The small mongoose followed the larger one.

Sometimes it vanished into the grass.

Then emerged again.

Far away, near the water, a long monitor-lizard track lay in the mud.

Mrinalini did not rise and go closer.
 She only watched—
 One generation behind.
 One ahead.
 A guardian is not merely a solitary creature.
 It is also a learned disposition.
 She said softly—
 “The watch is taught.”
 The water of the Kamla-Balan was still.
 But there is no rule that still water is innocent.
 Nor that moving water is guilty.
 Look.
 Observe.
 Examine.
 Then speak.
 No less.
 No more.
 The story was moving forward in court.
 And on the bank, two pairs of mongoose tracks were taking shape.



The trial in the Special Court moved on month after month.
 What looked from outside like a single event broke, inside, into
 hundreds of small questions.
 Which account was opened when?
 From whose phone did an instruction arrive?
 Which message was merely business language?
 Which message, once placed in context, revealed criminal intent?
 Which account holder knew?
 Who merely closed their eyes out of greed?
 Who was deceived?
 Who deceived others?
 The judge kept repeating one thing—
 “An individual’s guilt does not arise automatically from a collective
 environment.”
 The sentence restrained the prosecution too.
 And the defence.
 The prosecution could not colour everyone alike by saying “the whole
 network.”
 The defence could not erase responsibility by saying, “I was only a cog.”

There is Conjunction.

But within Conjunction, each part has its own nature.



On the day Manoj Nayak's role was argued, the courtroom was full.

He had chosen not to testify himself.

But his earlier statement, telephone records, Ritesh's testimony, Raghubir's statement, and Lokvistar's documents were before the court.

The defence said—

"Ritesh himself took commissions. He invokes Manoj's name to reduce his own responsibility."

The prosecution—

"Then why was Ritesh assaulted?"

"Manoj did not order an assault."

"The call to Raghubir?"

"Security work."

"Two hours before the assault?"

"Coincidence."

The judge asked—

"Raghubir himself admits that Manoj told him to 'talk' to Ritesh?"

"Yes, but not to use violence."

"What was the context of this 'talk'?"

Silence.

Sometimes deception does not lie in a false word.

It lies in removing the context.



Two of Raghubir's associates accepted responsibility in a separate case and applied for a lighter sentence.

Their statements made Manoj's role clearer.

One said—

"Raghubir said—the man above is very angry; make the boy understand."

"Who was 'the man above'?"

"Manoj."

"Did Raghubir use Manoj's name?"

"Yes."

"Did he tell you to beat him?"

"No. But we understood that we were to frighten him."

The defence immediately—

“Meaning you understood it that way.”

“Yes.”

“Manoj did not say it.”

“I never spoke with Manoj.”

Again, the boundary.

But the circumstances kept joining.

The court’s note did not use the word “order.”

It raised the question of “induced pressure.”

The language was fine-grained.

The weight of responsibility was heavy.



In final argument, Saurabh Bardhan’s side said—

“Investor risk management is not a crime. A lawful company, a lawful fund, lawful businesses. If someone at a lower level ran private gambling, the principal investor does not thereby become a criminal automatically.”

The prosecution agreed—

“Not automatically.”

The defence looked surprised for a moment.

The prosecutor continued—

“That is why we do not show you his title. We show you the documents.”

The meeting.

Knowledge of Night activity.

The instruction to “protect the main brand.”

The message to keep the old source separate.

Alok Bhasin’s subsidiary-loan method.

Early repayment of loans with money linked to mule accounts.

Saurabh’s response—“Keep the main brand and the fund separate.”

“The question is not that he was a director. The question is how much he knew about this specific flow, and what he did after gaining that knowledge.”

The defence said—

“Separation can also be transparent accounting.”

The prosecution—

“Then why was the true source not stated?”

“Commercial confidentiality.”

“Money from a gambling network is commercial confidentiality?”

The judge intervened—

“I will draw the conclusion.”

The words in court were slowly growing tired.

It was time for the documents to speak.



Keshav Mehta's final argument became more personal.

His lawyer said—

"Keshav's wrongdoing, if any, may amount to a compliance failure. He did not himself run the betting, recruit accounts, or arrange an assault."

The prosecution—

"He directed the financial separation."

"Brand risk."

"Write the service that was actually performed; keep the rest as a separate adjustment'—whose language is that?"

"Accounting."

"Accounting designed to hide the wrong source."

"That is the prosecution's interpretation."

"Then Pradeep Mahajan's statement?"

"A co-accused protecting himself."

"The digital messages?"

"The context is ambiguous."

"The meeting?"

"Commercial."

An attack on every link, one by one.

Vitandā?

No.

The right of the defence.

No one comes to court in order to accept the prosecution's story.

Justice is strong when it can endure opposition.



In final argument, Pradeep Mahajan's lawyer was already looking toward the future sentencing stage.

"He has admitted the offence. He cooperated. He made documents available. He surrendered voluntarily. He assisted poor accused persons with legal-aid work."

The prosecution did not object, but said—

"Remorse does not erase the earlier crime."

The judge—

"Guilt and sentence are separate stages."

Pradeep sat at the back and listened.

He knew Trisha still did not fully trust him.

If the court imposed a light sentence, the sentence at home would not end.

If it imposed a severe one, the crime would not become more true.

A number is not the whole meaning of justice.

But in the end the state must give a number—

Years.

Fine.

Restitution.

Conditions.

That is the institutional language of punishment.



In the old Satyaprakash case, Devanshu's trial was moving slowly in a separate court.

One day Mrinalini was called to testify.

She said only what she herself knew.

Satyaprakash had spoken at home about pressure being placed on him.

Six percent.

The sports-promotion payment.

“Did he name anyone?”

“He mentioned some names, but after twenty years I cannot be certain of the exact words.”

The prosecution tried to help her—

“Devanshu?”

Mrinalini was silent.

“Do you remember?”

“I had heard the name. But I cannot separate whether Satyaprakash used it in that very context, or whether I connected it later after reading the papers.”

The judge looked at her.

“Say only as much as you are certain of.”

Mrinalini nodded.

Ishaan sat at the back.

His mother was protecting the limits of her own memory.

Twenty years of grief had not given her false certainty.

Ishaan's eyes filled.

The lesson of Dadi's house had entered the courtroom.



Devanshu's lawyer asked—

“After your husband’s death, did you suspect Devanshu Rakshit?”

“At first, no one with certainty.”

“Later?”

“I heard the name through news reports, the police, and documents.”

“Then your present memory may have been influenced?”

“Yes.”

A stir ran through the courtroom.

Had the defence grown stronger?

Perhaps.

But Mrinalini would not lie in order to rescue the prosecution.

Outside, Ishaan asked—

“Ma, why did you say ‘yes?’”

Mrinalini looked at him with tired eyes.

“Because it may be so.”

“That lawyer will use it.”

“Let him.”

“Babu?”

“Should I lie in your father’s name?”

Ishaan was silent.

Mrinalini said softly—

“I want justice for Satyaprakash, not falsehood in Satyaprakash’s name.”

Ishaan would never forget that sentence.



In the Special Court, a date was announced for judgment in the new gambling case.

Three weeks later.

Speculation outside.

Who would be convicted?

Who would be acquitted?

How severe would the sentences be?

In the meantime Ishaan went to Garh Narikel.

Before the judgment he wanted to be away from the noise of the city.

Mrinalini had planted a new tulsi in the courtyard.

Half the flood marks had faded.

“Are you afraid?” Mrinalini asked.

“Of the judgment?”

“Yes.”

“Yes.”

“Why? You are not an accused.”

Ishaan laughed.

“Years of work can become very small inside a single order.”

“And if the court sees it differently?”

“Then?”

“Then read the court’s reasons.”

Ishaan looked at his mother’s face.

The woman who had wanted an answer for twenty years was now telling her son to read not the result, but the reasons.

Perhaps justice changed here.

From judgment toward reason.



On the day of judgment, there was not enough room in the courtroom.

The judge began by saying—

“This order is based on a separate evaluation of the evidence against each accused. Society’s moral outrage is not a substitute for legal proof.”

Ishaan sat at the back, holding his breath.

First, Raghubir Tanti.

Sending men to put pressure on Ritesh—the circumstances, calls, and statements of his associates—proved the charge.

Sentence according to the specific scope of the assault.

Manoj Nayak.

The mule-recruitment network, targets, pressure on Ritesh, Lokvistar’s structure—some charges were proved.

But knowledge of every financial layer was not proved.

He was therefore not declared the owner of the entire network.

Keshav Mehta.

Knowledge of financial adjustments, separation of Night settlements, assistance in accounting for false sources—some of the principal financial offences were proved.

On some broader conspiracy charges, the benefit of doubt.

Pradeep Mahajan.

His admitted role, supported by documents—guilt proved; cooperation, surrender, and remorse to be considered at sentencing.

Saurabh Bardhan.

The court read for a long time.

His position as investor alone was not enough.

But the meeting, emails, the subsidiary-loan structure, instructions to conceal sources, and communications with Alok Bhasin proved knowledge and assistance in some financial offences.

Yet the prosecution's claim that he directly controlled the entire private-betting operation was not fully proved.

Udaynath Mishra—not an accused; the order noted possible moral negligence, but insufficient basis had been presented to prove a crime against him in this case.

Some small account holders were acquitted.

Some who knowingly and repeatedly sold the use of their accounts were convicted.

Sabina remained a witness; she faced separate limited administrative and banking consequences, not liability for the criminal conspiracy.

Abhishek's non-culpable status remained unchanged.

The court did not kill the whole monitor lizard.

It measured the separate wrongs of separate bodies.



Outside, the media made headlines within the first five minutes—

“SAURABH, KESHAV CONVICTED.”

“COURT HAMMERS GAMBLING NETWORK.”

“SEVERAL ACCUSED ACQUITTED.”

No one had yet read the nuances of the order.

Ishaan did not wait outside.

He went straight to Aniruddh's house.

Aniruddh switched off the radio.

“What happened?”

Ishaan gave him the short version.

“Satisfied?”

Ishaan thought.

“Some guilt was proved. Some was not.”

“That is the court's work.”

“But the network as a whole?”

“The court was not sitting there to write the philosophy of the network.”

“Then?”

Pouring tea, Aniruddh said—

“Society will have to change the structure. The court will punish the individuals whose guilt it has proved.”

“The two are separate?”

“Yes. Law does not do every job by itself.”

Ishaan took a long breath.

For years he had expected far too much from a single institution.



On sentencing day, Pradeep's daughter Trisha came.

She sat at the back.

Pradeep saw her.

He said nothing.

The court considered cooperation, surrender, duration of the wrongdoing, role, and harm.

Sentence was pronounced.

Not very light.

Not the maximum.

Credit for time already spent in judicial custody.

A financial penalty.

Some restitution orders.

Pradeep bowed his head.

Outside, Trisha met him for a moment.

"Babu."

"Yes."

"Now?"

"What the court has said."

"Back to prison?"

"For some time."

With tears in her eyes, Trisha said—

"I will wait."

For the first time, Pradeep did not try to take her hand.

He only nodded.

One has no right over trust.

It is earned.

Slowly.



Vihan Sarang was not in court when Keshav's sentence was pronounced.

He was at the Ambar office, releasing a public reform plan with employees.

All outside contracts connected with private betting were terminated.

An independent compliance committee.

Mule-account risk training.

User-loss limits and assistance mechanisms.

Some employees said—too late.

True.

Some said—performance.

Possible.

Some reforms begin in fear.
Some in guilt.
Some to save reputation.
Time would evaluate the result.
Justice cannot measure only the purity of the heart.
It must also see whether the system changed.



Hearing Manoj's sentence, his mother cried—
“My son fell into bad company.”
Rachna heard it on television.
She thought—
Bad company.
Greed.
Structure.
Choice.
Each word shifts responsibility for crime to a different place.
Manoj was not a child.
He had made choices.
But those choices were not made in a vacuum.
The network created opportunity.
Money supplied the reward.
Silence from above.
Pressure below.
The court measured the individual's share.
Society still had to look at the rest.



Judgment in the old Satyaprakash case was still pending.
Ishaan was in a strange state within himself.
The court had already decided the new criminal case.
His father's story was still open.
Mrinalini said—
“Do not join the two.”
“But they are connected.”
“The money is connected. My grief is not.”
Ishaan understood.
Satyaprakash's death was not proved by the convictions of Keshav and Saurabh.
The entire novel had laboured to avoid precisely that error.



In final argument in Devanshu's case, the prosecution said—

“We do not present written proof of a direct order to kill. Our case rests on a chain of circumstantial evidence.”

Satyaprakash's objection.

Digant's financial motive.

Devanshu's admission that he directed unlawful pressure.

Haricharan's history of violence.

The booking of a heavy vehicle.

Its timing on the night of death.

The rapid repair afterwards.

Ramavatar's note on the photograph.

Devanshu's statement that Haricharan later said, “The job went wrong.”

The defence challenged each link, one by one.

“That it was the same vehicle—not directly proved.”

“The driver's statement was incomplete.”

“Haricharan is dead.”

“Devanshu's memory comes twenty years later.”

“No admission of an order to kill.”

“Pressure does not mean murder.”

All were proper questions.

The final problem before the court—

Did the links together make one conclusion inevitable, or only possible?

Nyāya inference and criminal law's standard of doubt stood face to face at a single point.



On the day of judgment, Mrinalini came.

Ishaan sat beside her.

Devanshu was in front.

The judge read a long order.

First, the court made one thing clear—

The old conclusion that Satyaprakash's death was merely an ordinary accidental road collision was no longer reliable.

There was sufficient evidence of a campaign of violent pressure by Haricharan.

The chain indicating probable use of a vehicle was strong.

Devanshu had initiated unlawful pressure—by his own admission.

He knew Haricharan's violent tendencies.

But—

It was not proved beyond reasonable doubt that Devanshu specifically desired Satyaprakash's death or directed a vehicular collision.

The highest direct liability for murder was therefore not proved.

But he was culpable to the extent of conspiring to exert unlawful pressure and instigating a dangerous course of conduct whose grave consequences were foreseeable.

The language of the order was legal.

For Mrinalini, its meaning was simple—

The state now said that Babu's death should not be treated as an ordinary accident.

But the state could not say that Devanshu had ordered murder.

A twenty-year question received half an answer.

Half remained lost.



Outside the court, reporters rushed toward Mrinalini.

"Have you received justice?"

She stopped.

Ishaan wanted to stop her from answering.

Mrinalini raised a hand to stop him.

She looked toward the cameras.

"I accept as much as has been proved. What has not been proved, I will not declare proved merely because of my grief."

The reporters fell silent.

One asked—

"Are you satisfied?"

Mrinalini said softly—

"Grief is not satisfied."

That was all.

She walked away.

Ishaan followed.

The entire tragedy was contained in that one sentence.

Justice may be received.

Grief does not end.



After hearing his sentence, Devanshu turned toward Mrinalini for a moment with the court's permission.

He tried to say something.

Mrinalini did not stop.

She had no duty to forgive him.
Nor did she have a duty to hate him.
Some relationships are not made by a court.
It merely ends them.



After returning to Garh Narikel, Mrinalini did not light a lamp before Satyaprakash's photograph.

She hung the photograph back on the wall.

That was all.

Ishaan asked—

“No lamp today?”

“It was not worship.”

“Then?”

“Waiting.”

“And now?”

Mrinalini opened the window.

“Now the waiting is over.”

“The answer is not complete.”

“The waiting had stopped being for the answer, son. I was waiting for the state to say that what I had been seeing was not madness. It has said so.”

Ishaan lowered his eyes.

“Then Babu?”

“With me.”

Mrinalini smiled.

Very slightly.

Very wearily.

But truly.



That evening Ishaan went alone to the bank of the Kamla-Balan.

After the rains, the river was wide.

A long monitor-lizard track lay in the mud.

He did not go closer.

Two mongooses emerged from a distant thicket.

One large, one small.

The larger one first sniffed along the bank.

The smaller copied its movements.

The water stirred.

Two circular ripples.

Something heavy turned beneath the surface.
The small mongoose stepped back once.
The larger remained still.
Then both changed direction and moved toward the higher grass.
No fight.
No victory.
No water-burial.
The monitor lizard in the water.
The mongoose on the bank.
Ishaan suddenly understood—
A guardian's work is not to rid the world of monitor lizards.
Monitor lizards will remain.
Snakes will remain.
Greed will remain.
Fear will remain.
New technology.
New money.
New names.
The guardian's work—
To carry the knowledge of recognition to the next generation.



In the capital city, Rachna Sinha was clearing the board at the final joint review meeting.

“Evidence.”

“Doubt.”

“Purpose.”

“Reasoning.”

“Conjunction.”

“Memory.”

One word after another was erased.

Rohit asked—

“Is everything over?”

Rachna said—

“A case can end. A method cannot.”

Mayank laughed—

“Nyaya philosophy survives.”

Rachna put down the marker.

“Not philosophy. Habit.”

Naina Verma asked—

“What habit?”

Rachna answered—

“Say what you saw as what you saw. Say what you inferred as inference. Leave what you do not know empty. And resist the temptation to fill an empty space.”

The room fell silent.

No one applauded.

Sentences like that are not meant for applause.

They are meant for work.



In the final public report of his mule-account risk project, Ishaan added one line—

“Criminal networks change their technology; the logic of exploiting social vulnerability returns again and again. Prevention means not only catching criminals, but also protecting vulnerable people before they can be turned into usable instruments.”

Sumedha read it.

“No ‘preliminary sample’ this time?”

Ishaan smiled.

“The basis for this conclusion is sufficient.”

“Good.”

He signed it.

Name—

Ishaan Karna.

For the first time, in his own name he heard not only his father, but also his own work.



One day, while cleaning the courtyard, Mrinalini laid Dhaneshwari’s water-damaged notebook in the sun to dry.

“Do not abandon the house out of fear of a snake; but do not believe there is a snake in the house until you have seen it.”

The line was half blurred.

The ink had run.

But it could still be read.

Beneath it, in her own hand, she added a new line—

“And if you do see it, keep watch not with fear—but with intelligence.”

She closed the notebook.

It was not scripture.

It was the memory of a household.
A small tradition of justice.



At night there was a rustle outside the threshold.
Mrinalini opened the door.
The small mongoose was alone.
Not the larger one.
It stood at the threshold and looked inside the house.
Then toward the field behind it.
Far away in the grass, the shadow of a cobra moved.
The mongoose did not chase it.
It simply stood between.
Mrinalini smiled.
“Have you learned?”
The mongoose did not answer.
Animals do not speak philosophy.
They only act.
After a while, the snake changed direction.
The mongoose too went away.
The water of the Kamla-Balan was black in the night.
Somewhere within it there might be a monitor lizard.
Or there might not.
Mrinalini closed the door.
She slid the bolt into place.
She extinguished the lamp.
The house went dark.
The watch did not end.



The city did not become quiet after the verdict.
Only the direction of the news changed.
Earlier the question had been—who is guilty?
Now—
Who will appeal?
How much will the sentence be reduced?
How much money will be recovered?
Will Ambar survive or shut down?
What will happen to the mule-account holders?
Will Satyaprakash's family receive compensation?

A court gives a judgment.
Life begins after the judgment.



Saurabh Bardhan filed an appeal.

Keshav did too.

Manoj did too.

Pradeep did not file a partial appeal; his lawyer was considering a limited plea only on the proportionality of the sentence, but Pradeep said—

“The part I did, I will not fight by pretending it was nothing.”

The lawyer was surprised.

“The law gives you a right to appeal.”

“I am not giving up that right. But I will not create a false dispute over facts.”

“The sentence?”

“Where there is a legal error, there.”

The lawyer nodded.

It would be easy to say that Pradeep had changed greatly.

The more accurate thing was this—

He no longer wanted to search behind every sentence for his own convenience.

The final proof of change is the future.

For now, there was only a beginning.



Trisha came to visit her father in prison.

This time she was not behind glass, but seated at a distance in the permitted family-visitation room.

“School is about to end,” she said.

“And after that?”

“I am not going to study accounting.”

Pradeep laughed for the first time.

“Why?”

“I have seen enough accounting at home.”

For a few moments, both of them laughed.

Then Trisha grew serious—

“I am thinking of studying law.”

Pradeep’s face changed.

“Because of me?”

“Partly.”

“To defend me?”

“No.”

The answer came at once.

Pradeep fell silent.

Trisha said—

“I want to understand how the same person can be wrong and yet not be a complete monster. At school everyone wants only two boxes—criminal or innocent.”

Pradeep's eyes filled.

“The law must have many boxes too.”

“Then I will study it.”

“All right.”

This was not forgiveness.

But conversation had been born again.

Many broken homes begin to join again with a first sentence.



Ambar Interactive survived.

But it became smaller.

Investors withdrew.

The number of employees fell.

Some products were shut down.

The main gaming platform continued in a limited form after regulatory review.

At a public meeting, Vihan Sarang said—

“I cannot take responsibility for every legal offence, but I will not run from responsibility for the institutional failure.”

A reporter asked—

“Is this a PR statement?”

Vihan replied—

“You may choose to see it that way. Then look at what we do.”

Work.

Again, the same thing.

Conduct after words.

The independent compliance committee's first report was severe—

Ambar's old culture had been growth-centred.

The meaning of warnings had been minimised.

Responsibility for external partners had been left unclear.

The board had been influenced by the speed of profits.

The report was made public.

The company's share-like private valuation fell.

One night Vihan sat alone in the empty office, reading the report.

Whether making the truth public would save the company or kill it—there was no answer yet.

But some truths are written not after profit, but even against profit—this was something new.



Rachna Sinha was transferred to a new post.

Far from the capital city.

Some said—it was a reward.

Some—the system had moved her out.

Some—a routine service transfer.

Rachna laughed.

“Three stories from the same piece of paper.”

Rohit asked—

“What do you think?”

“It is a transfer order. The rest is inference.”

Mayank burst out laughing.

“Now you have made the disease permanent.”

While packing, Rachna looked at an old photograph of the board—

Event.

Relation.

Cause.

Evidence.

Judgment.

She saved the photograph on her personal phone.

Not in the office.

A method can be transferred.

Institutions can change.



Ishaan's mule-account project became part of a training curriculum at two state universities.

On the first day in class he did not write an example of a crime. He wrote a simple question—

“Whose is the account?”

A student said—

“The person whose name is on it at the bank.”

Ishaan then wrote—

“Whose is the money?”

The answers differed.

“The person who earned it.”

“The person entitled to it.”

“The person it was sent to.”

“The person who is its source.”

Ishaan smiled.

“That is where the problem begins.”

He did not teach operational techniques.

He taught social warning signs—

Sudden commission.

A vague work-from-home offer.

A request to receive payments for an unknown business into one's own account.

A new route to “earn” offered to a user already in debt.

The consequences for the family when an account is used.

“A criminal network does not need only clever technology,” Ishaan said.
“It needs a vulnerable moment.”

A student asked—

“Sir, are poor people more excusable?”

Ishaan answered—

“Poverty is not a licence for crime. But circumstances are part of understanding responsibility. If justice refuses to look at circumstances, it will see only behaviour.”

“Then what is the boundary?”

“Evidence.”

Dadi's language had reached an academic classroom.



Sabina Khatoon's tailoring shop began running again.

It took time for monitoring on her bank account to be lifted.

Local distrust lasted longer.

One customer asked—

“Wasn't your account the one in the police case?”

Sabina stopped the machine.

Once she might have lied.

Now she said—

“Yes. For five thousand rupees I let them use my account. There was an investigation. I told them the mistake I had made.”

The customer picked up the cloth.

She thought for a few moments.
 “I need the blouse by Friday.”
 Sabina let out her breath.
 Social rehabilitation does not come by order of law.
 Sometimes it begins when one customer comes back.



Abhishek's sister Manjari was nearing the end of her nursing training.
 One day a bank-awareness camp was held at the hospital.
 The speaker was saying—
 “Do not let anyone else use your bank account.”
 Manjari sat at the back.
 She remembered her brother's face.
 The family land.
 The year that had been lost.
 The bank's phone calls.
 The police.
 During the question-and-answer session, she raised her hand.
 “If someone has made a mistake once, will the bank treat that person as suspicious forever?”
 The speaker gave a general answer—
 “It depends on the circumstances.”
 Manjari was not satisfied.
 “The system should have a clear path for correction.”
 An officer from the camp met her afterwards.
 No name, no case.
 Only to hear the suggestion.
 Manjari said—
 “Once a person's name turns red, their whole life should not remain red forever.”
 She did not know whether that sentence entered any policy note.
 But she had said it.
 Sometimes keeping watch is also a small sentence.



Shailesh Mandal did not return to his school job immediately.
 Departmental inquiry.
 Suspension.
 Counselling.
 Aarti continued living separately with the children.

At a behavioural counselling centre resembling a de-addiction programme, Shailesh began attending a gambling-addiction group.

Five men came the first day.

Three the second.

There was no magical recovery.

One man said—

“I keep playing to win back what I lost.”

Shailesh replied—

“So did I.”

“Did you win it back?”

“I lost my home.”

The room fell silent.

He did not preach.

He told his own story.

Some warnings are more powerful in the voice of a broken man than in a book on criminology.



Ritesh Das changed the name of his mobile-repair shop—

“New Road.”

Some people laughed.

He endured it.

Months later Abhishek came again.

To have a phone screen replaced.

Ritesh did the work.

He named the price.

Abhishek paid the full amount.

Ritesh said—

“Leave it, I—”

Abhishek stopped him.

“Money for work is money for work.”

Ritesh accepted the note.

That was all between them.

No written apology.

No embrace.

But the relation between them now rested not on criminal commission, but on an ordinary service.

Some forms of restoration are that ordinary.



Devanshu Rakshit appealed against his sentence.

Poor health.

Age.

Questions of law.

Mrinalini heard the news.

Ishaan asked—

“Are you worried?”

“No.”

“If the sentence is reduced?”

“The court will consider its reasons.”

“You have changed.”

Mrinalini laughed.

“I am tired.”

Both things could be true at once.

Then she said—

“Part of what I wanted has been written into the judgment. Counting the years of his sentence will not bring Satyaprakash back.”

An old word rose in Ishaan's mind—

Revenge.

Not justice.



Aniruddh Chaudhary's health declined rapidly.

Ishaan went to the hospital.

Aniruddh was on oxygen, but conscious.

“The report?” he asked softly.

“The training has begun.”

“Good.”

“Babu's case...”

Aniruddh raised a hand.

“I know.”

“If you had not been there...”

Aniruddh opened his eyes and looked at him.

“Do not say things like that.”

Ishaan fell silent.

“No investigation is done by one man alone.”

“But on the first day—direct perception separate, inference separate—”

Aniruddh smiled faintly.

“I did not invent that.”

“Then?”

“Old knowledge. A habit of work.”

Ishaan’s eyes filled.

“Dadi too.”

“Then you had two teachers.”

After a few moments, Aniruddh said—

“Remember—more important than a correct conclusion is the correct method. Conclusions can change.”

Ishaan held his hand.

Aniruddh’s palm was cold.

“And if, by a wrong method, we catch the right man?”

“Next time, an innocent man will be caught.”

He grew tired.

Ishaan sat quietly beside him.



Aniruddh died two weeks later.

The official honours were limited.

The family wanted a private funeral.

Rachna came from her distant posting.

Mayank.

Rohit.

Ishaan.

A few former officers.

Mrinalini did not come; her health would not permit it.

No one made a speech after the funeral.

With the family’s permission, Ishaan only looked through a copy of Aniruddh’s old notebook.

On one page was written—

“Respect doubt, not fear.”

On another—

“Weakness in testimony need not mean weakness in the witness’s character; memory is a human limitation.”

On a third—

“An investigation does not end when a criminal is found; removing the wrong accused is also investigation.”

Ishaan returned the notebook.

It seemed to him that Aniruddh’s death had removed yet another bank from the story.

Then Dadi’s words returned—

Do not abandon the bank.

Where one person has gone, the next must stand.



On the train back, Rachna kept looking out of the window.

A message came on her phone from the new district—

A fraud network.

Several bank accounts.

An innocent old man's pension frozen.

New case.

New names.

New water.

She did not switch off the phone.

She asked for the file.

Life is not a story in which music plays after the final judgment and everything ends.

Criminal networks take new forms.

The method returned to work.



A few months later, the state government issued new guidelines for classifying mule-account victims and participants.

Three broad categories—

Knowing, organised participation.

Continued participation for profit despite suspicion.

Victims of deception, ignorance, or limited negligence.

The classification was not perfect.

Difficult cases lay on the boundaries.

But the old simplicity—"all account holders are criminals"—had been broken.

Ishaan was not a direct member of the drafting committee.

His report was cited.

He read the notice and went to his mother.

"Ma, something changed."

Mrinalini asked—

"How much?"

"A little."

"A little worse?"

"A little better."

"Then that is good."

She went back to chopping vegetables.

Perhaps that was the most honest celebration of a policy change.
Life went on.



In the new public records of Udayrekha Public Trust and Uttarayan, Satyaprakash's objection was entered under his full name.

A researcher wrote an email to Ishaan—

“I am researching public projects, private sponsorship, and financial transparency in India. May I use the public records of the Satyaprakash Karna case?”

Ishaan looked at the email for a long time.

His father was no longer only the family's dead man.

He had become an example in a public study.

Ishaan showed it to Mrinalini.

“What should I say?”

Mrinalini said—

“Let them use what is public. But not what belongs to the house.”

A boundary.

Again, the same thing.

Public truth.

Private grief.

Each has a different ownership.



New embankment repairs began along the Kamla-Balan.

The irony did not escape Ishaan.

Satyaprakash. Contracting.

Embankment.

Percentage.

Death.

And now, government work again.

But Ishaan read the tender board not with fear, but with care.

Contractor's name.

Price.

Work period.

Complaint number.

Public portal.

He took a photograph with his phone.

Mrinalini asked—

“Investigating again?”

“No. Being a citizen.”

“The difference?”

“A great deal.”

She laughed.

“Good.”

Keeping watch is not only the work of the police.

Transparency is also a form of watchfulness.

So are questions.

So is information.



One evening the small mongoose came into the courtyard.

It no longer looked small as before.

Its body had filled out.

Its gait was confident.

Mrinalini could not be certain that she recognised it.

She had never given it a name.

Mongoose was not the name of an individual, but of a kind.

A role.

It crossed the courtyard and went near the old burrow, which had dried out again after the flood.

It sniffed.

Dug at the earth.

Went inside.

After a while it came out again.

Mrinalini watched from a distance.

“Have you chosen a home?”

The mongoose did not hear her.

Or heard and ignored her.

Human beings assign meaning.

Animals live their lives.



That night Ishaan sat with his mother on the veranda.

“Ma, if all this became a book?”

Mrinalini looked at him.

“About what?”

“Babu. The gambling network. The accounts. The court. Dadi. Everything.”

“Will you write it?”

“I don’t know.”

“Then?”

“Someone will.”

Mrinalini thought for a few moments.

“One thing.”

“What?”

“Do not make me the heroine.”

Ishaan laughed.

“Why?”

“I was afraid. I cried. Many times I wanted to give up.”

“That is precisely why—”

“No. Write me as a human being.”

Ishaan stopped laughing and grew serious.

“All right.”

“And do not turn Satyaprakash into a martyr. He was stubborn. He listened too little to the family. Sometimes he was foolish.”

Ishaan laughed.

“Ma!”

“It is true.”

Both of them laughed.

Turning the dead into gods can also be a form of laundering memory.

True memory includes faults.

And love.



The night deepened.

Wind came from the direction of the Kamla-Balan.

A dog barked in the distance.

There was a faint rustle in the bushes.

Ishaan rose to look.

Nothing.

Mrinalini said—

“Do not imagine a snake at every sound.”

Ishaan smiled.

“Dadi.”

“Me.”

They sat down again.

A little while later the mongoose really did come out.

It did not cross the threshold.

It stood at the edge.

Looking into the darkness.

Ishaan said softly—

“The watch.”

Mrinalini answered—

“Yes. But keeping watch does not mean living in fear all the time.”

Ishaan thought about this new line.

If watchfulness becomes fear, life becomes a prison.

If watchfulness disappears, danger enters the house.

Between them lies intelligence.

That is justice.

That is life.



At Rachna Sinha's new office, the first training session began.

She wrote five words on the board—

Seen.

Heard.

Inferred.

Proved.

Unproved.

A young officer asked—

“Ma'am, is it really that simple?”

Rachna said—

“Simple to write. Difficult to do.”

“Why?”

“Because human beings cannot bear an empty space.”

“Then?”

“Practise leaving the unproved unproved.”

The young officer laughed.

“The public will say the police know nothing.”

“Sometimes that will be true.”

“And reputation?”

Rachna put down the marker.

“The day you invent false certainty to protect reputation, the investigation is over.”

The room was silent.

Then the training began.

A new generation.

New files.

The watch was being taught.



First light at Garh Narikel.

Mrinalini opened the door.

Footprints on the earth.

One mongoose.

Then another set of smaller footprints.

Perhaps a young one.

She did not bend down.

She did not measure the steps.

She did not take a photograph.

Not everything has to become evidence.

Some things are only signs of life.

She began sweeping the courtyard.

Some footprints disappeared.

Some remained near the edge.

The waters of the Kamla-Balan glittered.

Somewhere far away, there might be a monitor lizard.

A snake too.

People would go out to their work.

Banks would open.

Courts would sit.

New tenders would be issued.

New games would flash on mobile screens.

Someone would offer temptation.

Someone would refuse.

Someone would be trapped.

Someone would escape.

Someone would ask questions.

Someone would remain silent.

Someone would keep watch.

The story went on.



Time slowly blunted the edge of the judgments.

Newspapers moved on to new subjects.

New scandals.

New elections.

New floods.

New games.

New applications.

The case that had once led every television channel was now one line in a court list.

But for the families who had lived inside it, time was not the order of the news.

Pradeep counted days in prison.

Manoj counted the date of his appeal.

Keshav had his lawyer's papers.

Saurabh had the ashes of his reputation.

Abhishek had a corrected bank record.

Sabina had the trust of her customers.

Mrinalini had the photograph on the wall.

Ishaan had his curriculum.

Court orders became public.

Punishment was served in private time.



In the High Court, Saurabh's and Keshav's appeals were heard separately, not together.

Saurabh's lawyer argued again—

“The investor side wanted risk kept separate. That does not prove criminal knowledge.”

The State replied—

“Not from one sentence. But the meeting, the financial trail, Alok Bhasin's email, the direction concerning ‘old sources,’ and the context of the night flow together establish knowledge.”

The court did not preserve every finding of the trial court unchanged.

Some charges were set aside.

Some remained.

The term of sentence was reduced slightly.

But the principal conviction relating to financial assistance remained.

Outside, one reporter said—

“Relief for Saurabh too.”

Another—

“Conviction stands.”

Both headlines were half true.

The full order was long.

Life had once again become the victim of a short sentence.



The court was sterner in Keshav's appeal.

It accepted that “separate accounting” was not, by itself, a crime.

But when a person repeatedly keeps a flow outside the main accounts despite having sufficient warning about its source and nature, responsibility does not end by calling it merely a “compliance failure.”

Most of Keshav’s conviction remained intact.

He returned to prison.

On the first night he asked for the library.

The guard laughed—

“Now?”

“Yes.”

He was given library access the next day.

Among the books he found economics, law, novels, religion—everything.

But what broke something inside him most deeply was not a book.

It was a small booklet from the prison-reform programme—

“The Human Impact of Financial Crime.”

It contained no real names.

Anonymous accounts.

A nursing student whose fees were held up during an account investigation.

A homemaker whose medical money was frozen.

A teacher’s family broken by gambling debt.

An elderly father whose son rented out his account for commission.

A small trader whose lawful money remained blocked for a month.

Keshav stopped turning the pages.

He had seen all these amounts before as figures—

Four lakh.

Eighty thousand.

One lakh fifteen thousand.

Three thousand commission.

Five thousand a month.

Now there was a household behind every amount.

He closed the booklet.

He could not sleep in the barrack that night.

The abstraction of money had been crime’s shield.

Punishment was turning it back into human faces.



A few days later, the prison held a statutory rehabilitation session on financial crime.

No victim was brought in directly.

There was no emotional confrontation.

Only anonymized statements were read aloud.

“My sister lost a year.”

“My child’s treatment stopped.”

“Five thousand was a great deal to me.”

“I gave my account, but I did not understand that it was a route for crime.”

“I knew something was wrong, and still I did not stop.”

Pradeep was not seated beside Keshav; he was serving his sentence in another prison.

But Keshav remembered Pradeep’s old sentence—

“First the job. Then fear. Then habit.”

He thought about himself—

First growth.

Then risk.

Then separate accounts.

Then silence.

Then habit.

The human mind searches for language for its own wrongdoing.

Sometimes truth begins when the right language is finally found.



Saurabh began serving a period in prison.

His lawyer was still advising a further appeal.

Saurabh said—

“We will.”

He did not want to surrender his legal rights.

But his voice was no longer as certain as before.

One day in the prison library his eyes met Keshav’s.

They sat at different tables.

Neither spoke.

For years the two of them had spoken in meetings about numbers, risk, brand, fund, expansion.

There was no iron grille between them now, only silence.

At last Keshav said—

“Ambar survived.”

Saurabh did not lift his eyes from the page.

“Barely.”

“What did we save?”

Saurabh looked at him this time.

No answer.

Keshav did not laugh.

“Earlier I would have thought that question pointless.”

Saurabh said—

“And now?”

“Expensive.”

They fell silent again.

No important offender suddenly became a saint.

The story did not take that cheap road.

Only the questions changed.

Sometimes punishment begins with no more than that.



Pradeep was released after completing the remainder of his imprisonment.

This time both his wife and Trisha were waiting outside the gate.

Trisha had now enrolled in law college.

Pradeep came out and folded his hands.

His wife said—

“Come home.”

This time the sentence was simple.

But the home was not what it had been.

Pradeep first looked for work at accounting firms.

None would take him.

A small nonprofit needed a temporary assistant for a financial-literacy programme.

Pradeep disclosed his entire history.

The manager said—

“For that very reason we cannot say yes immediately.”

Two weeks of checks.

Then a limited contract.

His work was to train small business groups to keep clean books of account.

In the first session a shopkeeper joked—

“You used to be an expert in bad accounts.”

The room grew uncomfortable.

Pradeep did not laugh.

“Yes. That is why I know how high the cost of a false paper can be.”

Silence.

Then the training continued.

Rehabilitation does not erase shame.
It teaches a person to work while carrying it.



In her first year of law school, Trisha came home after a class on “criminal intent.”

That night she asked her father—

“When did your crime begin?”

Pradeep was startled.

“The legal answer?”

“Your answer.”

He thought.

“When I signed the first false paper?”

“Perhaps.”

“Or the first time you knew the paper was false?”

“Perhaps.”

“Or the second time you did it?”

Pradeep drew a long breath.

“The second time.”

“Why?”

“The first time I could tell myself—it was a mistake. The second time I knew.”

Trisha did not take notes.

She was not a student then. She was a daughter.

“I want to write a paper—‘Habit and Criminal Intent.’”

Pradeep’s face went rigid.

“My name?”

“No.”

“All right.”

A few years earlier his daughter had been ashamed of him at school.

Now she was turning experience into thought.

Pain can become knowledge.

But knowledge does not compensate for pain.



One day Mrinalini said to Ishaan—

“Go and visit Aniruddh Babu’s family.”

“Why?”

“Just go.”

Ishaan went.

Aniruddh's wife gave him an old pen.

"He did not leave this specifically for you. But while I was distributing his things, I felt—you should keep it."

Ishaan hesitated.

"I—"

"He used this pen while writing on your father's file."

Ishaan took it.

It was not expensive.

An ordinary fountain pen with blue ink.

When he returned home, Mrinalini saw it.

"Will you write?"

"What?"

"For so long you have been saying someone will write it."

Ishaan laughed.

"You still won't be the heroine."

"I remember."

"Babu won't be a martyr."

"I remember."

"Devanshu won't be merely a monster."

Ishaan stopped.

Mrinalini said—

"He was a bad man. He committed a crime. But if you remove his human shape, how will you understand the crime?"

Ishaan looked at his mother's face.

The language of the novel was slowly being born inside the house.



Ishaan did not begin writing at once.

First he made notes.

"What was directly perceived."

"What was documented."

"What belonged to family memory."

"What the court proved."

"What remained only a possibility."

"What was metaphor."

He made five separate pages.

Mrinalini laughed—

"Are you writing a story or a case diary?"

"Something between the two."

"Be careful."

“Of what?”

“A story fills empty spaces.”

Ishaan smiled.

“That is why there are five pages.”

“All right.”

A new struggle began between literary freedom and the discipline of truth.

A story is not truth.

But neither must it be falsehood.



In her new district, Rachna Sinha stopped an order to arrest a young man during an investigation.

The reason—

The phone was in his name.

Money had entered his account.

But the phone had been reported stolen months earlier.

The account was jointly held by the family.

The initial inference could be wrong.

A young officer said—

“Ma’am, what if the accused escapes because of this?”

Rachna replied—

“Keep him under watch. Arrest is not a substitute for evidence.”

Two days later the actual user turned out to be another person.

The young officer was silent.

Rachna said—

“This time we were right. Next time we may be wrong.”

“Then where does confidence come from?”

“From the method.”

“Not from the conclusion?”

“Never completely.”

Aniruddh was gone.

But the voice continued.



The first annual review came after the State’s banking guidelines had been implemented.

Fewer accounts had been completely frozen in error.

Complaints about suspicious recruitment had increased—because people were now reporting it.

Some officers said—

“Crime has increased.”

Ishaan looked at the data.

“Reports have increased. The actual rate of crime is a different question.”

At one meeting he said clearly—

“More complaints do not necessarily prove a worse system; sometimes they prove better reporting.”

Someone asked—

“Then what counts as success?”

“People who were silent before now speak. Lawful money that gets blocked receives quicker review. Patterns of those who knowingly rent out accounts are detected earlier.”

Data too can give birth to a *hetvābhāsa*.

A number does not explain its own meaning.

It needs context.



Shailesh Mandal's departmental proceeding came to an end.

His job was not immediately restored in full.

He was permitted to return to service with conditions—counselling, financial monitoring, discipline.

Aarti returned home because of the children, but she said—

“This is not forgiveness. It is a chance.”

Shailesh nodded.

On the day of his first salary, he did not withdraw cash from the bank.

He sat with Aarti and made a complete budget.

A small saving.

Debt repayment.

Household expenses.

He had deleted the games from his phone long ago.

But the urge still rose sometimes.

At the group meeting he said—

“The addiction has not disappeared. I have learned to recognize it.”

The watch is not only for the snake outside.

It is for the one within as well.



Sabina Khatoon's daughter finished her treatment and posed for a smiling photograph.

Sabina put the photograph on the wall of her shop.

Behind it, the sewing machine.
 Below it, a small piece of paper—
 “Do not rent out your bank account to anyone.”
 It was not a government poster.
 It was her own experience.
 A customer read it and asked—
 “Does that really happen?”
 Sabina said—
 “It happened to me.”
 The story travelled from mouth to mouth.
 Before it becomes policy, watchfulness often begins as people’s experience.



Abhishek volunteered at a local bank-awareness camp.
 The first time he went up on the stage, his hands trembled.
 “I am not the police. I am not a bank officer. I am a man who made a mistake.”
 The room was silent.
 He said—
 “If someone tells you—give us your account, you have to do nothing, you will get money every month—ask questions. Ask for papers. Ask the bank. Quick money can very often become a slow punishment.”
 He explained nothing operational.
 Only the danger.
 Manjari sat at the back.
 Her brother was on the stage.
 The lost year had not vanished.
 But that loss was becoming a warning now.



After the restructuring of the Uttarayan Fund, Saurabh’s name was removed from the board of directors.
 The new chairperson said publicly—
 “An institution is larger than an individual.”
 Reading the news, Rachna thought—
 The same sentence had been used during the crime.
 “The system is larger than the individual.”
 The sentence itself was innocent.
 Context changed its meaning.

If an institution was larger than an individual, would the institution carry its old responsibilities too, or become pure merely by taking a new name?

Uttarayan's new board contributed money to an assistance fund for old victims.

Some of it was legally required.

Some voluntary.

Mrinalini too received a letter.

"Special compensation."

She read it.

The amount was not large.

Ishaan asked—

"Will you take it?"

Mrinalini said—

"In exchange for what?"

"The loss."

"Satyaprakash?"

Silence.

Then she said—

"If the law gives me a right to it, I will take it. It is not forgiveness. It is not a price. Only compensation."

Money does not decide moral meaning.

It merely lightens some practical burdens.



Mrinalini donated part of that amount to a book fund in Dhaneshwari's name at the village school.

Ishaan asked—

"Why not in Babu's name?"

"There will be many names."

"Dadi?"

"She taught us to keep watch."

The headmaster wanted to make a plaque.

Mrinalini refused.

"Buy books. Write the name inside them."

Inside the first book was a small stamp—

"Dhaneshwari Memorial Book Fund."

No photograph.

No speech.

No garland.

The quiet watch of knowledge.



A year later, a young woman from among Ishaan's trainees came to Garh Narikel.

Her name—Vaidehi Jha.

Her research topic—the social risk of financial crime.

She wanted to meet Mrinalini.

“An interview?”

Mrinalini asked.

“If you permit it.”

“What do you want to know?”

“The effect of a long investigation on a family.”

Mrinalini laughed.

“How many years do you have?”

Vaidehi fell silent.

Then both laughed.

Mrinalini said—

“One condition. Do not write me as a heroine.”

Ishaan laughed from the veranda.

“That condition applies to everyone.”

Vaidehi opened her notebook.

“Then the first question—the hardest day?”

Mrinalini answered—

“At what age?”

The researcher understood—tragedy was not a single day.

It was a long duration.



At dusk Vaidehi went to see the bank of the Kamla-Balan.

Ishaan went with her.

She saw the track of a monitor lizard in the mud.

“This could make a title.”

Ishaan smiled.

“Careful.”

“Why?”

“A metaphor is not evidence.”

Vaidehi laughed.

“You are very much a teacher.”

“A family disease.”

A mongoose emerged from the bushes.
 Vaidehi started to take out her phone.
 Ishaan said—
 “Leave it.”
 “No photograph?”
 “Not every sign needs to be preserved.”
 Vaidehi put the phone back.
 They kept watching.
 The mongoose went to the water’s edge.
 Sniffed at something.
 Then disappeared into the grass.
 A scene of a few moments.
 No record.
 Yet a memory.



That night Mrinalini opened the notebook.
 Dhaneshwari’s faded line.
 The line she herself had added.
 There was still a great deal of empty space.
 She picked up the pen.
 She wrote a third line—
 “The watch is not fear; it is awareness.”
 She let the ink dry.
 Closed the notebook.
 Ishaan asked—
 “Will you write more?”
 “When there is need.”
 “It will become a grammar.”
 “No. Household words.”
 Some philosophy is no greater than household words.



The next morning Mrinalini went alone to the river.
 Age had slowed her steps.
 She looked at the water from a distance.
 No monitor lizard was visible.
 No mongoose either.
 Only sunlight.
 A fisherman casting his net.

Two children going to school.
 A woman filling a water pot.
 Life went on even without symbols of crime.
 Mrinalini was glad of that.
 If every body of water becomes a monitor lizard, watchfulness becomes madness.
 If one never allows that there may be a monitor lizard, it becomes foolishness.
 Between them lies intelligence.
 She turned back toward home.
 Leaving her own footprints in the mud.
 This time not the mongoose's.
 A human being's.



With Aniruddh's old pen, Ishaan wrote the first line—
 "This is not the story of any single criminal."
 Then he stopped.
 Tore up the page.
 A second page—
 "On a rainy night in Garh Narikel, when a seven-year-old child lay asleep, a cobra entered the house."
 He stopped again.
 His mother's voice inside him—
 Write them as human beings.
 Dadi—
 The bank.
 Aniruddh—
 Direct perception apart, inference apart.
 Rachna—
 Leave the unproved unproved.
 Ishaan moved the pen again.
 Where a story begins is not a matter of evidence either.
 It is a literary decision.
 He kept writing.
 Outside, there were small mongoose footprints in the courtyard.
 The morning sunlight grew stronger.
 The prints slowly dried and hardened.
 After a while the wind would blow.
 The earth would become smooth again.

But what had been seen would remain inside someone.
That is how the watch changes generations.



The pages Ishaan had written slowly began to grow.
He did not write every day.
Some days he only read old files.
Some days he sat with his mother and asked questions.
Some days he wrote one line and crossed it out.
The first difficulty was not the event.
It was the voice.
If he kept too much of the police language—the human beings vanished.
If he kept too much grief—the limits of evidence broke.
If there was too much philosophy—the story grew heavy.
If there was too much crime—the victims receded.
At the top of a page he wrote—
“A story is not a court; but neither is it the opposite of a court.”
Then he turned the page.



One evening Vaidehi Jha came again to Garh Narikel.
Her research had moved forward.
This time she had no questionnaire with her notebook, only two questions.
“Does a long investigation change a family’s memory?”
Mrinalini said—
“Yes.”
“How?”
“Something that was clear in memory at first is later confirmed by papers.
Then one day you no longer know—did I already know it, or did I learn it
after reading the paper?”
Vaidehi fell silent.
“Then what should I do in the interview?”
“Whatever is not certain, write—not certain.”
“Only that?”
“Only that is difficult.”
The second question—
“Did you get justice?”
Mrinalini laughed.
“You researchers are very fond of this question?”

Vaidehi laughed too.

“Yes.”

“Then write this answer—justice is not one object that you receive in your hand and bring home. Some decisions, some truth, some compensation, some memory. The rest is grief.”

Vaidehi took notes after a long while.

This time the words came slowly.



Rachna Sinha’s fraud network in the new district turned out to be smaller than expected.

Five accounts.

Two accused.

One employee.

No interstate “kingpin.”

Some in the media were disappointed.

A television representative said—

“That’s all?”

Rachna replied—

“If the crime is small, I ought to be pleased.”

The journalist laughed.

“Then the news is small.”

“Should we pray for the crime to grow?”

The journalist fell silent.

Rachna regretted the sarcasm at once—again.

But the question inside it was right.

The public story of a criminal investigation often looks for a grand villain.

In real life, most harm is made from small people, small amounts, small lies.

Conjunction again.



A new example entered Ishaan’s training.

An elderly teacher’s pension account was suddenly frozen because his number appeared linked to a suspicious digital transaction.

The investigation found—

An old mobile number had been incorrectly updated at the bank branch.

The elderly man had committed no crime.

No account recruitment.

No commission.

Only a data error.

A student asked—

“Sir, then is the machine guilty?”

Ishaan smiled.

“A machine is a tool of decision. Human beings create data. Human beings make rules. Human beings investigate.”

“Then whose mistake is it?”

“Sometimes one person’s. Sometimes the system’s.”

“Punishment?”

“Not every mistake is a crime.”

The sentence was simple.

But necessary in the digital age.

Error, negligence, deception, crime—the four are not the same.

Justice needs distinctions.



Mrinalini went to the school to see the books in the Dhaneshwari Memorial Book Fund.

Children were turning through the books.

No one was reading the name.

No one was looking at the stamp.

She was pleased.

If the donor’s name becomes larger than the book, the purpose changes.

A child running with a science book stumbled.

Mrinalini helped the child up.

The book had fallen open to a page—

“The balance of predator and prey in the living world.”

She laughed.

The child asked—

“What happened?”

“Nothing.”

She gave the book back.

Mongoose, snake, monitor lizard—in nature none of them is a moral character.

Human beings make stories.

She understood that clearly now.

Yet a story can still be useful.

If the metaphor is not mistaken for fact.



Pradeep's financial-literacy classes slowly became well known.

Because he did not lecture.

He would say—

“Do not sign what you do not understand.”

“If a paper does not state the real service, do not make it seem small by calling it an ‘adjustment.’”

“If money that is not yours merely passes through your account, ask what it means.”

A young man asked—

“Where did you learn all this?”

Pradeep paused.

“By doing wrong.”

There was no laughter in the room.

He continued—

“There is no pride in that. But if you learn the right thing after a mistake, hiding it becomes a second mistake.”

Trisha sat quietly on the back bench.

For the first time she saw her father speak publicly without hiding the crime.

Trust did not return all at once.

But one brick was laid.



Manoj Nayak's appeal was partly successful.

One charge imposing higher-level direct responsibility for the assault was reduced.

The principal convictions concerning mule recruitment and pressure remained.

Hearing the news, his father said—

“See? My son is innocent.”

The lawyer corrected him at once—

“Not entirely.”

The father was irritated.

“Was the conviction reduced or not?”

“It was.”

“Then he is innocent.”

The lawyer said nothing.

The human mind likes binaries.

Guilty.

Innocent.

But the law often says—
On this charge, yes.
On this one, no.
Up to this limit.
Not beyond it.
Complexity is not a weakness of justice.
It may be its honesty.



One day Ritesh ran into Manoj's father in the market.

The old man spat as soon as he saw him—
“Traitor.”
Ritesh was silent.
He could have protested—
“He had me beaten.”
“He pushed me into crime.”
But before him stood an old father, not a court.
Ritesh said only—
“I did wrong.”
Some of the old man's anger paused.
“My son?”
“The court has spoken about him.”
“And you?”
“I accept my share.”
The old man could say nothing more.
Ritesh walked away.
An admission does not always quiet an opponent.
But it can change the voice of the quarrel.



Saurabh Bardhan asked for the old Uttarayan records as he prepared for a higher appeal.

His lawyer said—
“We will argue that ‘old source’ meant investment history, not illicit money.”
Saurabh kept reading the file.
On one page was Satyaprakash's name.
He stared at it for a long time.
The lawyer asked—
“Something?”

Saurabh said quietly—

“This man died then?”

“Yes.”

“I was a student at the time.”

“That is why there is no allegation against you in connection with the killing.”

“I know.”

“Then?”

Saurabh closed the page.

“Later, I wanted his objection hidden.”

The lawyer grew cautious—

“Do not use the word ‘hidden.’”

Saurabh looked at him.

“I am not saying it for the court.”

“Even so.”

“That is the problem.”

“What?”

“We kept polishing words so carefully that one day I could no longer understand what I myself had done.”

The lawyer did not answer.

Law demands language.

The defence chooses language.

But a human being's self-recognition is sometimes clearer in clumsy words.



Ishaan wrote “Saurabh” on a page of the manuscript, then crossed it out.

Mrinalini asked—

“Why?”

“Too many people are still alive. Cases, appeals.”

“Then?”

“The story will be wholly fictional.”

“Your father?”

“Him too.”

Mrinalini was surprised.

“You will change the names?”

“In the story, yes.”

“Why?”

“So that the event is not copied, but its meaning remains.”

Mrinalini thought for a long time.

“Then what about truth?”

“The author’s note will make it clear—the story is fiction.”

“And what I said?”

“Its form will change.”

“All right.”

She laughed.

“I am not the heroine.”

Ishaan laughed too.

“I remember.”

Literature was now creating distance from the actual case file.

That distance was not forgetting.

Protection.

Composition.

Freedom.



One chapter of Vaidehi’s dissertation dealt with “Prolonged Judicial Uncertainty.”

She wanted to use one sentence from her interview with Mrinalini—

“Grief is not satisfied.”

She asked permission.

Mrinalini said—

“Without my name.”

“Why?”

“The sentence is larger than I am.”

Vaidehi smiled.

“All right.”

The sentence entered the academic paper—

An unnamed widow says, “Grief is not satisfied.”

A reference in the footnote.

No photograph.

No sensation.

Grief became a line of knowledge.

Not its full weight.

Paper can never carry the whole weight.



On leave, Rachna Sinha came not to Garh Narikel but to the capital city.

She met Ishaan at a tea shop.

“Writing?” Rachna asked.

“A little.”

“Will you make me a character?”

“No.”

“Thank you.”

Ishaan laughed.

“The whole story will be fictional.”

“Even better.”

“But the method—”

Rachna set down her cup.

“Method belongs to no one privately.”

“Direct perception, inference...”

“Ancient.”

“Conjunction?”

“Philosophical.”

“Leave the unproved unproved?”

Rachna smiled.

“I like that.”

“Then I will use it.”

“Use it.”

Some ideas are a shared inheritance.

Copyright may attach to a person’s language.

Not to the common discipline of testing truth.

Ishaan understood the importance of that distinction.



A new family of mongooses had settled in the courtyard.

Sometimes one.

Sometimes two.

Once, three small young ones.

Mrinalini watched from a distance.

She did not feed them.

She made no attempt to tame them.

“Do not make the guardian dependent,” she said.

Ishaan laughed—

“Philosophy?”

“Household talk.”

The little mongooses played.

Catching one another by the tail.

No snake.

No monitor lizard.

Only life.

This could make a useful scene for the story, Ishaan thought.

Then he stopped himself.

Not every beautiful thing belongs in a story.

Some things are only to be seen.



One day, on the bank of the Kamla-Balan, an actual monitor lizard lay basking in the sun.

The village children ran toward it.

One of them picked up a stone.

Ishaan shouted—

“Stay back!”

A child asked—

“Kill it?”

“Why?”

“The monitor lizard is bad.”

Ishaan froze.

The metaphor had revealed its danger.

“A monitor lizard is an animal. It is not bad.”

“Then the story?”

“In the story it is a sign.”

“The snake?”

“An animal too.”

“The mongoose?”

“That too.”

The child looked disappointed.

“Then who is bad?”

Ishaan laughed.

“Wrong actions.”

The child was perhaps not satisfied.

The monitor lizard slid toward the water.

No one threw a stone.

Ishaan watched the scene for a long time.

If a metaphor turned an animal into a criminal, the story had failed.

That night he added a line to his manuscript—

“The monitor lizard was not guilty; it was only a metaphor for danger submerged in the human mind.”

Then he paused.

Too explicit?

Perhaps.
But necessary.



Mrinalini read the line.

“Good.”

“Has it made the literature weaker?”

“What use is literature if children start killing monitor lizards?”

Ishaan laughed.

“All right.”

He kept the line.

The story was learning that metaphor too has limits.



Time moved farther on.

The Dhaneshwari Memorial Book Fund acquired more books.

Manjari found work at a hospital.

Abhishek's bank record returned to normal.

Sabina bought a new sewing machine.

Shailesh's home was not fully repaired, but conversation continued.

Ritesh's shop survived.

Pradeep taught training sessions.

Trisha studied law.

Vihan struggled with the smaller, altered form of Ambar.

Keshav served his sentence.

Saurabh pursued his appeal.

Rachna opened new files.

Ishaan wrote.

Mrinalini lived.

No one was completely free.

No one was only a criminal.

No one was only a victim.

Human beings changed roles.

Responsibility did not disappear.



One night Mrinalini called Ishaan.

“Bring the notebook.”

Dhaneshwari's notebook.

Three lines—

“Do not leave the house for fear of a snake; but do not decide there is a snake in the house until you have seen it.”

“And if you do see it, keep watch not with fear, but with intelligence.”

“Watchfulness is not fear; it is awareness.”

Mrinalini wrote a fourth line—

“Before you call someone guilty, look at the act, not the name.”

Ishaan read it.

“That sounds like a court.”

“Household talk.”

They both laughed.

Mrinalini handed him the pen.

“Now you write.”

Ishaan looked at the blank line.

For a long time.

Then he wrote—

“Saying ‘I do not know’ about what we do not know is also a form of keeping watch.”

Mrinalini read it.

She nodded.

The notebook closed.

Five lines.

No scripture.

Yet the substance of an entire life.



Mist lay over the Kamla-Balan at dawn.

A mongoose stood on the bank.

Far away, a monitor lizard waited in the water for sunlight.

There might have been a snake's trail in the grass.

The human village was waking.

Hearth.

School.

Bank.

Court.

Mobile phone.

Tender.

Train.

Sewing machine.

Hospital.

Prison.

Book.

The whole world at once.

Ishaan closed the manuscript on the veranda.

It was not finished yet.

But for the first time he understood—

However long the story became, in the end the question would remain the same—

Was anyone awake?

And did the waking person look with fear, or with intelligence?

There were mongoose tracks in the earth at the threshold.

He did not photograph them.

He only looked.

Remembered.

Then went inside and began to write.



Ishaan's manuscript no longer remained inside a confidential folder.

He gave a few extracts to Sumedha Ghosh to read.

With one condition—

“Look at the language. Do not fix the story.”

Sumedha laughed.

“Once an analyst becomes a writer, he learns to give orders.”

Two days later the file came back.

One comment in the margin—

“Here you have written, ‘we all know.’ No one knows ‘all.’”

Ishaan read the line and smiled.

Then deleted it.

A second comment—

“How does the author know what this character is thinking?”

Ishaan paused again.

Literary freedom could have rescued him here.

But he had made a rule for himself—

Where he wrote an inner mind, the character must be wholly fictional.

Where a real experience cast its shadow, the limit of inference must be clear.

He wrote—

“A story can be answerable to truth without becoming a document.”

Sumedha replied—

“Now speak like a writer, not like a notice.”



At law college, Trisha gave a presentation—

“Moral Responsibility and Legal Guilt in Financial Crime.”

She did not say a single word about her father.

When the presentation ended, a student asked—

“If someone becomes part of a crime while following orders, who is guilty—the owner or the employee?”

Trisha answered—

“Both can be. To different degrees.”

“The employee’s fear?”

“Circumstance.”

“Fear of losing the job?”

“Circumstance.”

“Then innocent?”

“Not necessarily.”

“And the owner?”

“Not automatically wholly guilty either.”

The student laughed—

“Does law give any simple answer?”

Trisha smiled.

“If you want simple answers, read slogans.”

The class burst into laughter.

Her teacher called from the back—

“Do not write that in the exam.”

Everyone laughed again.

When Trisha came home, Pradeep asked—

“The presentation?”

“Fine.”

“Did I come into it?”

“No.”

Pradeep breathed in relief.

Trisha added—

“But because of you, I understood the question.”

Pradeep did not answer.

Some influences change a generation without being named.



Rachna Sinha’s new case closed before it ever reached court.

The reason—

The principal complainant had himself made a mistaken identification.

The bank's internal inquiry found that the record had been matched with another account belonging to a person with a similar name.

The young officer was disappointed.

"Three weeks of work wasted."

Rachna said—

"No."

"Nothing came out of it."

"A case was not built against the wrong man."

"That alone is an achievement?"

"Sometimes the greatest one."

The young officer fell silent.

On the final page of the file Rachna wrote—

"No criminal basis found; record error."

No medal.

No news story.

One innocent man's name out of the file.

Justice is sometimes a negative achievement—

An injustice that did not happen.



The Dhaneshwari Memorial Book Fund completed its first year in Garh Narikel.

The school principal wanted a small ceremony.

Mrinalini refused again.

"Let the children read the books. That is enough."

"At least a photograph?"

"Of the books."

"Of you?"

"No."

Ishaan laughed.

The principal gave up.

That afternoon the children were making a list of the books.

One child asked—

"Who was Dhaneshwari?"

The teacher said—

"An old woman of the village."

"A writer?"

"No."

"A teacher?"

"No."

“Then why is her name here?”

Mrinalini heard from a distance.

The teacher was searching for an answer.

She stepped forward.

“Because she wanted children to learn.”

The child was satisfied.

“That’s all?”

“That’s all.”

The worth of many lives does not fit inside a professional description.



Vihan Sarang invited Ishaan to a public seminar at Ambar’s new office.

The subject—

“Digital Entertainment, User Safety and Financial Responsibility.”

Ishaan thought for a long time.

He went to his mother.

“Go,” Mrinalini said.

“Ambar.”

“And now?”

“It has changed, but the name is the same.”

“You are not its employee.”

“No.”

“Then ask questions.”

Ishaan went.

On stage Vihan said publicly—

“I used to treat growth as success. Now I understand—growth that breaks the user is only a number.”

A listener asked—

“You understood all this only after the court case?”

Vihan did not defend himself—

“There were things I could have understood earlier. I did not.”

Ishaan watched him.

That sentence was not proof of reform.

But neither was it an excuse.

Admitting one’s delay is not a small thing.



Ishaan named no criminal in his presentation.

He drew only four circles—

Entertainment.

Addiction.

Debt.

Recruitment.

Then a fifth—

Financial abuse.

“Not every user enters these circles,” he said. “Not every game is a crime. Not every loss is addiction. But when the boundaries blur, the company’s responsibility increases.”

A young entrepreneur asked—

“Is the user not responsible too?”

“Yes.”

“Then why the company?”

“Both can be.”

Again the same answer.

Responsibility can be divided.

One person’s mistake does not erase another person’s responsibility.



After the seminar Vihan spoke to Ishaan alone.

“I read your father’s old email again.”

Ishaan was silent.

“He insisted on ‘service verification.’”

“Yes.”

“I was young then. I was frightened.”

“I know.”

“For years I protected myself with the thought—I was junior.”

Ishaan looked at him.

“Being junior can reduce responsibility. It does not make it zero.”

Vihan smiled faintly.

“You speak like your mother.”

“An illness of the household.”

They were silent for a few moments.

Vihan said—

“I am thinking of making a small room in Ambar’s old building—internal records, wrong decisions, warnings, reforms.”

“A memorial?”

“No. Training.”

Ishaan answered at once—

“Do not turn the dead person’s name into decoration.”

“No.”

“Keep the full context of the old mistakes.”

“Yes.”

“Then do it.”

If memory becomes decoration for an institution, that is memory-laundering again.

If it remains an uncomfortable question, it is a form of watchfulness.



Saurabh's higher appeal was partly allowed.

One technical part of the conviction was removed.

The principal finding concerning financial assistance remained.

The remaining term of sentence was reduced.

The news said—

“Major relief for Saurabh.”

The actual order said—

“Limited relief.”

Mrinalini smiled as she read the newspaper.

Ishaan asked—

“What?”

“I no longer think I understand a judgment from its headline.”

“Progress.”

“Exhaustion.”

They both laughed.



Keshav began writing regularly in the prison library.

Not a diary.

No victims' names.

Only questions.

“After how many warnings does ignorance cease to be an excuse?”

“Do corporate targets alter an employee's morality?”

“If everyone profits, whose responsibility is it?”

“If the papers are clean, is the money clean?”

One day the prison teacher said—

“This could become an essay.”

Keshav laughed.

“I am not a writer.”

“Then?”

“Someone who began asking questions too late.”

The teacher said—

“A question asked late is still a question.”

Keshav closed the page.

His punishment did not repair society’s loss.

But if prison meant only passing time, the state too would have failed.



A teenager came into Ritesh’s shop.

Phone repair.

He wanted to make a digital transfer for payment.

The network was down.

The boy said—

“Brother, give me your account. Money will come from my friend, then give me cash.”

Ritesh went completely still.

An old sentence.

A new face.

“No.”

“Why? It’s a small amount.”

“Your money, your account.”

“Brother, I’m in a great hurry.”

“Then go to the bank.”

The boy left irritated.

Ritesh’s hands were trembling.

He called Abhishek.

“Something happened today.”

He told him everything.

Abhishek was silent.

Then said—

“You did right.”

That was all.

Ritesh put down the phone.

The proof of reform is sometimes not a court order, but a small refusal.



Financial Awareness Week was held at Shailesh’s school.

The principal did not want him speaking on the stage.

The old case.

“Effect on the children.”

Shailesh himself said—

“All right.”

He sat at the back.

The main speaker gave the usual cautions.

After the programme two senior students came to Shailesh.

“Sir, people say about you...”

Shailesh did not stop them.

“Yes, I was caught in online gambling.”

Both were startled.

“Really?”

“Yes.”

“And then your job?”

“Returned with conditions.”

“Sir, how much did you lose?”

Shailesh did not give an amount.

“More trust than money.”

“Will you play again?”

“The urge sometimes rises.”

“Then?”

“I tell someone. Keep the phone away. Go to the group meeting.”

For the first time the students heard addiction described not as ‘weak character’ but as something requiring continuous vigilance.

The watch within.



At the hospital Manjari heard that a patient’s family bank account had been frozen because of a fraud inquiry.

Her old pain could have made her react at once.

Instead she told the hospital social worker—

“I do not know the bank’s decision. Ask only whether this family’s legitimate medical money can be verified separately.”

The difference was small.

Before—

“Unfreeze the account.”

Now—

“Check the facts.”

Pain had made her cautious rather than impulsive.



Before Ishaan’s manuscript reached fifty thousand words, he stopped.

He read a few pages to Mrinalini.

Halfway through she said—

“Make this character cry less.”

“Why?”

“Not every grief is tears.”

Ishaan picked up his pen.

“And here?”

“Here the man has become too good.”

“Which man?”

“The one who admits his mistake.”

“Then?”

“An admission does not change a habit at once.”

Ishaan made another note.

“Mother, you are the editor.”

“No. I have watched life.”

When the story leaned toward sweetness, Mrinalini cut it back.

When it leaned toward melodrama, she stopped it.

She wanted—

Grief to remain grief.

A human being to remain human.



One night Mrinalini woke from sleep.

A dog was barking outside.

Old fear returned for an instant—

Someone there?

A snake?

A thief?

A reporter?

Twenty years of memory lived in the body.

She did not open the door at once.

She looked through the window.

Nothing.

The dog was barking at some sound from another part of the village.

She went back to bed.

Said softly to herself—

“Not every sound is danger.”

Dhaneshwari’s line.

Watchfulness is not fear.

Awareness.

She went back to sleep.

That small night would never be entered in any case file.

Yet perhaps it was one of the story's important victories.
The empire of fear had grown a little smaller.



At dawn Ishaan opened the notebook.

Five lines.

A blank sixth.

He knew nothing of his mother's night.

He wrote a line of his own—

“Even after keeping watch, one must still live.”

Mrinalini read it.

She was silent for a long time.

Then said—

“That will do.”

Six lines.

The household philosophy of justice was not complete.

Perhaps it never would be.

Completeness too is sometimes a deception.

Life would bring a new situation.

A new line would be needed.



The water of the Kamla-Balan was low that year.

A monitor lizard basked far away on the sand.

A mongoose stood on a field ridge.

Neither was near the other.

A storyteller could have made them confront each other.

Life had no need to.

Ishaan watched from a distance.

He did not open his notebook.

He simply stood there.

Some scenes should be allowed to remain ordinary before they are made
into symbols.

Mrinalini came up behind him and said—

“Come. The food will get cold.”

Ishaan turned.

The river behind him.

The house ahead.

The watch in between.

Life too.



Ishaan's writing slowly became an ordinary thing in the house.

Mrinalini no longer asked for pages to read.

She only sometimes asked—

“Did you write today?”

“Yes.”

“How much?”

“Three pages.”

“Good?”

“I don't know.”

“Then read them tomorrow.”

Ishaan could not tell whether the advice was for a writer or for life.

Without setting out any theory, many of Mrinalini's words had become principles.



One day Ishaan received a call from the bankers' association.

A new pile of complaints.

This time the problem was not like the old recruitment of mule accounts.

People heard what seemed to be the voice of a family member over the phone.

An emergency.

Money needed immediately.

A few minutes later they discovered—the voice had not been real.

Ishaan's first question was—

“How many cases are confirmed?”

The answer—

“Very few so far. More rumours than cases.”

“Then separate them first—confirmed, suspected, unverified.”

The officer at the other end fell silent.

“We need immediate advice.”

“Immediate advice—the voice alone is not proof. Verify the familiar number, use another family channel, confirm through the bank.”

“The criminal method?”

“The police will deal with that. I am looking at victim protection.”

New technology.

Old rules.

What seems like direct perception is not always direct perception.

A voice too can be artificial.

A new crisis for Testimony.



Rachna Sinha encountered a similar case.

An elderly woman said—

“I heard my son’s voice.”

“Where was your son?”

“Abroad.”

“The call?”

“From a new number.”

“What did he say?”

“There had been an accident. He needed money.”

“You sent it?”

“Yes.”

“Then?”

“Two hours later my son called. Nothing had happened.”

Rachna looked at the woman’s face.

Before looking for the criminal, she saw the shame.

“I am a fool,” the woman said.

“No.”

Rachna stopped the word at once.

She did not want consolation, but fact.

“You trusted a familiar voice. That trust was exploited.”

“I should have known.”

“Next time, verify.”

The woman lowered her eyes.

“The money?”

“The investigation will continue. I cannot say yet whether it will come back.”

Again, the same rule.

No false hope.

Truth in the midst of pain.



Ishaan built a training module around the new risk.

The title was simple—

“Listen to the Voice, but Verify.”

He did not teach how the technical imitation was created.

He taught only the structure of trust.

Family.

Emergency.

Time pressure.

Fear.

Secrecy.

“Criminals change technology,” he said, “but human moments of weakness are very old.”

A student asked—

“Sir, then in the future should we trust no one’s voice?”

Ishaan paused.

“If distrust itself were the solution, society could not function.”

“Then?”

“Keep the trust. Add verification.”

That was the watch.

Not fear.

Awareness.



Mrinalini laughed when she heard about the training.

“Now voices are snakes too?”

“Mother!”

“You turn everything into a metaphor.”

Ishaan smiled.

“No. Not this time.”

“Good.”

Then Mrinalini grew serious—

“If criminals destroy trust, they win.”

Ishaan fell silent.

He wrote the sentence down.

“Mother, I am going to use this.”

“No name.”

“All right.”

“And do not make me a scholar.”

“All right.”

They both laughed.



In her law studies, Trisha wrote an article—

“New Forms of Evidence and Old Caution.”

She did not show the draft to her father.

After publication, she gave him a copy.

Pradeep read the title and said—

“Very heavy.”

“Read it.”

One sentence in the article said—

“As technical reliability increases, judicial caution should not diminish; it should increase.”

Pradeep placed a finger on the line.

“This is right.”

“Why?”

“Earlier, paper looked clean and people believed it. Now voices will sound clean, videos will look clean.”

“Then?”

“A clear appearance is not the same as truth.”

Trisha looked at her father.

“You have not stopped reading accounts.”

Pradeep smiled faintly.

“I stopped reading false accounts.”

Conversation at home could now withstand discussion of the crime.

The wound was becoming a scar.

Not disappearing.



One day a customer said in Sabina Khatoon’s shop—

“Sister, a friend of my sister wants to receive money through my account. Just for two days.”

Sabina stopped the machine.

“Why?”

“Her limit...”

“Go to the bank.”

“It is a small thing.”

Sabina remembered her own five thousand.

“It had seemed small to me too.”

The customer laughed.

“You are afraid.”

“Yes.”

Sabina said without shame—

“Fear is right in this matter.”

Then she corrected herself—

“Not fear—caution.”

She had never read Dhaneshwari’s notebook.

Yet society’s experience was producing the same sentence in different homes.



At Shailesh's school, a student was caught secretly playing a gambling-like game.

The headmaster confiscated his phone and called his parents.

Shailesh was not in that meeting.

Later, the headmaster himself called him for advice.

"You have experience..."

The sentence remained unfinished.

Earlier, the same experience had kept him off the stage.

Now it was being called upon for help.

In private, Shailesh asked the student only—

"How long?"

"A little while."

"Money?"

"Not much."

"Have you lied at home?"

The student was silent.

"Start there. The amount comes later."

"Sir, the police?"

"For now, the school and the family. If there is financial crime, then according to the rules."

"Am I bad?"

After a long time, Shailesh said—

"An act can be bad. You are not the whole of one act."

As he said it, he himself felt like crying.

What if someone had told him this earlier?

Perhaps something would have changed.

Perhaps not.

History is full of "perhaps."

In the present, action is possible.



Ritesh's shop had begun to provide a steady income.

He hired an assistant—an eighteen-year-old boy named Monu.

On the first day, Ritesh stated one rule about bank payments—

"The shop's money goes to the shop's account. A customer's private money does not come into my account."

Monu laughed.

"Such a small rule?"

"The most important one."

“Why?”

Ritesh replied—

“I learned it at great cost.”

Monu asked no more.

Some lessons can be given without a complete autobiography.



Vihan Sarang prepared Ambar’s training room.

There were no awards for success on the wall.

Four failed decisions.

“We treated warnings as resistance to growth.”

“We left the role of outside partners unclear.”

“We did not recognise user harm early enough.”

“We did not ask enough questions about the meaning of financial separation.”

One corner remained empty.

The heading—

“What We Do Not Yet See.”

Ishaan went to see the room.

He stopped at the empty corner.

“This is good.”

Vihan said—

“The hardest part.”

“Why?”

“Management does not like empty spaces.”

Ishaan smiled.

“Neither does investigation.”

They both laughed.

Perhaps that empty wall was the institutional form of leaving the unproved unproved.



Saurabh Bardhan completed the remaining term of his sentence and came out.

There were fewer cameras.

The news had lost interest.

He went straight home.

For several weeks, he said nothing publicly.

Then Uttarayan’s new board invited him to a public dialogue—

“Learning from Past Governance Failures.”

Several members objected.

“A convicted former officer on the stage?”

In the end, the programme was held without publicity and before a limited audience.

Saurabh said—

“I have not come to this platform to prove that I am reformed. I want to say only one thing—corporate language can distance a human being from responsibility.”

Someone asked—

“An example?”

“When we said ‘keep the risk separate,’ sometimes what it really meant was—keep an uncomfortable fact out of sight.”

“An admission of crime?”

Saurabh paused.

“What the court proved is in the order. I am speaking now in moral language.”

The distinction was clear.

This was not a forum for changing the legal judgment.

Self-recognition had a different language.



Mrinalini was growing old.

She took the stairs slowly now.

Her knees hurt.

Ishaan began spending less time in Capital City and more in the village.

One evening, while giving her medicine, he said—

“Mother, come to the city. The hospital is nearby.”

“Not yet.”

“Why?”

“Home.”

“Home is not a hospital.”

“I am not a patient yet.”

Ishaan fell silent.

Mrinalini smiled.

“Why do you ask everything like an investigator’s question?”

“Habit.”

“A bad one.”

“Rachna Madam would say—”

“I am not Rachna Madam.”

They both laughed.

Before age becomes tragedy, it is also ordinary irritation.
Life is true in such places too.



Dhaneshwari's notebook no longer stayed on top of the cupboard; it now lay beside Mrinalini's pillow.

One night she said to Ishaan—

“Write a seventh line.”

“What?”

“You think.”

Ishaan opened the notebook.

Six lines.

Fear of the snake.

Keeping watch with intelligence.

Watchfulness as awareness.

The act, not the name.

Leave the unproved unproved.

Life after keeping watch.

He thought for a long time.

Then he wrote—

“Do not abandon trust; give trust eyes.”

Mrinalini read it.

“This is good.”

“From the voice case.”

“It applies at home too.”

“Mother!”

“What?”

She laughed.

The notebook closed.

Seven lines.

Not a university curriculum.

But wisdom that had remained on the walls of a household from one generation to the next.



One day Vaidehi Jha brought the final copy of her dissertation.

She thanked Mrinalini.

“Where is your name?”

“In the acknowledgments—if you permit it.”

Mrinalini thought.

“Only the name. Not the story.”

“All right.”

Ishaan asked—

“The title?”

Vaidehi said—

“Long Justice, Social Memory and Economic Crime.”

Mrinalini asked—

“No mongoose?”

Everyone laughed.

Vaidehi said—

“That would not be research. Perhaps literature.”

Ishaan looked at his mother.

Mrinalini winked.



Rachna Sinha was preparing a training manual.

Its title—

“Evidence Discipline in Preliminary Digital Financial Investigation.”

Five sentences appeared on the first page—

“Unusual conduct is not synonymous with crime.”

“Do not assume that the account holder and the actual controller are the same person.”

“The authenticity of technical material and its meaning are separate questions.”

“Do not try to make a witness remember what the witness cannot remember.”

“Eliminating a wrong hypothesis is also progress.”

Rohit read the copy and called her—

“Madam, there is no name of philosophy here.”

“Is it needed?”

“No.”

“Then.”

Knowledge often remains alive in practice without the name of its source.

But forgetting the source altogether is not right either.

Rachna added a short reference list on the final page—

Indian thought on evidence.

Logic.

Nyāya philosophy’s discourse on means of knowledge.

Modern digital forensic methodology.

Old and new.

Side by side.



Ishaan's manuscript was now taking the shape of a full novel.

He kept stopping as he tried to write the final part.

"Where is the ending?"

Mrinalini asked.

"I do not know."

"When everyone dies?"

"Mother!"

"People do that in novels."

"I will not."

"Then a wedding?"

"Mother!"

She laughed loudly.

That much, after many days.

Then she coughed.

Ishaan gave her water.

Catching her breath, Mrinalini said—

"End it like life. Some things complete, some things left over."

Ishaan was silent.

Perhaps that was the novel's final rule.

But the story was not over yet.



Evening was descending over the Kamla-Balan.

The new young mongooses were growing bigger now.

One crossed the field ridge.

One disappeared into a bush.

One went farther away.

The monitor lizard was on the other side of the water.

There was no need for a confrontation.

Ishaan walked slowly with his mother.

Mrinalini leaned on a walking stick.

"Tired?"

"A little."

"Shall we turn back?"

"A little farther."

They went a little farther.

Then stopped.

They looked at the river.
 Neither spoke.
 Some truths can remain in silence too.
 If the silence is not born of fear, but of letting go of the demand for completeness.
 Then Mrinalini said—
 “Come.”
 They turned toward home.
 Water behind them.
 Footprints along the bank.
 A faint glow of a lamp ahead.
 The watch continued.



Mrinalini's knee pain was no longer confined to her knees.
 The fatigue deepened.
 She ate less.
 Sometimes she became short of breath.
 Ishaan took her to a hospital in the city.
 Tests.
 Blood.
 Heart.
 Lungs.
 Age.
 No single dramatic disease.
 Several small weaknesses.
 The doctor said—
 “She needs care. Regular medication. Protection from infection. Her condition could worsen suddenly.”
 Mrinalini asked directly—
 “Can I go home?”
 “Yes.”
 “Then.”
 Ishaan interrupted—
 “A few days in the city—”
 “Home.”
 The doctor looked at Ishaan.
 “If care can be arranged at home, she may stay there.”
 Mrinalini smiled.
 It was a small decision.

But now the most important right in her life was—
Where she would live.



Back in Garh Narikel, she placed Dhaneshwari's notebook beside her pillow.

Seven lines.

Ishaan wrote down the medicine schedule.

Morning.

Afternoon.

Night.

Mrinalini asked—

“Is this evidence too?”

“No. A reminder.”

“All right.”

They tried to make the days ordinary.

The veranda.

Sunlight.

Books.

Sometimes a neighbour.

Sometimes Vaidehi.

Sometimes a call from Trisha.

Sometimes a short message from Rachna Sinha—

“How are you?”

Mrinalini said over the phone—

“An investigating officer's question is very short.”

Rachna laughed.

“The answer?”

“Going on.”

“That is enough.”

In the last years of life, “going on” can be a large answer.



Ishaan slowed his writing.

He wrote while his mother slept.

When she was awake, he sat with her.

One day Mrinalini said—

“You have to write.”

“Later.”

“How much later?”

Ishaan was silent.

"I am here now. Write in this time. Later, memory will change."

Ishaan's eyes filled.

"Mother..."

"Do not cry. It is bad for the writer."

They both laughed.

Mrinalini said again—

"Do not hurry to write my death."

Ishaan went still.

"Why are you saying that?"

"Because writers look for an ending."

"I am your son."

"Both."

Mrinalini closed her eyes.

"Be the son first."



One evening she opened the notebook and asked him to write an eighth line.

Ishaan held the pen.

"What?"

Mrinalini looked out of the window.

No mongoose.

No monitor lizard.

Only dusk.

"Who is the watch for?"

"The house?"

"Human beings?"

"Truth?"

"All of them?"

She laughed.

"All right. Write."

Ishaan looked at the empty line for a long time.

Then he wrote—

"Let the watch not consume the freedom of those it seeks to protect."

Mrinalini read it.

She nodded slowly.

"This is necessary."

Ishaan understood—his mother had remembered his insistence that she live in the city near a hospital.

Protection too can become confinement.

There is a boundary between protection and autonomy.

Justice is not only a question of crime.
It is also a question of love.



In the middle of a training session, Rachna Sinha heard about a case—

A family would not allow their elderly father to leave the house because they feared online fraud.

No phone.

No bank card.

No freedom.

“Safety,” the family said.

The old man said—

“Prison.”

Rachna knew nothing of Ishaan’s new line.

Yet in the meeting she said—

“Risk control does not mean ending a person’s life.”

New crime gives birth to new forms of overprotection.

Another face of fear.

If criminals frighten people so much that they abandon trust, freedom and the act of going out into the world, the effect of crime is greater than money.



Trisha came to Garh Narikel during a holiday.

Not with Pradeep.

Alone.

The moment Mrinalini saw her, she said—

“The law woman.”

Trisha laughed.

“Still a student.”

“Does studying law make people more certain or less?”

Trisha thought.

“Less.”

“Good.”

They both laughed.

Trisha saw the notebook.

Eight lines.

“These should be published.”

Mrinalini immediately—

“No.”

“Why?”

“Household talk.”

Trisha said—

“Some household talk is useful to society.”

Mrinalini fell silent.

Ishaan listened from a distance.

After some time Mrinalini said—

“If they are printed, without a name.”

Trisha smiled.

“Uncle Ishaan, did you hear?”

“Yes.”

Mrinalini raised a finger—

“Not the whole book. The lines.”

It was the first time she had permitted the notebook to leave the house.

The watch of knowledge was beginning to be shared.



Ishaan made a small sheet containing the eight lines.

No title.

No author.

Only the lines.

Five copies in the school library.

One in the tailoring shop.

One in Ritesh's shop.

One in Shailesh's school.

One in Ambar's training room.

One in Rachna Sinha's office.

Pradeep put one on the wall in his class.

No one knew whose lines they were.

People read—

“Saying ‘I do not know’ about what we do not know is also a form of keeping watch.”

“Do not abandon trust; give trust eyes.”

“Even after keeping watch, one must still live.”

“Let the watch not consume the freedom of those it seeks to protect.”

Household talk became a small public declaration.

But without a name.

Mrinalini was pleased.

“This is right.”



A few weeks later, Mrinalini's breathing worsened again.

At night.

Ishaan called an ambulance.

She did not resist.

They reached the hospital.

Oxygen.

Medicine.

Two days of improvement.

On the third day the doctor said—

"She has an infection. At her age we need to be cautious."

Mrinalini was awake.

"Home?"

The doctor said—

"Not yet."

She closed her eyes.

Ishaan held her hand.

"A few days."

"All right."

This time safety was not confinement.

It was necessity.

Boundaries change with circumstances.



One night in the hospital Mrinalini asked Ishaan—

"Where is the manuscript?"

"On the laptop."

"The ending?"

"No."

"Good."

"Why?"

"Do not end the story after me."

Ishaan's chest tightened.

"Mother."

"Listen."

Between difficult breaths she said—

"If I go, the story will not end. Rachna will investigate. Trisha will study. Sabina will sew. Manjari will work in the hospital. The mongoose will do its work."

"Mother, not now—"

"I am not calling death. I am stating a rule."

Ishaan began to cry.

Mrinalini touched his forehead with a weak hand.

"Grief is not satisfied—do you remember?"

"Yes."

"Life is not satisfied either. It keeps moving."



On the fourth day her condition stabilized.

On the fifth, there was some improvement.

On the seventh day the doctor permitted her to return home—with oxygen arrangements, nursing care and an emergency plan.

When Mrinalini reached home, she paused at the threshold.

"The latch?"

Ishaan laughed.

"It is daytime."

"Still."

She went inside.

The bedside.

The notebook.

Satyaprakash's photograph.

Dhaneshwari's shawl.

The veranda outside.

A house does not welcome in the way a human being does.

It simply remains there.

Sometimes, remaining there is enough.



A week later Mrinalini was taking sunlight on the veranda.

A mongoose came.

One.

Medium-sized.

It stopped near the threshold.

Mrinalini said—

"After many days."

From behind her Ishaan said—

"Mother, it cannot be the same one."

"I know."

"Then why speak to it?"

"Who told you I think it is the same one?"

Ishaan laughed.

After a while the mongoose went away.
Mrinalini said—
“Individuals change. The watch remains.”
Ishaan took out his notebook.
Mrinalini immediately—
“Do not write everything.”
He closed the notebook.
“All right.”
One of the last rules—
Some part of life should remain protected from literature.



Rachna Sinha saw the anonymous sheet in her office.

Eight lines.

She stopped at the line, “To say that we do not know what we do not know is also a form of watchfulness.”

Rohit, who had come to meet her on work, asked—

“Whose?”

“No name is written.”

“Good.”

“Why?”

“Then people will read the lines, not the name.”

Rachna smiled.

“True.”

Then she read the eighth line—

“The watch must not devour the freedom of the one it seeks to protect.”

Rachna remained silent for a long time.

A line about police power.

About family as well.

About bank freezes as well.

About digital security as well.

About the state as well.

She thought of adding the sheet to the training manual.

Then stopped.

Permission?

Anonymous did not mean free of rights.

She called Ishaan.

“This sheet...”

“Yes.”

“May I use it?”

"I'll ask Mother."

Mrinalini gave permission—

"Do not change the lines."

"Name?"

"No."

Respect for anonymous authorship.

The watch extended to language as well.



One night Ishaan reread the final third of the manuscript.

He saw that the story had already said "watch" too many times.

He cut some of it.

Repeated often enough, a symbol turns into a slogan.

He reduced the mongoose.

Reduced the monitor lizard.

Where characters themselves were not speaking them, he removed the vocabulary of Nyāya philosophy.

To let the action survive.

To lighten the language.

Mrinalini had been right—

"Do not write everything."

Literary restraint too was a kind of evidentiary discipline.

Cut what was not necessary.

Remove what merely repeated an already-made meaning.

Where silence said more, let silence remain.



The next morning Mrinalini's health suddenly deteriorated badly.

The nurse called Ishaan.

Instructions from the doctor over the phone.

Preparations for an ambulance.

Mrinalini opened her eyes.

"Hospital?"

Ishaan said—

"Yes."

She shook her head very slowly.

"Not this time."

Ishaan went still.

"Mother, your breathing—"

"The doctor?"

The nurse said—

“It would be better to take you to the hospital.”

Mrinalini caught Ishaan’s hand.

“Will you make the decision?”

The question was clear.

Inside Ishaan, fear was screaming.

The eighth line stood before him—

The watch must not devour the freedom of the one it seeks to protect.

He spoke to the physician again.

Comfort-focused care at home was possible, but the risk was high.

Mrinalini was conscious.

Capable of making the decision.

She said—

“Home.”

Ishaan closed his eyes.

“All right.”

This decision was not heroism.

Not a wish for death.

Autonomy.

Age.

Exhaustion.

Home.

Many end-of-life decisions are harder than a criminal investigation—
because here there is not only one “right” answer.



The day moved slowly.

Oxygen.

Medicine.

Sometimes sleep.

Sometimes wakefulness.

Once Mrinalini looked at Satyaprakash’s photograph.

“You made me wait a very long time.”

Ishaan heard her.

Said nothing.

Another time she touched Dhaneshwari’s notebook.

“No more lines.”

Ishaan smiled.

“All right.”

Vaidehi came in the evening.

Trisha on the phone.
 A message from Rachna.
 Pradeep sent his respects from afar.
 Sabina sent flowers—Mrinalini had forbidden them, but they came anyway.
 The house was not crowded.
 Quiet.
 That night Mrinalini asked Ishaan—
 “Have you eaten?”
 Laughing and crying at once, Ishaan said—
 “Yes.”
 “Lie?”
 “A little.”
 “Eat.”
 It sounded like a final command.
 But it was an ordinary command of life.
 Ishaan went to the kitchen.
 Ate two mouthfuls.
 Returned.
 Mrinalini was asleep.



Mrinalini died a little before dawn.
 No final speech.
 No unveiling of a secret.
 No criminal's name.
 Her breaths gradually grew sparse.
 Then stopped.
 Ishaan kept holding her hand.
 The nurse wrote down the time.
 A number on a clock.
 The official form of life's ending.
 Ishaan did not look at the clock.
 Outside, there was the faintest light.
 Something rustled in the bushes.
 He did not get up to see.
 Not every sign needs to be given meaning.
 He remained seated beside his mother.
 Son first.
 Writer later.



The funeral was simple.

As Mrinalini would have wanted—no speeches, no politicians, no media.

The village.

Family.

A few friends.

Vaidehi.

Trisha.

Pradeep did not come; he thought it better to remain away.

Rachna came, silent.

Vihan sent flowers; Ishaan made no public display of them.

Dhaneshwari's notebook remained in the house.

Satyaprakash's photograph remained on the wall.

No new photograph of Mrinalini was put up.

Ishaan was not ready yet.

No one pressed him.

Grief, too, has a right to freedom.



After the thirteenth day, Ishaan sat alone on the veranda for the first time.

The chair was empty.

His mother's spectacles.

Medicines.

A half-read book.

For a long time he did nothing.

Laptop closed.

Manuscript closed.

No work.

In the evening a mongoose crossed the courtyard.

Ishaan watched it.

No metaphor came to his mind.

Only a mongoose.

It went away.

Ishaan's eyes filled.

But he smiled too.

Mother had been right—

Do not write everything.



Several weeks later he opened Dhaneshwari's notebook.

Eight lines.
 The ninth blank.
 He lifted the pen.
 Then put it down.
 Mother had said—
 “No more lines.”

Had that been a final instruction, or only the weariness of that day—how could he know?

Ishaan did not infer.
 He left the blank line blank.
 Leave the unestablished unestablished.
 Leave silence to silence.
 He closed the notebook.



After Mrinalini’s death, Rachna Sinha sent Ishaan a short letter.

On paper.
 Not by phone.
 “Her testimony taught me a great deal. Especially this: admitting the limits of memory is not a weakness.”

That was all.
 Ishaan did not put the letter into the manuscript.
 He kept it among his mother’s private papers.
 Some sources are not for turning into story.
 They are for remaining as memory.



Trisha came to Garh Narikel.
 She looked at the notebook.
 “Ninth line?”
 “No.”
 “Why?”
 Ishaan said—
 “Mother said—no more.”
 “Maybe she was joking?”
 “Maybe.”
 Trisha fell silent.
 Then smiled.
 “Then that’s right.”
 They both laughed.

No decision on a “maybe.”
The household rule remained in force.



Ishaan reopened the manuscript.
The page on Mrinalini’s death lay before him.
In the first draft he had written a great deal.
Last words.
Mongoose.
Dawn.
Satyaprakash.
The notebook.
He cut half of it.
Kept only this much—
“Before dawn, Mrinalini died. Ishaan kept holding her hand.”
The rest, silence.
He read it.
Hard.
Right.
Perhaps.
The writer made a decision.
The son cried.
Both in one body.



Months later he went to the bank of the Kamla-Balan.
The water was ordinary.
A fisherman.
Children.
A monitor lizard far away.
No mongoose.
He sat on the bank.
His mother’s words came back—
“Do not end the story after me.”
He got up.
Turned toward the village.
The school was open.
The sewing machine was running.
Customers at the mobile-repair shop.
Trisha was studying law.

Rachna was investigating.
 Shailesh was teaching a class.
 Manjari was seeing patients.
 Pradeep was conducting training.
 Vihan was struggling with the institution.
 Saurabh was carrying his history.
 Keshav was asking questions inside his sentence.
 Life truly had not ended after Mother.
 Ishaan understood—
 Now the story could move close to its ending.
 Because the watch had passed beyond one person.



The first year after Mrinalini's death became not seasons for Ishaan, but distances.

The monsoon came.
 The Kamla-Balan filled.
 Paddy was planted.
 The school opened.
 Dussehra passed.
 Winter came.
 With every changing season he heard a sentence—
 "Mother would say this now..."
 At first he completed the sentence.
 Later he began to stop himself.
 To keep making a dead person speak new sentences is not memory.
 Often the living place their own thoughts in the mouths of the dead.
 Ishaan wanted to guard against that injustice too.
 What Mrinalini had actually said was one thing.
 What he imagined she might say was another.
 The same rule again.



One day someone proposed placing Dhaneshwari's notebook in a glass case in the school library.

Ishaan refused.
 "Why?"
 the headmaster asked.
 "It will stop being used."
 "Keep the original safe?"

“Make a copy. Let the original remain at home.”

“History.”

“History is not only the act of sealing an object away.”

Copies of the eight lines were already in the school.

The original notebook stayed at home—to be opened, touched, read, and left in the sun.

Paper too can be a living tradition.

Museums preserve many things.

They also kill some.



Trisha completed law school and became an advocate.

Her first year brought no great cases.

Bail.

Documents.

Family disputes.

Small cyber complaints.

One day the legal-aid cell gave her a case—

A rural elderly woman whose Jan-Dhan account had suddenly been frozen because of numerous suspicious transactions.

The woman said—

“Apart from my bank passbook, I understand nothing.”

The police’s preliminary record said—

The account had been used in an organized payment network.

Trisha did not call her father.

She wanted to do her own work.

First, the bank records.

Then the old woman’s statement.

Then the branch’s account-opening records.

It emerged—

The woman’s grandson, while looking for work in the city, had allowed the account details to be used for a “job.”

The old woman knew nothing.

Even after becoming suspicious, the grandson kept taking commission.

One family.

Two different liabilities.

Trisha told the court—

“The person in whose name the account stands and the person actually making the decisions may be different people.”

The judge asked—

“And the grandson?”

“His role requires a separate investigation.”

An order was made for limited release of the old woman’s legitimate pension.

The investigation into the grandson continued.

Trisha came outside.

She remembered her father.

Law had travelled from books into life.



That night she called Pradeep.

“There was a case.”

She told him everything.

Pradeep was silent.

Then he said—

“Why didn’t you ask me?”

“Because I am the lawyer.”

Pradeep laughed.

“Right.”

“But one thing.”

“What?”

“The person whose name is on an account is not always the person moving the money.”

“Yes.”

“I had read that even before your case. But now I understand it.”

Pradeep took a long breath.

“Sometimes knowledge gets a body late.”

Trisha said—

“That’s a heavy sentence.”

“I learned to say simple heavy things by living with your mother.”

“Mother?”

“She says heavy things simply.”

They both laughed.

Inside the family, the shadow of crime was now one part of the conversation, not the whole house.



After reaching a senior post, Rachna Sinha did less investigation herself and more training.

One day a young officer brought her a file.

“Ma’am, it is a small account. Only seven thousand in unusual flow. There is no point linking it to a big case.”

Rachna looked at the page.

A rural seed shop.

Seven thousand.

Then two days later, a payment intermediary in another state.

Rachna asked—

“Why is it unusual?”

“It does not match the shop’s business.”

“Goods?”

“No.”

“Account holder?”

“Says a relative asked for help.”

“Relative?”

“In the city.”

Rachna returned the file.

“Do not drop it because it is small. Do not turn it into a crime because it is large either. Verify.”

Three days later it emerged—

This was a small initial account in a new fraud network.

The total loss was still limited.

The account was stopped quickly.

Five potential victims were spared.

The young officer said—

“Seven thousand.”

Rachna smiled.

“The first footprint of a very large step is often small.”

She immediately added—

“But not every small footprint belongs to a monitor lizard.”

The young officer laughed.

“Where did that metaphor come from?”

Rachna said—

“Heard it somewhere.”



Ishaan later received public training data about that case.

He saw—

One small rural account.

One modest anomaly.

A question asked in time.

The network stopped before it became large.
 For the first time since Mrinalini's death, he felt a deep satisfaction.
 No "emperor" had been caught.
 No press conference about crores.
 Five families might never even know that they had been saved from something.
 When the watch succeeds, the event never happens.
 What never happened gets no memorial.
 Yet it has value.



The empty corner in Ambar's training room was never filled.
 Employees changed.
 A new manager came.
 One day he asked—
 "Why is this wall empty?"
 Vihan said—
 "What we do not yet see."
 "Should we write something?"
 "No."
 "The design looks unfinished."
 "Let it."
 Institutions often want completeness.
 Empty space is uncomfortable.
 But that very emptiness was a guard against arrogance.
 Vihan spoke less now.
 His work lay more in process.
 Every warning that came in was recorded.
 Every unclear risk was discussed.
 Every signal of user harm was reviewed separately from the growth team.
 The system was not perfect.
 Sometimes it failed.
 But there was one difference—
 There was less of a culture of hiding mistakes.



When Keshav completed his sentence and came out, there was almost no media.
 He reached home and met no one for the first week.
 Then one day he sent Ishaan an email.

"I would like to meet. If you do not wish to, no reply is necessary."

Ishaan did not answer for three days.

Then wrote—

"A public place."

They met in an ordinary café.

Keshav had grown very thin.

"I came to ask forgiveness," he said.

Ishaan answered directly—

"From whom?"

Keshav fell silent.

"Me? Abhishek? Sabina? Manjari? Employees? Gamblers? Banks? Society?"

Keshav lowered his eyes.

"That is why the sentence is difficult."

"Then don't simplify it."

A long silence.

Keshav said—

"I protected a system that was hurting people because the numbers looked good."

"Did you know?"

"Some of it. Some of it I did not want to know."

Ishaan looked at him.

"That distinction matters."

"I understood it in prison."

"Late."

"Yes."

"Forgiveness?"

Ishaan was silent.

"I am not in a position to give it. There are many people."

Keshav nodded.

"All right."

He began to rise.

Ishaan said—

"One thing."

Keshav stopped.

"If you ever speak about this—do not turn yourself into a 'redeemed hero.'"

Keshav gave a faint smile.

"Would Mrinalini-ji have said that?"

Ishaan's face hardened.

"Do not put words in my mother's mouth."

Keshav immediately—
 “I’m sorry.”
 They parted.
 As Ishaan stepped outside, he understood—
 The boundaries of grief, too, need protection.



Saurabh never fully returned to public life.

He donated his private records to a university centre for governance studies—within the limits permitted by law, with sensitive personal information removed.

The condition—
 The archive would preserve not only success, but controversy as well.
 A researcher asked—
 “Are you trying to repair your image?”
 Saurabh said—
 “Possibly. That is why you should trust the records, not my motive.”
 The researcher fell silent at the answer.
 A person cannot be an impartial witness to his own purpose.
 Paper is not complete either.
 But comparison is possible.



One day, returning home after a training class, Pradeep found that Trisha had brought the eight lines from Dhaneshwari’s notebook in a frame.

“Shall we put it on the wall?”
 Pradeep asked—
 “With whose permission?”
 “Ishaan Uncle’s.”
 “Mrinalini-ji’s?”
 Trisha fell silent.
 “While she was alive, she had permitted them to circulate without a name. Ishaan Uncle told me.”
 Pradeep nodded.
 The frame went up.
 He read the eighth line—
 “The watch must not consume the freedom of the one it seeks to protect.”
 He looked toward his wife.

Years earlier, after coming out of prison, he had wanted to control every detail of the family—to make trust return quickly.

His wife had stopped him.

Now he understood—

Protection, reform, love—all three can become control.

The frame was not only about criminal investigation.

It was about the home as well.



The student of Shailesh who had been caught playing a gambling-like game passed his school examination a year later and was leaving for the city to study.

Before going, he came to see Shailesh.

“Sir, I changed my phone.”

“Why?”

“Blocked all the old groups.”

“Good.”

“Sometimes I still feel like playing.”

Shailesh said—

“A desire is not a crime.”

The student looked startled.

“Then?”

“Watch what you do after the desire comes.”

“Sir, do you still—?”

Shailesh smiled faintly.

“Yes.”

Each knew the other’s weakness.

There was a little less shame there.

The watch was shared.



Outside Sabina Khatoon’s shop, a government poster appeared—

“Beware of mule accounts.”

The poster was full of difficult words.

Underneath it, Sabina wrote by hand—

“Do not rent out your bank account.”

People read the line below.

They read the one above less often.

Language, too, is a form of watchfulness.

It is not enough to assume that a warning has been given to someone who cannot understand it.

Ishaan saw a photograph—someone had sent it to him.

He asked permission to use it in training.

Sabina said—

“No name.”

The same thing again.

The journey of anonymous experience.



Vaidehi Jha’s research was published as a book.

Mrinalini’s name appeared only in the acknowledgements.

On one page there was an anonymous quotation—

“Grief is not satisfied.”

Ishaan held the book in his hands.

He read the line and closed it.

His eyes filled.

His mother’s voice felt different in printed letters.

Lesser.

Colder.

But enduring.

Paper cannot carry the whole weight.

But it can preserve a little of it.



While writing the final section of his manuscript, Ishaan became stuck on one question—

Should he write about the lives of the guilty after the verdict?

Should the story end with judgment?

His mother had said—

Do not end the story after me.

He wrote—

“Punishment is not the final scene.”

Then came short fragments of the characters’ later lives.

Some changed.

Some only partly.

Some changed only their language.

Some carried their stain.

Some were never forgiven.

Some never asked to be.

The story refused to grant salvation to every character.
So did life.



One evening Ishaan saw Dhaneshwari's notebook, Aniruddh's pen, and Mrinalini's spectacles on the same table.

Objects from three generations.

He thought of taking a photograph.

Then he did.

Then immediately understood—this was a private photograph.

Not for publication.

Not for the manuscript.

He placed it in a separate folder—

“Home.”

That was all.

The right name for many things is not “source.”

It is “home.”



Rachna Sinha was nearing retirement.

In her final training batch, an officer asked—

“Ma’am, after thirty years, what is the most important rule?”

Rachna said—

“Before making an arrest?”

“Yes.”

“Ask yourself—if the opposite of what I believe were true, what facts would I expect to see?”

The class fell silent.

“Meaning?”

“Look for evidence that contradicts your own hypothesis.”

“Wouldn’t that help the criminal?”

“It helps the truth.”

“And if there is very little time?”

“Write down the risk of error. Do not hide it.”

A student asked—

“Are you ever completely certain?”

Rachna smiled.

“I’m close to retirement. Still not.”

The class laughed.

So did she.



There was no grand ceremony on her retirement day.

A small gathering at the office.

Rohit was now senior himself.

He gave Rachna a frame.

The eight anonymous lines.

Rachna looked at it.

“There is no one’s name on this.”

“I know.”

“Good, then.”

She took the frame home.

Not beside the certificates on the wall.

Into her study.

Where young officers sometimes came for advice.

Retirement did not end the watch.

It ended only the authority.

Experience remained.



Ishaan did not conduct a final formal interview with Rachna.

He could have gathered a great deal of material for the novel.

But one day over tea he asked only—

“What does an investigator learn in the end?”

Rachna said—

“Nothing.”

Ishaan laughed.

“Really?”

“Every case makes you a student again.”

“Then what is experience?”

“You recognise sooner where you may be wrong.”

Ishaan did not take out his notebook.

He kept it in memory.

If he forgot, that was all right.

Not every good sentence needs to be preserved.



A new paved path was built along the Kamla-Balan.

People walked there in the morning.

Children rode bicycles.

Old people sat in the sun.

At first Ishaan felt a little sadness—
Less of the old mud, the footprints, the grass.
Then he understood—
The bank was not there only for the story.
It was there for people's lives.

One day, on a small patch of earth beside the paved path, he saw
mongoose tracks.

Even after all the changes, some paths remained.
Whether a monitor lizard still lived in the water, he did not look.
The need to look had diminished.



That night Ishaan began writing the opening of the manuscript's final pages.

He knew what kind of final scene he wanted—

No celebration of victory.

No dead monitor lizard.

No end of crime.

No triumph of the police.

The bank.

The mongoose.

The snake.

The water.

But he did not write it yet.

Because the final use of a symbol should not be cheap.

First he had to remove every unnecessary echo from the story.

He reread the old pages.

Where there was too much mongoose—he cut.

Where the monitor lizard had become only a slogan—he cut.

Where Nyāya philosophy had turned into a lesson—he dissolved it into
dialogue.

Where a character had become too clean—he restored the flaw.

Where a criminal had become too black—he restored ordinary
humanity.

Where a victim had become only a victim—he restored the person's
choices.

The story was taking its final shape.



At dawn he stepped out onto the veranda.

Mrinalini was gone.

Dhaneshwari was gone.
 Satyaprakash was gone.
 Aniruddh was gone.
 Yet the house was not empty.
 The kitchen.
 The notebook.
 Books.
 Files.
 Plants.
 The courtyard.
 The distant school bell.
 Ishaan closed the door and left for a training session in the city.
 No mongoose appeared on the road.
 He did not wait for one.
 The watch no longer depended on the appearance of an animal.
 Perhaps that was the story's final direction.



A year later, Ishaan's novel was almost complete.

Almost.

The word troubled him.

Because the moment he said "complete," the mind wanted every question answered.

But Satyaprakash's death had never been fully proved in all its particulars.

Devanshu's responsibility had been established only to a certain limit.

Haricharan was dead.

Ramavatar was dead.

Mrinalini was gone.

Aniruddh too.

The gambling network had been broken, but online betting had not ended.

New ways were devised to stop mule accounts, and the criminals found other routes.

Some people changed.

Some only became more careful.

Some continued carrying their stain.

No file in life is ever "complete."

On the title page Ishaan wrote—

"Completed Manuscript."

Then crossed out "Completed."

Leaving only—
“Manuscript.”



That week Rachna Sinha called.

Even after retirement, her voice was just as sharp.

“I’m sending you something.”

“A case?”

“Public training material.”

A small account.

Agricultural-assistance payments in a village.

The amount was very small.

Two unusual movements of money.

A young man had said, “Online work.”

The bank froze the account.

At first the local police assumed—a mule account.

The inquiry went further.

It turned out—

Not a mule account.

A family had mistakenly sent another relative’s legitimate money into this account.

Ishaan laughed as he read the file.

Rachna asked on the phone—

“What?”

“Nothing.”

“Understood?”

“Yes.”

“A small anomaly is not always a large monitor lizard.”

“Yes.”

“That is why I sent it.”

Ishaan looked out the window.

“Ma’am, you’re still a teacher.”

“Retired.”

“Those are not the same thing.”

Rachna laughed.

“Is your novel finished?”

“Almost.”

“‘Almost’ is the right word.”

The call ended.

Ishaan changed one line in the manuscript—

“A small sign may sometimes be the beginning of a network; sometimes it is only human error.”

Literature of fear is easy.

Literature of caution is harder.



Trisha was now practising law regularly.

One day outside court a reporter asked her—

“Why are you so careful with the word ‘knowingly’ in economic-crime cases?”

Trisha said—

“Because an account is not a person, and a person is not an account.”

The reporter tried to ask another question.

Trisha was in a hurry.

“Read the rest in the order.”

She walked away.

Pradeep later saw the video.

He called her.

“Well said.”

“Half of it in a three-second clip.”

“Even so.”

Trisha laughed.

“Babu, don’t trust a clip.”

Pradeep laughed too.

The wounds of the house could now sometimes bear a joke.

That too was the work of time.



Keshav declined an invitation to speak at a public rehabilitation programme.

The organiser asked—

“Why?”

“If people listen to me now, they will make the story too neat—crime, prison, change, redemption.”

“Would that be wrong?”

“Too neat.”

He sent a written note—

“My responsibility for what I did has not ended. I can say only this much: when numbers take the place of human faces, moral judgment grows weaker.”

The organiser read the note.

The same line was read from the stage.
With his name.
Keshav was not present.
Sometimes remorse also means choosing to stay away from the stage.



Saurabh's name gradually disappeared from the news.
Researchers began reading the archive he had donated.
One research paper said—
Uttarayan's early governance structure had created a culture in which
information was withheld between profit, reputation, and risk.
Saurabh read it.
Some lines seemed wrong to him.
Some harsh.
Some correct.
He thought of calling the author.
He did not.
Donating an archive also means conceding the right to criticism.
Wanting to regain control over memory can be another form of the old
disease.
He folded the paper and put it away.



In Ambar's new training room, an employee stuck a small note on the blank
wall—
“What are we not seeing today?”
Vihan saw it.
He did not remove it.
A few days later another employee wrote underneath—
“User complaints that look small in the data.”
A third—
“Rising late-night spending.”
A fourth—
“Unclear payment language from one partner.”
A new review followed.
This time there was no crime.
One partner's poor billing.
A product-design problem.
Some signs of user addiction.
Immediate corrections.

For the first time, the blank wall had proved useful without a crime having occurred.

The watch is not only for after crime.

It is also for before.



Ishaan had the house at Garh Narikel repaired one last time.

Then laughed at the word “last.”

Nothing in a house is ever final.

The roof.

The drains.

The walls.

Termites.

The kitchen.

One old wooden drawer would not open.

The carpenter said—

“Shall I break it?”

Ishaan said—

“Open it.”

There was nothing remarkable inside.

Old tax receipts.

Thread.

Satyaprakash’s broken pen.

Mrinalini’s wedding list.

An envelope.

Not Ishaan’s name.

Only—

“House papers.”

He opened it.

A small sheet in Dhaneshwari’s handwriting.

The letters trembled.

“To save a house is not merely to save its walls.”

Nothing after that.

Ishaan sat down.

No one had shown him this page before.

What did it mean?

Family?

Memory?

People?

Morality?

He could have inferred.
He did not.
He placed the page inside the notebook.
Not a ninth maxim.
An unfinished sentence.
Let it remain unfinished.



Ishaan's final revisions accelerated.
Now he shortened sentences.
Where action moved, philosophy did not stop it.
Where people ran, the author did not follow behind explaining the meaning.
Where the court asked questions, he trusted the reader.
Where Mrinalini wept, he did not count the tears.
Where the mongoose appeared, he did not explain the symbol afterward.
The language began to breathe.
The story became faster.
Fewer words.
More movement.
He reread the first page.
Night.
A sleeping child.
A cobra.
A mongoose.
He cut a few lines.
Now the scene moved.
A hiss.
A leap.
His mother's cry.
The child's sleep.
A faint drop of blood.
That was all.
The meaning belonged to the reader.
Ishaan smiled.
After a very long time, the opening scene finally felt right.



Trisha came to the village one weekend.

Ishaan did not show her the final draft, only a passage just before the ending.

She read quickly.

"The pace is good here."

"Mother used to say—do not explain too much."

"Right."

"And here?"

"This courtroom section is a little long."

"Cut it?"

"Cut what does not change the judgment."

Ishaan picked up his pen.

"You are a dangerous editor."

"Law."

They both laughed.

Trisha asked—

"Will you say what happened to every character at the end?"

"Some of them."

"Not a list."

"No."

"Good."

She closed the manuscript.

"The final scene?"

"I won't show it yet."

"Why?"

"Let me write it first."



That night Ishaan went alone to the river.

There was little moon.

The water was black.

The village lights were behind him.

There was less mud now because of the paved path.

Where the path ended, earth began.

There was movement there.

A mongoose.

Medium-sized.

It walked not on the path but along the edge of the grass.

Ishaan stopped.

A little distance away, a cobra emerged from the grass.

The mongoose stood still.

So did the snake.
Distance between them.
No leap.
No battle.
The cobra slowly changed direction.
It disappeared into the grass.
Ishaan let out his breath.
Then came a heavy sound in the water.
A monitor lizard surfaced.
Only the eyes, the line of its nose.
For a moment.
Whether the mongoose looked toward the river was hard to say.
The monitor lizard slowly sank.
Ripples spread.
The water turned black again.
Ishaan's hand moved automatically toward the phone in his pocket.
He stopped himself.
No photograph.
The scene was enough for the story.
And enough for life.



Back home, he wrote the final page.

The first draft was long.

He cut it.

Then cut it again.

At last—

“In the grass, the cobra changed direction. In the water, the monitor lizard surfaced for a moment and sank again. The mongoose did not leave the bank.”

Ishaan read it.

Paused.

Then added one line—

“The forms of crime will keep changing; may the habit of recognition endure as well.”

He looked at the line.

Too explicit.

He deleted it.

The final three sentences were enough.

The reader would understand.

And if not, the story had still done its work.



At dawn Ishaan opened Dhaneshwari's notebook.

Eight lines.

The unfinished page—

“To save a house is not merely to save its walls.”

He placed Aniruddh's pen beside it.

Mrinalini's spectacles nearby.

Satyaprakash's broken pen.

Four objects.

Four lives.

No one had given a complete answer.

No one owned the whole truth.

And yet the manuscript had come into being.

One last time, he read the title—

“MONGOOSE: AMONG THE MONITOR LIZARDS”

Below it—

“Nyāya Philosophy and a Modern Crime Saga”

He saved the file.

He did not immediately write “Final.”

Only the date in the filename.

Habit.



At noon, two schoolchildren came to return books.

The veranda of the house was open.

One child saw the sheet with the eight anonymous lines.

“Did you write this?”

Ishaan said—

“No.”

“Whose is it?”

“The house's.”

“Name?”

“Not necessary.”

The child read the fourth line—

“Before you call someone guilty, look first at what they did, not at their name.”

He asked—

“Is this for the police?”

Ishaan laughed.
“For everyone.”
“For me too?”
“For you too.”
The child thought about it.
Then picked up the book and left.
Perhaps that is the swiftest journey of knowledge.
One question.
One sentence.
Then the next person.



By evening a strong wind had risen over Garh Narikel.
Ripples crossed the water of the Kamla-Balan.
A farmer returning home.
A girl cycling back from school.
The distant sound of a hospital ambulance.
The red light of a mobile tower.
A notice for a new tender on the panchayat building.
The bank doors closing.
The last customer at Ritesh's shop.
Sabina covering her sewing machine.
Shailesh closing the attendance register.
Manjari preparing for the night shift.
Trisha reading the next day's case.
Rachna placing a book beside the eight lines in her study.
Pradeep gathering his training papers.
Vihan reading a new note on the blank wall.
Keshav writing a question on a sheet of paper.
Saurabh leaving the margin of an old record without comment.
Life moved in separate houses.
No single centre.
No single hero.
The watch was distributed.



Night again, and quiet by the river.
The cobra in the grass.
The monitor lizard beneath the water.
The mongoose on the bank.

Far away, the lamps in the houses were going out one by one.
The darkness deepened.
The watch did not end.



AN ORIGINAL MAITHILI NOVEL • ENGLISH EDITION

MONGOOSE

AMONG THE MONITOR LIZARDS

Justice, like the mongoose, waits low in the grass.

On the banks of the Kamala-Balan, a boy once watched a mongoose turn back a cobra at his own threshold. Years later, the river has a new predator: an embankment contract that quietly multiplies into culverts, ghost invoices and a widening trail of fraud. As Satyaprakash Karna's small construction firm is pulled into the current of easy money, the old lesson about the mongoose and the monitor lizard returns — not as folklore, but as method. Working the Nyāya categories of evidence and inference against the grain of a modern financial crime, this novel asks how a society tells a true witness from a false one — and what, in the end, keeping watch actually costs.

GAJENDRA THAKUR founded and edits Videha (www.videha.co.in), the first Maithili e-journal, and has translated this novel into English from his own original Maithili text.



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